

York

written by: Thomas E. Ferraro and Jon Stewart

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INT. INDIAN TENT-FIRESIDE-1832-NIGHT

The CAMERA shows a TIGHT SHOT of a campfire as reflected in the deep brown eyes of an elderly African-American man. This is OLD YORK. His gaze is soulful and reflective.

FADE TO:

FLASHBACK

EXT. KENTUCKY FARM-SUMMER-1782-MORNING

SUPERIMPOSE: KENTUCKY, 1782

AERIAL SHOT

The VIEW is of a large and rustic FARM and the deeply-wooded grounds of the surrounding area. There are several rolling fields of various crops, being worked by a group of AFRICAN-AMERICAN SLAVES. The MAIN HOUSE and numerous OUTBUILDINGS are constructed of logs, but they are expertly crafted and highly elaborate structures. The CAMERA pans across the hills and dense forest at the edge of the FARM to a CAMPSITE along a RIVER.

The CAMERA moves down a dirt trail to a bend in the river where 2 shirtless boys, one African-American 10 years old and stocky, and the other Caucasian, around 12 years old with flaming red hair, are sitting on a branch overhanging the river. This is YOUNG YORK and YOUNG CLARK, respectively. They wear only colonial-style boy's knickers, rolled up to their thighs. The CAMERA continues an AERIAL SHOT of the boys involved in the good-natured banter of two obvious friends.

OLD YORK (VO)

My name is York. I was born a slave round the year of our Lord, seventeen hundred and seventy three. My family and I were owned by Master John Clark of Virginia. I was willed by law and given to Master John's son, William who was nearly my same age.

(beat)

As far back as I can remember, William and I were together...I guess you could say we were glued together even before I can remember. (slight laugh) My mamma told me that as babies, she nursed us side by side. As we got older, I was always at William's side. Wherever he was, there I'd be, like a friendly shadow. I was a slave, but I became like William's brother and that was good enough for me 'cause he was the best friend a person could ever have.

EXT. TREE LIMB-RIVER-SAME

YOUNG CLARK

Let's have a wager. Um, bet you I can swim to that old log quicker than you.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

YOUNG YORK
(about to jump)
When you going to stop making bets you
can't win?

YOUNG YORK, an African American boy age 10, pushes YOUNG CLARK, a Caucasian boy of 11 years of age, with fiery red hair, backwards off the limb into the river. Young York jumps into the water and swims towards the log, easily winning the race.

Young Clark is now standing in waist deep water under the branch.

YOUNG CLARK
(yelling and furious)
Treachery! You were supposed to wait for
the signal, not push me off like a cheating
dog!

Young York is now resting at the log.

YOUNG YORK
(laughing and cocky)
Only thing I'm waitin' for is to see if
you'll ever stop flappin' your jaws and
swim to this ol' log.

Young Clark feverishly swims towards Young York, who is perched atop the old log like a proud conqueror. Young York stands with his chest puffed out and chin up; he affects exaggerated boredom while folding his arms and drumming his fingers on his biceps. As Young Clark reaches the log, he lunges at Young York, toppling him into the water. The two boys begin wrestling and laughing in the river while they furiously attempt to dunk each other.

YOUNG CLARK
(exhausted)
I'm hungry...lets go back.

YOUNG YORK
Now your talkin'! I'll race you there!

YOUNG CLARK
(laughing)
Nope...I see how you race.

Young York begins to laugh with Young Clark as they exit the water towards the river's edge.

CUT TO:

EXT. DIRT TRAIL-SUMMER-SAME-DUSK

The CAMERA shows the backs of the two boys, wet and still bare-chested, making their way down a narrow dirt trail. They are carrying their homespun shirts under their arms as they fall into a somewhat serious conversation.

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CONTINUED:

YOUNG CLARK
I think I am going to like it here in
Kentucky. How about you?

YOUNG YORK
(offhand)
Don't matter where we're in Virginia or
Kan'tuck, so long as I'm with you.

The two boys continue to walk silently down the road.

YOUNG YORK (CON'T)
(looking towards YOUNG CLARK)
Can I ask you somethin'?

YOUNG CLARK
(shrugging his shoulders)
Sure.

YOUNG CLARK POV

YOUNG YORK
You ever miss George?

YOUNG YORK POV

YOUNG CLARK
(looking straight ahead and
reflective)
Sure I miss him, (beat) but he'll be back.
Sometimes soldiers have to stay away from
home. But he's fighting Indians and before
that he fought the British and helped free
America from that crazy English King.

YOUNG CLARK POV

YOUNG YORK
(quizzical)
So how come *I ain't* free? I *am* an American,
ain't I?

YOUNG CLARK
(pauses, deep in thought)
I reckon I don't know... I mean you're a
Negro and you're a servant...

YOUNG YORK
(abruptly)
You mean a *slave*.

The boys stop walking. The word *slave* hangs in the air above
their heads like a black cloud.

YOUNG CLARK
(abrupt and defensive)
No, I *don't* mean a *slave*.
(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

YOUNG CLARK (cont'd)
 A slave can never be free, because his
 heart and soul belong to another man.
 Freedom is here.
 (points to YOUNG YORK'S heart)
 And here.
 (points to YOUNG YORK'S head)

YOUNG YORK
 But your family owns me.

YOUNG CLARK
 Ya...but no one owns our friendship. And
 someday I'm going to own you right and
 proper. And when that time comes, I promise
 you, I'll make you free!

YOUNG CLARK'S POV

YOUNG YORK
 (slightly afraid)
 I don't want to go nowheres 'cept where you
 are, Willy.

YOUNG YORK'S POV

YOUNG CLARK
 (wise beyond his years)
 Don't worry...we'll always be friends.

FADE TO:

EXT. UNDER A TREE-FIRESIDE-SAME-NIGHT

We see the two boys in close proximity of each other. They are eating a meal which consists of a roasted rabbit which Young York has prepared. Young York cuts two pieces of the spitted rabbit with his hunting knife, serving Young Clark first, and then himself. The two boys devour the meal in silence, pausing only to take turns sipping from a shared water jug. Young Clark's face is full of grease and he is shaking his head in disbelief.

YOUNG CLARK
 Where'd you learn to roast a rabbit so
 good?

YOUNG YORK
 'Member that blacksmith who died last
 season?

YOUNG CLARK
 Ol' Bartholomew?

YOUNG YORK
 Yeah. Well, sometimes after supper or when
 yous were at school, I'd go to the stables
 and just sit and watch him tend to the
 horses and stuff. He'd talk to me about all
 kinds of things...like when he was
 blacksmith for your brother George.

(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

YOUNG YORK (cont'd)
He taught me about huntin', soldiering,
cookin' and lots of stuff. Guessin he was
like a father to me...same way you're like
a brother to me.

After reflection an idea dawns on Young Clark.

YOUNG CLARK
I know a way we can be brothers for real.

YOUNG YORK'S POV

YOUNG CLARK (cont'd)
Do you trust me?

YOUNG CLARK'S POV

YOUNG YORK
(respectful)
'Course.

YOUNG CLARK
Then do what I do.

The CAMERA shows a TIGHT SHOT of Young Clark removing his knife from its sheath and cutting the palm of his own right hand. He pushes the blood to the surface. The CAMERA then shows a frightened Young York reluctantly cutting his right palm. The CAMERA shows Young Clark taking and firmly pressing their bleeding hands together. The two boys interlock their fingers in a highly personal and unique handshake that is demonstrative of their close friendship.

YOUNG CLARK
(solemnly)
This is what the wild Indians do...it means
that we're blood brothers. You got white
blood in you now, that means you're no
longer black.
(pauses, almost embarrassed)
It's our secret.

YOUNG YORK
Dat means our blood is mixed, right? Like
some of my blood runs in you too?

Young Clark quickly recoils his hand and looks at it.

YOUNG CLARK
(defensive)
Yeah...why?

YOUNG YORK
(mock resentment)
Then who you calling black?

Young Clark proceeds to tackle Young York. The 2 laughing boys commence pummeling each other and rolling around in the grass. Their camaraderie does nothing to diminish the severity of the beating they inflict on each other.

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CONTINUED: (2)

Both bloody and exhausted, they wind up face-to-face, while resting on their sides. Both wipe the blood from their mouths.

YOUNG YORK'S POV

YOUNG CLARK
(out of breath)
We were only supposed to mix the blood on
our *hands*!

YOUNG CLARK'S POV

YOUNG YORK
Well, I just wanted to make sure that the
magic took!

CUT TO:

EXT. UNDER A TREE-FIRESIDE-SAME-NIGHT

Young Clark helps Young York read from a battered, leather-bound copy of The Arabian Nights, which is prominently displayed to the CAMERA.

YOUNG YORK
(stumbling over the words)
Then he, a...alit..

YOUNG CLARK
Alighted.

YOUNG YORK
Alighted from his stallion and repaying...

YOUNG CLARK
Repairing.

YOUNG YORK
Repairing to his chamber, rubbed the lamp
and behold, the slave stood before him and
said, Ask, o my lord, whatso thou wantest;
And Aladdin rejoiced...no..rejoined, I
require thee of a service grave and
important which thou must do for me...

Young Clark smiles as he looks affectionately at Young York.
Young Clark starts to fall asleep as Young York's narration grows fainter and fainter.

FADE OUT:

FADE IN:

INT. REAR OF FARMHOUSE-THE NEXT DAY-LATE AFTERNOON

The CAMERA shows the boys coming home from their camping expedition. Both have crude bandages wrapped around their hands. The CAMERA now shows the boys' POV as they approach the back of the house and see a matronly, African-American woman in her 40s holding the screen door open. The boys share a guilty look as they quicken their pace. They know they are late and in trouble.

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As they near the house, MISS ROSA, York's mother and the Clark family maid, confronts them at the door of the kitchen.

MISS ROSA

(displeased)

My God how do two boys get so filthy? Do you know how late you both are? Seein' how you two seems to be joined at the hip, can't you use one of those two brains the Lawd gave you to knows when it's supper time?

(secretly smiling, with a look of fondness at their friendship as the boys pass her)

William, get yo'self washed up and go directly to the dinning room, your father is waiting.

(looking at YOUNG YORK sternly with her hand on his chin)

And you, my son, you wash up and git ready to serve the Clarks dey meal.

(motioning into the side hallway)

Go on, the both of you rascals, git going!

The boys stop briefly to glance at each other as they go their obvious separate ways. They look disappointed, but not entirely sad, as if they are both accustomed to this uncomfortable ritual.

CUT TO:

INT. FARMHOUSE-DINNING ROOM-SAME-DUSK

The CAMERA shows the CLARKS sitting down for supper. At the table are WILLIAM CLARK'S PARENTS and other BROTHERS and SISTERS. Young Clark rushes in on supper being served.

JOHN CLARK

(mock sternness)

You're late, sir!

(unfolds his napkin)

You've already missed our prayer, but we'll wait until you've given thanks on your own.

(motioning down to the floor)

On your knees son, (pauses) go on, on your knees and pray to the Lord.

YOUNG CLARK

(submissive)

Yes, father.

As Young Clark begrudgingly falls to his knees and prays silently, the CAMERA shows Young York in the hallway, putting a platter of beef down on the sideboard and covering his mouth in an effort to conceal his laughter. Young Clark sees Young York, laughing off camera, and gives him a scornful look. Young Clark finishes praying and takes his seat at the table.

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CONTINUED:

His face is bruised and cut as a result of his recent scuffles with Young York. Young Clark has dressed for supper hastily and attempts to fix his tie and re-button his coat while seated.

JOHN CLARK

William, how was your little excursion on the wild frontier?

YOUNG CLARK

(sheepish)

Fun.

CLARK'S MOTHER

(surprised)

Have you and York been fighting *again*?

YOUNG CLARK

Not fighting, mother, just playing and wrestling like wild Indians.

JOHN CLARK

(laughing)

Just wrestling, eh? Well, I suppose boys will be boys, good practice too for when you become a soldier like your brother George. But tell me this, (pauses; whispering conspiratorially) are you always the victor in these little skirmishes?

YOUNG CLARK

(boastfully)

Oh yes, father! I always beat him soundly!

Young Clark smirks sarcastically at Young York standing in the hallway. YOUNG YORK enters the room with a covered serving platter. He is able to throw a quick and painful rabbit-punch to Young Clark's arm without being seen. Setting the platter down on the table politely, Young York attempts a quick exit, but CLARK'S MOTHER notices his bandaged hand.

CLARK'S MOTHER

(concerned and reaching for

YOUNG YORK'S hand)

York, come here a minute.

(cooking at his hand, peeling
back the bandage)

Oh my gracious, what a nasty cut! How on earth did you get it?

YOUNG YORK

My knife slipped as I was whittling ma'am.

CLARK'S MOTHER

Since when does a right-handed boy whittle with his left hand?

YOUNG YORK

Sometimes I get tired of using my right-hand, ma'am, so I use my left.

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CONTINUED: (2)

CLARK'S MOTHER
(semi-convinced and not
without affection)
Well, you be sure to see me after supper so
I can put a fresh dressing on that for you,
and try to be more careful.

The CAMERA shows Young Clark witnessing the end of this exchange. He immediately hides his own bandaged hand under the table. Young York makes a second unsuccessful attempt to exit as JOHN CLARK notices his facial cuts and bruises.

JOHN CLARK
Master York, front and center please.

YOUNG YORK
(scared)
Yes sir?

JOHN CLARK
(examining YOUNG YORK'S face,
not unkindly, with his hand)
Looks like you've got some battle scars of
your own? Now that I have seen both of you,
I'd say it looks like our wild Indians are
in for a hot time when you two wolverines
hit the frontier. Tell me Master York, are
you going to follow young William into the
Army?

YOUNG YORK
(proud)
Yes sir!
(remembering his place)
As his servant, of course.
(looks at YOUNG CLARK)
I'll go anywhere Master Willy goes.

JOHN CLARK
Well that's right fine, young man, that's
right fine.

Young York and Young Clark exchange smiles across the table. The CAMERA shows a TIGHT SHOT of Young Clark's blue eyes followed by a TIGHT SHOT of Young York's brown eyes.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. MAUMEE RIVER VALLEY-RIDGE-1794-DAY-RAINY-DAMP

SUPERIMPOSE: AUGUST 4TH, 1794, THE NORTHWEST OHIO FRONTIER

The CAMERA shows a CLOSE-UP of an adult York's brown eyes. The CAMERA then shows a CLOSE-UP of an adult Clark's blue eyes. They are both robust men, but YORK is a muscular giant of a man. The CAMERA pans out to reveal a company of 50 SOLDIERS in their 20s and 30s, dressed as frontiersmen, huddled on a RIDGE, overlooking a RIVER VALLEY. The men are making an obvious attempt to conceal themselves. Some men are wearing military coats; some are wearing military trousers, but all are wearing fringed buckskins of some kind.

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These men are hand-picked sharpshooters and rangers, and Clark is their Lieutenant. Also with the group are 3 fierce looking, but allied MOHAWK INDIAN SCOUTS. All the men are heavily armed with flintlock pistols, muskets, tomahawks, and large hunting knives.

The CAMERA shows Clark, his Sergeant, and York huddled together on the edge of the plateau, overlooking the hostile Indian position, which is directly adjacent to a well-traveled dirt wagon trail. Clark is looking through his spyglass at the Indian position.

OLD YORK (VO)

I did indeed follow William to the frontier. We were serving under General Wayne, or as the men used to call him, "Mad Anthony". Our orders were to protect the settlers in the Ohio territory from hostile tribes of the Ottawa nation who had fought with the British during the War of Independence. The Indians were raiding farms, homes, and settlements up and down the Maumee River valley. William was now a Lieutenant in charge of a hand-picked company of scouts, rangers and sharpshooters, along with a handful of friendly Mohawk Indians. And, of course, I was by his side.

Clark and his Sergeant continue to spy the Indian position. The ground is dense and thick with high brush and covered with old, rotted timber. Tall grass and heavy brush hide even the smallest clearings.

SERGEANT

(nervous)

Do you think the savages are down there, Lieutenant? Between this blasted mist and that fallen timber, we wouldn't see Wayne's column if it was five feet in front of us.

Clark continues to look through his spyglass.

CLARK

(confident)

Oh, they're down there, Sergeant. The question is, exactly *where* are they? Now, if I was gonna lay an ambush, I'd be in that stand of trees off to the right. Or maybe in that fallen timber just off the trail. Major Price and his Kentucky boys have the advance today, by my recollection, and we should be seeing them anytime now.

SERGEANT

Do you want me to send a man back to the column to tell them that the trail is clear up to the fallen timber?

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CONTINUED: (2)

CLARK

Well, I agree with you that the trail is clear up to the fallen timber, but is the timber itself clear? From this vantage point, I say it's impossible to know for certain...the woods are just too thick.

(beat)

Something just doesn't feel right.

Clark looks down at the ground as he rubs the back of his neck, thinking.

CLARK (cont'd)

Ok, have a reliable man ready to make a run for the column. We'll sit tight for a few more minutes.

York is crouched on the line next to the SERGEANT and overhears their conversation.

YORK

William (stammers), I mean Lieutenant Clark, sir, I'm your man to find the column.

CLARK

(smiling and attentive)

You are, are you? Your place is here with me. Besides, some greenhorn sharpshooter might mistake you for an Ottawa in those buckskins. Then who would cook my breakfast in the morning?

YORK

(determined)

William, if the Ottawas are down there, you'll need every man up here on the ridge. I can track the column...and I can outrun any man here. Send me. Please.

CLARK

(convinced)

Alright...you'll go then.

The Sergeant is now looking through the spyglass. Several OTTAWA INDIANS are now seen moving out of the woods and taking positions of cover behind the fallen timber off the main trail. Several the Indians wade through the Maumee River and take positions behind the fallen timber covering a small isle. They are only 10 yards from the riverbank and the trail that runs along it.

SERGEANT

Lieutenant, it's an ambush! Look there (pointing)...they're coming out of the trees.

CLARK

We don't have a minute to spare.

(calling to York)

York!

(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

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CLARK (cont'd)

Backtrack along our trail until you find General Wayne and the rest of the Army.

(grabbing YORK'S arm and gesturing for emphasis with his other hand)

Tell the General we've located the Ottawas ahead of him at the rapids. Tell him that about fifty Indians, maybe more, are hidden in a cluster of fallen timber and are waiting in ambush. Tell him that they hold the isle in the middle of the river. Tell the General that Lieutenant Clark respectfully advises him to halt the command immediately and wait until he hears the sound of our guns as we attack the Indians from behind. When he hears our first volley, tell him to proceed quickly up the trail and engage the retreating Indians. Are there any questions?

YORK

No William, (flustered) I mean, no Lieutenant, sir.

CLARK

Very well then, get going.
(grabbing YORK'S arm emphatically)
And be careful.

York checks his weapons. He has in his belt a flintlock pistol, a large hunting knife, a tomahawk, and he carries a long-barrelled Kentucky rifle on a rawhide sling over his shoulder. He takes off at a quick pace and the CAMERA shows Lt. Clark and his Sergeant watching YORK disappear soundlessly into the forest.

SERGEANT

(still looking at YORK)
Sir, that was a lot of information for your boy to remember. Shouldn't we have written it down for him?

CLARK

(confidently, and turning towards the SERGEANT)
No need for that, Sergeant. York can recite entire passages of scripture from memory; he can remember my instructions.

SERGEANT

Yes sir. But shouldn't we at least send a couple of men back with him?

CLARK

No, I need every man present for our flanking attack, I trust him like I'd trust my own brother.

The Sergeant nods with a subtle look of astonishment at Clark's remarks.

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CONTINUED: (4)

CLARK (cont'd)

Now pass the word and get the men ready for a flanking attack. I want to attack them on the run. I want to drive them up the trail right into the General's position. Hopefully, he'll have an ambush of his own waiting for them.

CUT TO:

EXT. DEEP FOREST-SAME

The CAMERA shows York rushing through the forest. As he approaches a rather robust tree, an OTTAWA INDIAN, armed with a tomahawk, leaps into his path to intercept him. As York comes within striking distance, the Ottawa Indian swings his tomahawk at York's head with a shrieking war cry. York, bewildered, ducks, and reflexively tomahawks the Ottawa Indian in the stomach. The Indian grabs his mid-section and drops to the ground, mortally wounded. York has an anguished look on his face as he continues on.

CUT TO:

EXT. MAUMEE RIVER VALLEY-RIDGE-SAME

Starting with Clark, the word is passed along the line to prepare to move out and attack the Indians from behind. Just as the men are ready to move, the CAMERA shows the Sergeant looking through the spyglass. The SPYGLASS catches 2 AMERICAN SCOUTS, in their 20s, dressed similarly to Clark's men, appearing out of the tree-line and advancing cautiously towards the Indian position, oblivious to the ambush.

SERGEANT

Sir, (pointing down) that's Moore and Steele of Price's advance guard; they'll be cut to pieces!

Just then, the 50 visible Ottawa Indians fire an undisciplined but deadly volley of fire at the 2 advancing scouts, killing them in their tracks. 2 Ottawa Indians emerge and scalp both men and rob their corpses of their weapons and gear.

CLARK

Bastards.

Turning towards the men.

CLARK (cont'd)

Lets get some payback, boys.

CLARK'S MEN rise up and begin to run down the ridge while yelling their battle cries. However, the battle cries of Clark's men are simultaneously drowned out by the savage roar of 600 screaming Ottawa Indians, who suddenly emerge from all sides of the woods to join their 50 tribesmen who are now charging up the trail.

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CONTINUED:

More AMERICAN SOLDIERS have appeared at the tree-line and are routed by the Ottawa Indians. Many are killed and scalped and the remaining few retreat into the woods with the Ottawa Indian pursuing. Lt. Clark's Men halt abruptly and skid to a stop on the hillside, in awe of the overwhelming number of Ottawa Indian who, intent on their prey, have been completely oblivious to Lt. Clark's aborted charge. All stand silent and dazed.

CLARK (cont'd)

(clipped voice)

Sergeant...pass the word to retreat back to our original defensive position on the ridge.

SERGEANT

I hope for Mad Anthony's sake that York gets through. If those Ottawas catch him, he'll have a hard time reciting scripture with no tongue.

(to the men)

All right men...retreat back to the ridge.

Clark turns and looks with concern towards the dark forest where York entered on his mission.

CUT TO:

EXT. DARK FORREST-MID-MORNING-SAME-MIST

Running and nervous, York continues his search for Gen. Wayne's Army. As he approaches several large trees, he hears the massive fire of the Indian guns and it stops him in his tracks. He looks back along his path with fear in his eyes, and realizes that he is being silently pursued by 2 OTTAWA INDIANS. They each have a tomahawk in one hand and a war-club in the other. YORK turns to face them. Scared and highly agitated, he yells at them.

YORK

(flustered and fearful)

Get along you two! I don't want no trouble. Go on and git!

When the LEAD OTTAWA INDIAN is within 15 yards, York begins to yell wildly and runs toward his adversary. As they close to within striking distance the Lean Ottawa Indian is somewhat shocked by YORK'S unusually large size and black skin. YORK, seeing the hesitation in the Lead Ottawa Indian's eyes, raises his right arm at the last second and clotheslines his enemy. The Lead Ottawa Indian is knocked cold by York's brute strength.

York barely has time to compose himself before the SECOND OTTAWA INDIAN closes in on him. York raises his musket to block a savage overhand tomahawk blow and York kicks the Second Ottawa Indian down.

The Second Ottawa Indian then draws a large knife from his belt and regains his feet and charges blindly towards York with his knife. York draws his flintlock pistol and fires it into the Second Ottawa Indian's torso, killing him. York slowly approaches the body of the Second Ottawa Indian and kneels down next to it in a state of shock. He looks at the young, dark-skinned faced of the dead Second Ottawa Indian and stifles a sob.

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CONTINUED:

Hearing more GUNSHOTS from the woods behind him, York continues running through the forest and comes to a clearing where the main path skirts the trees. YORK looks to his left and spots the FLAGS of Wayne's Army about 200 yards away. Hearing the FIFES and DRUMS of the advancing American troops, YORK runs up the trail towards the men,

CUT TO:

EXT. DEEP FORREST-TRAIL-SAME

A veteran soldier, CORPORAL FINLEY, is in one of the front ranks of the advancing line of foot soldiers, and turns to speak to a mounted officer, LIEUTENANT SUDDETH.

CORPORAL FINLEY
Beggin' the Lieutenant's pardon sir, but
ain't that Lieutenant Clark's negro runnin'
towards us?

LT. SUDDETH
Why yes, Corporal Finley, I believe it is.

CORPORAL FINLEY
That boy's runnin' like a rabbit. Slave-
catchers must be after him!

A low chuckle runs through the ranks as Corporal Finley looks back at the men for approval. As Corporal turns back to check York's progress, he is hit by an Ottawa arrow in the middle of his neck dropping him instantly.

York is now being pursued by HUNDREDS of screaming Ottawa Indians. Lt. Suddeth's white horse is hit with several musket balls and begins to rear and plunge wildly. The troop begins to scatter, running for the safety of the woods as the Indians charge.

With a group of screaming Indians charging at him, Lt. Suddeth rams his spurs into his horse's sides...BLOOD gushes from the animal's wounds and its nose and mouth, but the crazed horse springs forward and runs for 150 yards before collapsing. Lt. Suddeth leaps from the saddle and runs into the woods in an attempt to rally his men. York runs through the retreating men as Lt. Suddeth calls out to him.

LT. SUDDETH
Find the General and warn him!

York runs up the trail, followed by a hoard of screaming Ottawa Indians. As York reaches the crest of a small hill with the Ottawa Indians in hot pursuit, he disappears from the CAMERA and the Indians' view. As the Ottawa Indians come to the crest of the hill, their POV is shown. They look onto an open field where the front two ranks of GEN. WAYNE'S ARMY fire a blistering volley at them, stopping them dead in their tracks. YORK emerges from a depression in the sloping ground and rushes up to GEN. WAYNE who is on horseback.

GEN. WAYNE
Where the devil did you come from?

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

YORK

General sir, it was an ambush! I heard heavy firing behind me...I think the advance guard scattered in the woods...that officer on the white horse is trying to rally them. Lieutenant Clark was going to attack them from behind, but there must have been too many for him. I need to get back to him.

GEN. WAYNE

(regards York's blood
spattered clothing)
You'd better stay with me for now. How many Indians are there?

YORK

More than I can count. Hundreds.

Gen. Wayne turns towards his ADJUTANT.

GEN. WAYNE

Form all companies into defensive square formations.

ADJUTANT

Yes, sir.
(to the company)
Men, form defensive squares!

General Wayne's men form defensive squares as the Indians mount another attack. The Ottawa Indians charge the defensive squares and are repelled by massive VOLLEY FIRING. As the Indians retreat as they are ambushed by the combined forces of Lt. Clark and Lt. Suddeth. Caught in the crossfire, the Ottawa Indians are forced to retreat.

CUT TO:

EXT. DEEP FORREST-CLEARING-SAME

Clark and Lt. Suddeth report to Gen. Wayne.

LT. SUDDETH

(indicating YORK)
General, if it weren't for this Negro here, we would have never seen them coming.

GEN. WAYNE

Good work, son, and maybe someday you'll have freedom as your reward.

YORK

Don't need no freedom, Gen'l, sir. I only want to stay with Lieutenant Clark here.

GEN. WAYNE

Well...bravery and loyalty, good qualities in a servant.

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CONTINUED:

CLARK
And friend too.

GEN. WAYNE
(caught off guard)
If you say so, Lieutenant.

Clark and York are now walking away and out of earshot of the troops.

YORK
(somber and reflective)
I had to kill two Indians back there,
William.

CLARK
You had a run in with the Ottawa?

YORK
Three of them.

CLARK
You didn't kill any men. You killed a pair
of savages who would have eaten your heart
for dinner and shared your liver for
dessert. There's a difference. There's no
shame in killing enemies in battle.

YORK
If dere's no shame in it, why do I feel so
bad?

CLARK
(dismissive)
Never mind that. There's no time for that
kind of talk. Besides, the fighting ain't
over yet.

YORK
If it's all the same to you, I'm hoping the
killing is over for me.

CLARK
(derisively)
Very well, then. If you can't stomach man's
work, you can stick to making my bed and
cooking my dinner.

York reels back as if he has been slapped. An injured look
crosses his face as he hangs his head. Clark, realizing that he
has hurt his friend's feelings, becomes conciliatory.

CLARK
You know I meant, don't you?

YORK
Meant what, William?

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

CLARK
That first and foremost, I regard you as my friend.

YORK
I know I'm your friend, but am I still your blood brother? Even though the killing don't sit well with me?

Clark instinctively looks down at his scarred palm.

LT. CLARK
Of course.

Clark shows his scar to York.

CLARK (cont'd)
How could I ever forget? We'll just leave the blood part of it to me from now on...

York smiles and the 2 men clasp their right palms together and entwine their fingers in their secret handshake. From 25 yards away, Gen. Wayne watches this unusual exchange between a black slave and a white officer. The general looks down and shakes his head skeptically, and then turns his horse and rides off CAMERA.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. KENTUCKY DIRT ROAD-SUMMER-DAY-1795

York is driving a wagon laden with baggage. Clark, in uniform, rides atop his white mare in front of the wagon. As they ride past a farm, a pretty young slave woman, SARAH, African-American, 20s, stops working in the field and runs towards the wagon.

SARAH
York...York!
(remembers her manners as
York reigns up)
Master Clark, excuse, me sir. I'm just so glad to see the both of you. The whole county is buzzing like a hive of bees about your coming home.

York blushes in the wagon, but is obviously enamored with this woman. Clark is enjoying his friends discomfort.

CLARK
Well, thank you, Sarah. It's good to have such a warm welcome home. The Indians weren't so gracious, but I'm sure York will tell you all about it. Won't you, York?

YORK
(embarrassed and slightly
stammering)
Uh, uh, um, yes... 'course I will after I unpack the wagon.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

CLARK

(amused)

Nonsense...you stay here and tell Miss Sarah all about your adventures. I'll ride along and make sure they save some vittles for you. Just make sure the team gets taken care of and my bags are unpacked.

York starts to protest but Clark cuts him off.

YORK

I...

CLARK (cont'd)

(cutting YORK off)

Good day to you, Miss Sarah.

(turns slowly to YORK and smiles)

York, I leave you in capable hands.

Clark rides off and YORK looks down and smiles at Sarah.

CUT TO:

EXT. PLANTATION FARM SUMMER-DAY-1795

The CAMERA shows that a slave wedding is taking place. It is attend by dozens of slaves and the CLARK family and Sarah's owner, MR. JOHNSON, a white male in his 50s. York and Sarah stand in front of an Itinerant Black PREACHER, 50s.

PREACHER

....and do you Sarah take this man, York, to be your lawfully wedded husband, to love and obey, in sickness and in health, til death or distance do you part?

SARAH

I do.

PREACHER

In the eyes of God Almighty and his Son, Our Lord, Jesus Christ, you are now husband and wife. York, you may kiss your bride.

The CAMERA shows York and Sarah kiss. Everyone applauds. The CAMERA then shows a bored Mr. Johnson turning towards Clark.

MR. JOHNSON

(dryly and under his breath)

Well, it looks like I'm going to have to postpone selling the farm and moving to Mississippi...at least until your boy gives my Sarah a couple of pickaninnies. With a little luck, they'll be big buck men like him. And I'll need all the strong field hands I can get in Natchez.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

CLARK
(dismissing him)
Have a heart, Johnson. Can't you see
they're in love?

MR. JOHNSON
(disinterested)
If you say so.

The CAMERA shows York and Sarah getting ready to "jump over the broomstick". This was a common practice in slave marriages, and was designed to show who would be the boss in the union. The CAMERA shows 2 FEMALE SLAVES holding a broomstick a foot off the ground.

PREACHER
All righty then...hold on, hold on.
Everybody gather round and pay close
attention. It's time for Master York and
Miss Sarah to jump over the broomstick.
York, Sarah, you both know the rules.
Whoever jumps over this here stick without
touching it wears the britches in the
family. If you both jump clear over the
stick without touching, or you both touch
the stick, that means no one's boss, and
you got to share the marriagin'
responsibilities. Sarah, you're first.

He looks knowingly at the 2 Female Slaves holding the broom.

PREACHER (cont'd)
Girls, you know what to do. On the count of
three...One, two, three!

Sarah jumps over the broomstick and clears it with ease. As if by a long standing custom, the 2 slave girls lower the broom to within an inch of the ground as Sarah jumps. EVERYONE laughs, pretending not to notice the exaggerated cheating; no one dares protest.

PREACHER (cont'd)
(mock seriousness)
Master York...approach the broomstick.
Girls, I must remind you, yours is a mighty
solemn duty...cheating will not be
tolerated!

The Preacher winks at the 2 slave girls.

PREACHER (cont'd)
Once again, on the count of three... One,
two, two and a smidgin'...three!

The 2 slave girls raise the broomstick as high as they can from their position. York pretends that he is going to jump over the broomstick from where he stands, but he suddenly takes 6 giant steps backwards, and, because of his large size and natural athleticism, easily clears the broomstick with a running start.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

PREACHER (cont'd)

(shocked)

Ahem! Well now, I think I saw Master York's coat touch the broomstick. (Points to the hem of YORK'S long coat) Right down here...yes, I'm sure of it. Sarah, I deliver him into your keeping! Keep this one on the straight and narrow path, 'cause Lord knows, this one's gonna need lookin' after.

Everyone claps and gathers around the happy couple. They break into song and make their way towards a huge festive table, piled high with food. Clark, forgotten, makes his way up the road towards home. His departure momentarily catches York's attention and York alone watches him leave. A quick flash of affection and sadness crosses York's face.

CUT TO:

EXT. MONTICELLO-JANUARY-1803-DAY

SUPERIMPOSE: JANUARY 18TH, 1803, MONTICELLO

Jefferson's home is an architectural marvel, but it is continually unfinished and under construction. ARTISANS and CRAFTSMEN are hammering, laying bricks, carving banisters and making other aesthetic changes to Monticello. SLAVES work in the fields. A horse-drawn carriage pulls up in front of the main house. Across the driveway, the CAMERA shows a beautiful YOUNG SLAVE WOMAN in her 20s; she is light-complected and well-dressed. She is picking flowers and carries herself in a refined manner. She is SALLY HEMMINGS, Jefferson's confidant and lover, but this remains undisclosed. She watches the carriage hastily pulls up and its passenger, a COURIER in his late teens, exits in a rush, quickly mounting the steps to the house.

CUT TO:

INT. MONTICELLO-HALLWAY-OUTSIDE JEFFERSON'S LIBRARY-SAME

The Courier approaches JEFFERSON'S AIDE, who is protecting THOMAS JEFFERSON from all distractions and disturbances as the President waits in the library.

JEFFERSON'S AIDE

(halting the COURIER by
extending his arms)

Whoa there, young fellow!

The Courier is carrying a letter with an embossed wax seal.

COURIER

(adamant)

But sir, you don't understand...I was summoned here by the President! (Pauses to catch his breath) I am the Congressional messenger!

CUT TO:

INT. JEFFERSON'S LIBRARY-SAME

The CAMERA pans across a library/laboratory filled with scientific instruments and 1000s of books. We finally see Thomas Jefferson at his desk, immersed in a letter he is writing.

THOMAS JEFFERSON (VO)
 January 18th, 1803. Confidential. Gentlemen of the Senate and House of Representatives: The Indian tribes residing within the limits of the United States have, for a considerable time, been growing more and more uneasy at the constant diminution of the territory they occupy. And the policy has long been gaining strength with them, of refusing absolutely all further sale, on any conditions; insomuch as it excites dangerous jealousies...two measures are deemed expedient: First, to encourage the Indians to abandon hunting, and apply to raising stock, to agriculture and domestic manufactures, thus proving to themselves that less land and laborers will better their lives than their former mode of living. Second,...to bring them together and prepare them ultimately to participate in the benefits of our government of these United States of America.

CUT TO:

INT. MONTICELLO-HALLWAY-OUTSIDE-JEFFERSON'S LIBRARY-SAME

Jefferson's Aide looks at his pocket watch nervously.

THOMAS JEFFERSON (VO)
 An intelligence officer with ten or twelve men...might explore the whole line, even to the Western ocean...The appropriations of two thousand five hundred dollars...would cover the undertaking. Thomas Jefferson.

CUT TO:

INT. MONTICELLO-HALLWAY-OUTSIDE JEFFERSON'S LIBRARY-SAME

The door to JEFFERSON'S library opens and Thomas Jefferson hands the letter to his Jefferson's Aide, who in turn hands it to the Courier. The Courier makes a hasty departure and Thomas Jefferson and his Jefferson's Aide watch him go.

THOMAS JEFFERSON
 (looking forward)
 I hope Congress realizes the importance of this expedition. We must explore and define the West.

(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

THOMAS JEFFERSON (cont'd)
I fear if we do not accomplish this goal,
Spain or Mexico might divide this country
forever.

DISSOLVE TO:

INT. OFFICE ROOM-A HOUSE-PHILADELPHIA-1803-DAY

SUPERIMPOSE: PHILADELPHIA

The CAMERA shows MERRIWEATHER LEWIS, a neat and trim man, 30 years old, opening a letter from Thomas Jefferson. He silently reads the dispatch while sitting at his desk and suddenly smiles. After digesting what he has read for a few moments, his initial happiness is replaced by nervous apprehension.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Mister Frazier...Mister Frazier! Can you
come in here, please?
(rises from his chair)

MR. FRAZIER, Lewis' secretary, a mild-mannered and business-like man in his 50s, enters the room.

MR. FRAZIER
(holding the doorknob as he
opens the door)
Yes, Mister Lewis?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(still looking at the letter)
The President requests that I lead an
expedition to explore the West...

MR. FRAZIER
Why, that is wonderful news sir!

Lt. Lewis slowly and pensively moves away from the desk while looking out the window. He is manic-depressive and suffers from intermittent losses of self-confidence.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(softly and unsure)
Yes...yes, it is good news at that, isn't
it?

MR. FRAZIER
(reassuring)
Why, of course it is, sir. The President is
offering you a most singular honor...most
singular, indeed.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Yes, a most extraordinary honor, but am I
capable of leading a group of men into the
unknown? God only knows what we might find
west of the Mississippi...I don't know what
to expect...

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

MR. FRAZIER
(praising)
Yes, that is true sir. But neither did
Columbus, Magellan or Cortez...

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(interrupting)
But those were men of great abilities and
sustenance.

Mr. Frazier calmly walks over to Merriweather Lewis and puts his hand on his shoulder in a respectful, but fatherly way. He is used to comforting Merriweather Lewis, but never grows tired of his role.

MR. FRAZIER
(reassuring and firm)
And so are you.

Relieved, Merriweather Lewis looks intently out of the window at the setting sun. The smile is back on his face.

CUT TO:

EXT. CLARK FAMILY FARM-1803-SUMMER-MORNING

SUPERIMPOSE: CLARKSVILLE, INDIANA TERRITORY, OPPOSITE LOUISVILLE, KENTUCKY

Clark and York are taking target practice on the edge of the Clark family farm. York is standing beside Clark and holding an extra rifle and powder horn. The CAMERA shows Sarah running towards the 2 men from the direction of the main house with a letter in her hand.

BANG goes the gun.

CLARK
Did you see that last shot, York? Almost
took that damn rabbit's head clean off.

YORK
Didn't see no rabbit. I saw some bark fly
off that old Oak tree...is that the rabbit
you mean?

Clark stares out into the field.

CLARK
He must have gotten himself into a hole,
but I hit him just the same. (notices
SARAH) Well now, here comes Sarah running
like the devil. I hope it isn't bad news...

The men turn to face the running Sarah.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

CLARK
Easy Sarah, easy. You act like you have a shovel full of hot coals under your apron! What's the matter?

YORK
(mumbling and affectionately)
She always looks like that.

SARAH
(out of breath)
I was visiting Miss Rosa up at the house when this letter came from town. Dey said to gives it to you right away. I begged Mrs. Clark to let me bring it to y'all.

She points towards York.

SARAH
(teasing)
And you better check yo' biscuits at supper. I'll show you hot coals...

Sarah walks off laughing to herself about YORK'S comment. Clark smirks at York and begins opening the letter.

LT. CLARK
Good to see that marriage hasn't made her lose her spark.

YORK
Spark? Some days she's a forest fire.

Sarah yells from the distance.

SARAH
I heard 'dat too!

Clark and York both smile as they watch Sarah make her way back to the house. Clark removes the letter from the envelope. He reads it to himself with growing interest and begins to smile.

CLARK
York...do remember Merriweather Lewis from Virginia?

YORK
Sure do. Served under you right before we left the Ohio Valley. Good manners, and if I can remember, he was a little high-strung.

CLARK
How do you mean?

York ponders this question.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

YORK

Well...let's just say Mister Lewis was a very particular man. Liked to have things done his own way.

CLARK

(laughing)

Well...I can't argue with that, and I am sure Merriweather would be happy to hear that you approve of his manners. As a matter of fact, you can pay him that compliment in person. It looks we're going on a little adventure with our old friend Merriweather.

YORK

An adventure...where?

CLARK

He doesn't say, just that we're going to explore West of the Mississippi.

YORK

West of the Mississippi!? I've heard they've got giant bears out there, and Woolly Mammoths, even!

CLARK

What's a Woolly Mammoth?

YORK

I don't know, but I sure don't want to be meeting one alone at night.

CLARK

Don't believe everything your mammy told you when you was a youngin'...you're a little old to still be believin' in old wive's tales. You're braver than that.

Clark starts walking back towards the house as he talks over his shoulder.

CLARK

The only thing I can guarantee is there surely won't be any shortage of Indians.

YORK

(looking at the ground)

Indians? Shucks, I don't take too kindly to them Indians. 'Specially ones I never laid eyes on before.

CLARK

And what do you think they'll say when they see the mighty York coming up the river?

YORK

I don't care what they say. It's what they'll do that I worry about.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (3)

CLARK

I wouldn't get yourself all in knots. The Indians have probably seen lots of different looking folks, just like you.

YORK

Yeah, I guess you're right. They probably have seen lots of men who are as tall and wide as me.

CLARK

That's not what I meant. I meant that...

Clark looks back to see York measuring the top of his head and admiring how high his hand is in the air. Clark smiles affectionately and resumes his walk towards the house.

CUT TO:

EXT. JOHNSON PLANTATION-SLAVE QUARTERS-SAME-NIGHT

York stands on the doorstep and Sarah stands in the doorway.

SARAH

(shocked)

Ex-ped-i-tion? What do you mean, a expedition?

YORK

I've got to go away for a spell, honey. Don't you worry; I'll be back.

SARAH

When? When will you come back?

YORK

I can't say exactly, but I know I'll be back. William always gets us home, safe and sound.

SARAH

But I'll miss you...

YORK

I'll miss you too...I miss you already. You've got to remember that I belong to William and William is a soldier. Seems like a soldier's duty is never done.

SARAH

But you're no soldier.

YORK

That's right, Sarah, I'm not....but I've got a duty too and my duty is to take care of William and makes sure he comes through in one piece. Funny thing is, even if I had a choice, and I don't, I'd still choose to go. (pauses) I guess you could say being with William is in my blood.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

SARAH
(crying)
A lot of good that does me. What about your
duty to me?

YORK
Sarah...you know that we can't change
things, so there's no use in cryin' about
them. Go and fetch your blankets
now...William is letting me sleep out
tonight.

CUT TO:

EXT. PLANTATION FARM-FIELD-SAME

York and Sarah spread their blankets over the ground and lay in
each other's arms. They stare up at a sky filled with stars.

SARAH
Do they have the same stars out West as
they have here?

YORK
Yeah...I think they do.

SARAH
Then you go ahead and go on your
expedition, but I want you to promise me
something...

YORK
Anything...

SARAH
Every time you look at those stars, I want
you to think of me...and I'll do the same.

YORK
I love you Sarah...and if I don't make it
back...

SARAH
(demanding, challenging)
You come back...no matter what...no matter
what!

York's facial expression is commandeered by Sarah's challenge.

FADE OUT:

FADE IN:

EXT. PHILADELPHIA-1803-PHILISOPHICAL SOCIETY-DAY

SUPERIMPOSE: PHILADELPHIA

The CAMERA shows a montage of Merriweather Lewis preparing for
the westward journey.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

Merriweather Lewis is at the Philadelphia Philosophical Society learning about all aspects of scientific discovery from the greatest NATURALISTS of the day. Merriweather Lewis learns astronomy, biology, botany, chemistry, and metallurgy.

CUT TO:

EXT. PHILADELPHIA-DR. RUSH'S LABORATORY-SAME

DR. RUSH is one of the leading medical doctors in colonial America. He is supplying Merriweather Lewis with the necessary medical supplies for the trip. In particular, Dr. Rush is giving Merriweather Lewis a generous supply of his own patented laxatives called "Rush's Thunderbolts".

DR. RUSH

Now Captain, this is a very mild laxative, to be taken for slight discomfort of the lower abdomen and bowels. An average man should take roughly two pills. Those slightly on the portly side...well, three or four should do. But do not fret over dosages; they are mild purgatives at best.

The CAMERA shows a CLOSE-UP on the red and yellow box that reads, "DR. RUSH'S THUNDERCLAPPERS".

CUT TO:

EXT. PHILADELPHIA-MAIN STREET-1803-DAY

Merriweather Lewis reaches in his vest pocket to remove a coin to pay for the National Intelligencer, a popular newspaper. A PAPER BOY, around 11 years old, stands on a crate at the street corner and holds a paper high in the air.

PAPER BOY

Read all about it, the King Napoleon sells Louisiana to President Jefferson!

LEWIS

I'll take one, lad.

PAPER BOY

Here you go, sir.

LEWIS

(handing the money to the
PAPER BOY)

Here you are, and it is not King Napoleon, it is the Emperor Napoleon. And he did not sell the land to President Jefferson personally; he sold it to the United States of America.

PAPER BOY

(ominously)
All I know is, my father says the land the President purchased is full of wild Indians and huge monsters.

*

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
 (taken aback, mumbling)
 Yes...we'll soon find out for sure, wont
 we?

Merriweather Lewis turns and walks away.

PAPER BOY
 (puzzled)
 Sir?

Merriweather Lewis reads the front headlines, pauses and looks into the distant sky with caution and uneasiness.

CUT TO:

EXT. WINTER CAMP-ALTON, IL-1803-DAY

SUPERIMPOSE: WINTER 1803, ALTON, ILLINOIS, CAMP WOOD ON THE MISSISSIPPI RIVER

There is snow on the ground. The CAMERA shows a montage of the newly-assembled the CREW as they settle into their winter quarters and prepare for the 2 year journey. The men's hot breath is visible in the cold air. Two log bunkhouses and two smaller log shacks comprise their makeshift "compound". The Crew break down, oil, clean and repair Kentucky long rifles. TAILORS sew, mend, and construct rugged buckskin clothing. WOODCUTTERS chop wood, and the COOKS cure beef for jerky. COBBLERS resole boots and COOPERS make barrels. HUNTERS bring in game. The SERGEANTS train some of the CORPS in close-order drill.

The Sergeants are: FIRST SERGEANT CHARLES FLOYD, 32 years of age, SERGEANT JOHN ORDWAY, 29 years of age, and SERGEANT NATE PRYOR, 21 years of age. Floyd and Ordway are tough, veteran soldiers. CAPT. LEWIS checks and rechecks the supplies and gear, mulling over every detail on his list.

York and Clark monitor the progress of the KEEL BOAT'S construction and its drunken BOAT MAKER'S antics. The CAMERA shows the CAPTAIN'S (Merriweather Lewis and William Clark) teaching the Crew how to identify different tribes of Indians by using color drawings of individual Native Americans.

OLD YORK (VO)
 We prepared all winter long for our journey west. The Captain's struggled to turn an undisciplined crew of trappers, mountain men and surly tradesmen into a trained company of soldiers. The Sergeants did their part, but the task was a long and difficult undertaking...

CUT TO:

EXT. TAVERN-ALTON, IL-1803-WINTER-NIGHT

3 CREW MEMBERS, rough-looking men in their 20s, stumble out of a dimly lit tavern.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

1 CREW MEMBER falls to the ground, flat on his face in the snow, while the other 2 CREW MEMBERS are bent over, laughing hysterically.

CUT TO:

INT. SHIPYARD WAREHOUSE-SAME

The CAMERA shows a CREW MEMBER, wearing some semblance of a blue, Continental Army uniform, in his late 30s, "guarding" the unfinished keel boat, rifle in hand, while sound asleep in a chair.

CUT TO:

INT. TAVERN-ALTON, IL-SAME

Inside another tavern, a CREW MEMBER, in his late 20s, attempts to seduce a dockside HARLOT while Merriweather Lewis, coincidentally outside, disgustedly looks through the small tavern window.

MERRIWAETHER LEWIS (VO)

December 6, 1803. Dear Mother, I have found my task of organizing a group of frontiersmen into a functional military unit far more difficult than I could have imagined. The men are prone to public intoxication, womanizing, and general disorder. I cannot for certain understand their behaviors only to assume that a man will turn to almost any vice when he's bored and restless. But our expedition and its success weighs heavily on my mind. I must turn the men into a disciplined military unit, no matter what price we have to pay. Pray for me and our journey. Your loving son, Merriweather.

CUT TO:

EXT. WINTER CAMP-ALTON, IL-1803-DAY

SNOW is falling. The CAMERA slowly pans down from the sky and shows thick, contrasting red drops of BLOOD on the snow. A CREW MEMBER, in his early 20s, is being flogged for some type of military transgression. He is shirtless and lashed to a post. The Entire Crew is standing in formation, witnessing the punishment. Blood mixes with melted snow on the Crew Member's back.

CUT TO:

EXT. WINTER CAMP-ALTON, IL-1803-DAY

The Entire Crew, with the exception of York and the Captains, line up in a gauntlet, brandishing the ramrods from their muskets. PRIVATE POTTS, 21 years old, shirtless, stands at the front, in between the lines of men, ready to endure his sentence. Merriweather Lewis holds open a military manual and addresses the crew; he stares the men down with icy malevolence, as if daring someone to challenge his authority.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
 (proclaiming to PVT. POTTS
 and to the CREW)
 For repeated drunkenness and sleeping on
 his post, Private John Potts is hereby
 sentenced to run the gauntlet (pauses for
 effect) four times.

Merriweather Lewis closes his book and nods to Pvt. Potts to
 commence his punishment run. Terrified, Pvt. Potts sprints
 through the path made by his peers. The Entire Crew swat and
 flail at the man's back. Pvt. Potts reaches the end and falls to
 the ground, exhausted and beaten bloody.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
 (coldly)
 Again.

Pvt. Potts struggles to his feet and, with a deep breath, once
 again hurls himself through the merciless path of his peers. He
 falls to the ground in agony.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)
 (without emotion)
 Again.

CUT TO:

EXT. WINTER CAMP-ALTON, IL-SPRING-1804-DAY

The Captains approach the Entire Crew assembled on the camp
 grounds. The Entire Crew stands at attention. Their appearance
 and bearing are noticeably more "military" than when they started
 training.

SGT. PRYOR
 Company...Stand at ease!

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
 We have been together for a little more
 than six months now. In that time, you have
 gone from being an unorganized rabble,
 whose behavior would make even the most
 recalcitrant sinner blush, to an actual
 military unit.

(beat)
 Now, the typical pioneer and frontiersman
 that I have come to know is a chronic
 drunkard who seems to spend his entire life
 in an undisciplined stupor. That type of
 man will destroy this expedition faster
 than anything you can imagine. The articles
 of war, which rule over our expedition,
 provide for the disciplining of enlisted
 men. As many of you know, I have not been
 shy in administering justice. I trust that
 those of you not previously acquainted with
 the military have come to know that
 discipline and rules are often the only
 thing that separates a successful military
 operation from one that fails miserably.

(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)
If you don't know it now, you will know it soon. Captain Clark and I are proud of the progress you have all made. Still, we will not tolerate anything less than a man's best efforts. It is my opinion that your previous experience in whatever field you have mastered will be no substitute for hard work. You will all be tested to the extreme.

(beat)
Your very lives are at stake men... and will be at stake, every day of this expedition. My one piece of advice to you is that you'd best remember that unpleasant bit of reality. That is all--Sergeant Floyd, dismiss the men.

SGT. FLOYD
Company...dis' missed!

CUT TO:

EXT.-MISSOURI RIVER-ST. CHARLES,MO-MAY 22ND 1804-MORNING

SUPERTITLE: MAY 22ND, 1804, SAINT CHARLES, MISSOURI

A crowd of 250 SPECTATORS CHEER as the keel boat maneuvers from the bank and sets off on the journey. The Captains and the Entire Crew are dressed in their military blue uniforms, wave from the keel boat deck. Merriweather Lewis' huge Newfoundland dog, SEAMAN, runs back and forth along the length of the deck, BARKING enthusiastically.

CLARK
(confidential and serious)
Lewis, I want to speak to you about something that's been troubling me. Do you think that the men should know that I did not get the commission of Captain for this journey? I feel awkward being called such, when in fact I am not.

Merriweather Lewis looks to see if any of the crew are listening. Satisfied that no one can hear them, he turns to his friend.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
I think it's imperative that the men believe that we were both commissioned Captains for this expedition. We must never let them think that either one of us outranks the other. It would undermine our authority, and we can't have that. If you and I stand together, the men will never question who commands. We must never let them see us divided. Agreed?

CLARK
Yes, agreed. Thank you, Lewis.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(smiling)
No need for thanks, Captain. Always know
that you are as much in charge as I.

The Captains smile and wave back at the shore a final time.
Merriweather Lewis turns and looks now to the distant horizon.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(to CAPT. CLARK)
All right, Captain Clark, shall we raise
the sail?

CLARK
Excellent idea, Captain Lewis!
(to the CREW)
All hands to stations for raising the sail!

SGT. FLOYD
Aye-aye, sir. Crew, man stations, prepare
to set sail!

The Crew, who have been manning the oars and setting poles now
tender rope lines and prepare to raise the large, single sail.
Merriweather Lewis paces anxiously up and down the main deck.

SGT. FLOYD (cont'd)
She's ready, sirs.

CLARK
Very well, then. Set the topsail!

The canvas sail drops down to its full extent. As the wind
catches the sail, the boat begins a slow, but steady wake through
the water. At first, the men help the boat along by rowing with
all of their might and pushing off the river bottom with the
setting poles, but soon, the sail is all that is needed. PVT.
CRUZATTE, a 1/2 French, 1/2 Omaha Indian boatman is manning the
rudder. Pvt. Cruzatte is in his early 30s. A patch covers his
missing left eye.

CLARK
(to PVT. CRUZATTE)
Private Cruzatte, steady as she goes.

The keel boat glides over the Mississippi River and disappears
into the blue horizon.

FADE TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-1804-DAY

The keel boat is moored in front of a rocky, jagged hill, about
300 feet high. Merriweather Lewis is atop the crag looking into
the distance with his spyglass. Clark is on the shore
administering Dr. Rush's Thunderbolts to PVT. RUBEN FIELDS and
PVT. JOSEPH FIELDS who are brothers; Ruben is 25 and Joseph is
21.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

CLARK

Now, Captain Lewis said that these here pills are a mild laxative of some sort. They'll make you feel better, but real gradual-like. Just give them a chance to work.

PVT. JOSEPH FIELDS

Sir, my belly's so sore, I'd let a mule kick me right square in the guts to push out my innards.

PVT. RUBEN FIELDS

Captain Lewis says we drink too much and that's why we get belly-aches. You reckon the Captain's right, sir?

CLARK

I don't know how you two even have stomachs left with all the spirits you drink. (gesturing towards RUBEN'S stomach) Maybe there's just a big old whiskey cask in there? What do you think about that?

The Fields Brothers look anxiously at Clark as they nervously take their Thunderclappers with water from a shared canteen.

CLARK (cont'd)

And that had better be water in that canteen!

The Fields Brothers look hangdog. They make their way down the riverbank towards where the rest of the men are relaxing. York packs up the medical kit while Clark laughs to himself.

CLARK (cont'd)

I should let them drink themselves to death...it'd serve 'em right. But they're good boys, and we could use more of their kind. What say we join Captain Lewis up on that lookout?

Clark and York make their way up the rocky incline.

CUT TO:

As York and Clark reach the summit, Merriweather Lewis is still surveying the horizon ahead. Clark reaches into his pouch and removes the map that he is in the process of creating. As York helps Clark unfold the map, Merriweather Lewis notices them for the first time. He is slightly startled by their presence.

CLARK

Didn't mean to sneak up on you, Lewis. Can you make out how far the next bend is?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

I can't be entirely sure, but by using those cottonwood trees as an approximate landmark, I'd say that the next bend is at least two miles away.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

CLARK
(pleased)
That was my guess too. We should get the boat up to the next bend and make camp. We are running against a hard current and I don't figure we'll get much farther than...

Suddenly, Merriweather Lewis loses his footing and begins to slip down the jagged hill. His knife sheath catches a clump of rocks and stops his descent. York helps him to his feet, shaken, but uninjured.

CLARK
It's a little early in the journey to be having life-threatening accidents, don't you think, Merriweather?

YORK
(pointing over towards the tree-line)
Captain, it looks like somebody else is having their own accident.

The Field Brothers are doing their best to run into the woods near the riverbank. They are bent over and alternately holding their stomachs and trying to loosen their pants.

CLARK
(musing)
Why, I believe Dr. Rush's Thunderclappers are aptly named.

York nervously looks down at the red and yellow box in the medical kit.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-1804-DAY

The keel boat approaches a bend in the river.

PVT. CRUZATTE
Sirs! Shallow water approaching!

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Nonsense, Private...these waters are at least twenty feet deep...thirty in some places. Steady as she goes.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-1804-DAY

The keel boat is laid up on a sand bar like a beached whale. The Crew is attempting to pull the boat into deeper water using tow ropes. Merriweather Lewis and Clark are looking over the side of the boat as the men, waist-deep in the river, tug on the ropes.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(to himself)
How can it be this shallow?

York is in the water with the rest of the Crew.

YORK
(quietly to SGT. FLOYD)
President sends us to explore the other
side of the world, and we can't even make
it out of our own backyard.

SGT. FLOYD
(exerting himself)
Ah, a little sand and a few miscalculations
ain't all that bad if they're the worst of
it. After all, there's nothing wrong with a
swim in the ole Missouri, 'cept maybe some
leeches and a crawdad or two.

YORK
Leeches?

SGT. FLOYD
Ya, leeches. You ain't afraid of those
slippery, bloodsucking critters are ya?

YORK
No...I jus' wanted to make sure that I knew
what's crawling down the back of your neck.
Right now, as a matter of fact.

SGT. FLOYD
My God!
(quickly swiping at his neck
and back)
They're Satan's own creations! Damn things
are all over me!

YORK
(imitating FLOYD'S voice)
What...you ain't afraid of a couple of
slippery, bloodsucking critters, are ya?

Sgt. Floyd, still freeing himself of the leeches, stares hard at York, and for a brief moment, his look is one of pure hostility. Realizing that York meant no disrespect and was only being friendly, Sgt. Floyd is able to laugh. York, relieved that he has not offended Sgt. Floyd, joins his new friend in laughing.

CUT TO:

INT. KEEL BOAT-MERRIWEATHER LEWIS' CABIN-SAME-NIGHT

Both CAPTAINS have retired to Merriweather Lewis' cabin.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
I looked foolish in front of the men this
morning, didn't I?

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

CLARK

I reckon we should have accounted for the lack of rain this past month...Easy mistake to make, my friend.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

(terse)

William, we cannot afford such mistakes in the future. The success of our mission depends on us taking into account every detail of our immediate environment.

CLARK

Merriweather...we cannot see everything coming.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

You are right, William. It's just that I so desperately want this expedition to be successful.

CLARK

My friend, we are the first white men to explore the West...no matter what occurs, if we make it back alive, our journey *will* be considered a success. You have to trust in what you know and who you are. Everything else will fall into place.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

(reassured, but not completely)

Thank you, William.

CLARK

Get some rest...tomorrow's a new day.

Clark leaves Merriweather Lewis lying on his bunk in the cabin. The CAMERA shows Merriweather Lewis from above; his facial expression is one of worry and self-doubt.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. CAMP-MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-1804-LATE AFTERNOON

The men stand in line holding their tin cups and plates. Sgt. Ordway is distributing rations of biscuits, honey and whiskey to the Crew. CORPORAL PATRICK GASS, a gruff, husky, 33 year old Irishman receives his rations from Sgt. Ordway. Sgt. Ordway carefully pours whiskey into Gass' cup. York is next in line.

CPL. GASS

(looking into his tin cup and muttering as he steps to the side)

Damned stingy...

SGT. ORDWAY

(asking YORK)

What did he say?

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

YORK
Looks like he don't think much of your portions.

SGT. ORDWAY
He doesn't, does he? Well, we'll fix that, wont we?

Sgt. Ordway serves York a double portion of whiskey as Gass observes this injustice. York sits by Gass to eat his meal. Gass is unaccustomed to being in such close proximity to a black man. York's presence makes him uncomfortable.

YORK
You want some of my whiskey?

CPL. GASS
(surprised and hesitant as he looks into his own empty cup)
Sure, why not? You don't have anything catching, do you?

YORK
(chuckling, and missing the insult)
Nah, I'm as healthy as a horse. See, I can do without whiskey ever' so often, but biscuits and honey, no siree. I'd fight the whole British army if they took a piece of biscuit from me.

Gass holds his cup out towards York, almost like a beggar. York pours all, not just some, of his whiskey into Gass' cup. Gass inspects the inside of his cup and smiles with satisfaction.

CPL. GASS
(matter-of-factly and without thinking)
Well, you certainly are a generous slave. Thankee, boy.

York is hurt by the remark, but tries not to show it. He gives Gass an embarrassed smile.

YORK
(taken aback and softly)
Well, I'm sure you're very welcome.

Pvt. Gass drains his cup as York watches. Their eyes meet momentarily, and Gass realizes that his comment was hurtful and insensitive. He says nothing and York looks away.

CUT TO:

EXT. CAMP-MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-SAME-NIGHT

The men gather by the fireside after supper to listen to Cruzatte play his fiddle. While the fire roars on and the men delight in the music, Clark notices York's rather distant demeanor.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

Clark looks at his servant again, but does not appear to be overly concerned about York's distracted state, passing it off as fatigue. Gass and Sgt. Floyd walk over towards the water barrel for a drink.

CPL. GASS

Tell me, Floyd, why isn't the Negro serving the men?

SGT. FLOYD

He ain't a servant on this trip. He's one of the crew.

CPL. GASS

(surprised)

One of the crew?

SGT. FLOYD

Yeah, one of the crew.

(taking a sip of water and
wiping his mouth)

Let me tell you about that man. He's been everywhere with Captain Clark. Fought in all kinds of wars with the Captain. Indians, English and Canadians...the man fought 'em all, and never got paid a cent. It's like once the battles was over, he jus' went back to being the Captain's slave. Christ, the man has better clothes and schooling than most of the crew.

CPL. GASS

He never said anything about the wars the whole time we was at the winter camp.

SGT. FLOYD

(taking a sip of water and
smiling)

Yeah, well, I guess it ain't his way to talk himself up...

(backhands GASS' arm and
hands him the ladle)

Be careful what you say to him...him and the Cap'n are like brothers...

Gass looks towards the ground as Sgt. Floyd walks away. Gass then looks reflectively towards the campfire at York and is somewhat remorseful of his earlier remarks.

CUT TO:

EXT. CAMP-THE MISSOURI RIVER-SAME-NIGHT

As the men sleep, York is still awake, lying on his side. York hears some commotion behind him and waits until the intruder walks away. York rolls over and feels something under his hip. York pulls a brown leather pouch from under him and unravels it to find 3 biscuits, drenched in honey. York looks up toward where Gass is bedding down for the night and catches Gass just as he is lying back down and pulling his blanket over himself.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-1804-DAY

The men can barely keep the MOSQUITOS out of their eyes, mouths, and ears while they row up the river. A constant hum is heard in the air. Cruzatte spots a FUR TRADER up the river. The BLACK SWARM is biblical in size and noise.

PVT. CRUZATTE
Pirogue ahead!

GEORGE DROUILLARD, a 35 year old, 1/2 French-Canadian, 1/2 Shawnee Indian hunter, trader and trapper makes his way down the river in a scaled down keel boat, loaded with bearskins. Drouillard is also hauling several barrels of "voyager's grease", an edible mosquito-repellent made of bear's lard. As the 2 vessels approach one another, Cruzatte calls out to his old friend.

PVT. CRUZATTE
(in jest.)
George, you slippery bastard, I see the Sioux haven't taken your scalp yet--you must be leaving their women alone!

The Captains move to the bow of their keel boat to get a better look at this newcomer.

DROUILLARD
Ahoy, Pierre. I see you've managed to keep one of your eyes...you must have stopped playing that blasted fiddle of yours in public places.

Drouillard makes eye contact with Merriweather Lewis dressed in his Army uniform and tricorn hat.

DROUILLARD (cont'd)
(softly to Cruszatte)
Who do we have here...Napoleon?

PVT. CRUZATTE
(to the CAPTAINS)
Sirs, this here is George Drouillard, the finest hunter and trapper west of Saint Louis. George, allow me to present Captains Merriweather Lewis and William Clark of the United States Army.

Drouillard and the Captains size each other up with appraising looks. They nod at each other in polite recognition.

DROUILLARD
(amused)
If this is an expedition to make the Lakota Sioux behave themselves, I hope the other 500 men in your party are coming up the river right behind you.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

(annoyed)

We are primarily concerned with scientific investigation and geographic exploration, not Indian wars. These lands now belong to the United States of America. You travel these waterways by the leave of the President. I suggest you remember that, sir.

DROUILLARD

(unfazed)

This may be United States territory on paper, but fancy talk about Presidents and scientific what-fors ain't gonna mean a barrel of crap to the real rulers of these lands.

(beat)

You're traveling at the mercy of the Lakota Sioux, and you had better get used to that fact. They've been watching you for days. You haven't been attacked because they're curious about you.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

(imperious)

Is that so?

CLARK

(interrupting and
conciliatory to DROUILLARD)

What Captain Lewis means to say, George, is that we come in peace. Now, how is it that you know they've been watching us?

DROUILLARD

Well, I trade with them from time to time. I have to pay them a heavy tribute in food and furs because I trade with their enemies, the Crows and the Mandans. They abide me most of the time, but sometimes they can be downright friendly, that's when they're the most dangerous.

CLARK

(interested)

I've heard of these Lakota Sioux. I've heard them called Tetons also. Fierce bunch, that's for certain. Do you speak their language?

DROUILLARD

I know a little bit of Lakota, Crow and Mandan too. Anything I can't say, I can usually make up for with the sign-talk. All the tribes seem to use the hand signs some.

CLARK

This may surprise you, but I've heard of you too.

(beat)

(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

CLARK (cont'd)
Cruzatte wasn't kidding about you being the best hunter and trapper in these parts, was he? We could use a man like you. What do you say about joining us?

Merriweather Lewis has taken a genuine interest in Drouillard because of the hunter's potential value as an interpreter. He watches the exchange between Clark and Drouillard with considerable expectancy.

DROUILLARD
(uncertain)
I don't think much of soldiering...

CLARK
Nevermind soldiering. We'd hire you as a civilian hunter and interpreter...

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(clinching the deal)
At say...twenty-five dollars a month? We could be out for three years. That's a tidy sum of money for doing what you do best.

DROUILLARD
(impressed)
I didn't realize the scientific business paid so well. But what about my cargo?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(without hesitation)
We'll buy all of the bearskins and voyager's grease for the expedition. Will that suffice?

DROUILLARD
Okay, Captains, you got yourselves a interpreter.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
And an interpreter...

CLARK
That voyager's grease is going to come in handy to fight off these mosquitoes...and maybe we'll get some sleep tonight without being eaten alive.
(beat)
This here is my servant, York. He'll help paddle your skiff upriver with you until we make camp.

DROUILLARD
Grateful to have the help. Good to know you, York.

YORK
Pleasure to meet you too, Mister George.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (3)

Some of the Crew help York down into Drouillard's small craft. Once aboard, York and Drouillard shake hands.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-1804-SAME

As the SUN sinks lower in the sky, the expedition makes its way west on the calm water. York and Drouillard follow the Smaller Crew in Drouilliard's small boat.

DROUILLARD
So, you're Captain Clark's servant? How much does that pay? Not twenty-five dollars a month, I reckon.

YORK
(embarrassed)
Nah, I don't take no money to serve William.

DROUILLARD
(not understanding)
No man works for nothing.

YORK
(patient)
You don't spend a lot of time back east, do you?

DROUILLARD
Just enough to sell my furs and resupply. Then it's back on the river. I never feel truly free unless I'm out here alone.

YORK
Truly free. That's what's most important, isn't it? (pauses, then speaks softly, almost to himself) I'm a slave, George. Captain Clark owns me. He takes good care of me, but there's no pay. Besides, you don't take money to be someone's friend.

DROUILLARD
(apologetic)
I know about slavery, but you don't look like the kind of man who allows himself to be owned by another.

YORK
I didn't have much of a choice in the matter.

Drouillard looks at his new friend thoughtfully. Before either man can say anything more, Sgt. Floyd calls back to them from the main keel boat:

SGT. FLOYD
Land ho!

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

Grateful that the awkward conversation is over, York and Drouillard paddle for shore.

FADE OUT:

FADE IN:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-JULY 4TH 1804-DAY

SUPERIMPOSE: JULY 4TH, 1804, UNCHARTED TERRITORY NEAR PRESENT-DAY NEBRASKA

The men fire the boat's CANNON in celebration of the 4th of July. The MOSQUITOES continue to be unbearable. The Crew is assembled at the bow of the keel boat to listen to Merriweather Lewis give a speech. Everyone is finding it hard to concentrate on anything but the incessant insect attacks.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(distracted as he brushes
mosquitoes from his face and
arms)
Men, today we celebrate the first Fourth of
July West of the Mississippi. In honor of
this momentous occasion, we will name the
tributary we passed today Independence
Stream.

The Crew reacts to this pronouncement with blank faces and stoic silence. The endless droning of the mosquitoes is the only background noise. Merriweather Lewis registers their reaction and makes a quick judgment call.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)
Also, each of you will receive an extra
ration of whiskey to help you make merry in
a more practical manner.

The men perk up slightly.

SGT. FLOYD
Three cheers for the Captain! Hip hip...

THE CORPS
Hooray!

SGT. FLOYD
Hip hip...

THE CORPS
Hooray!

SGT. FLOYD
Hip hip...

THE CORPS
Hooray!

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

Merriweather Lewis looks pleased to have won the confidence of the men, if only momentarily. Soon, the Crew is once again completely distracted by the plague of mosquitoes.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Sergeant Floyd, dismiss the men. Break open a barrel of bear's grease.

SGT. FLOYD

Yes sir. Company, dismissed!

(beat)

Corporal Warfington, Corporal Gass, bring a barrel to the main deck and stand by to dole it out to the company.

CPL. GASS & CPL. WARFINGTON

(in unison)

Aye aye, Sergeant!

SGT. FLOYD

All those wishing to partake in the bear's grease, form a line on the main deck.

The entire Crew sprints to the middle of the boat. York and Clark have anticipated this mad rush, and are already first in line. They stand with arms folded facing the onslaught of the rushing men. When the men catch sight of Clark, they stop in their tracks and resume their military bearing.

Gass and CPL. WARFINGTON have the barrel open and begin to dispense scoops of the grease with ladles. York smears the grease liberally over his exposed skin as Clark and the Crew watch skeptically.

YORK

(cheerful)

This stuff stinks!

CLARK

(disgusted)

You smell like a pile of horse shit!

YORK

Yeah but the mosquitoes sure seem to stay away now, don't they?

The men notice that there are no longer any mosquitoes tormenting York; they all begin to aggressively and enthusiastically coat themselves with the bear's grease.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-SAME-NIGHT

Caked with thick white grease, the men sleep deeply. Seaman continues to be menaced by the mosquitoes. He whimpers and howls while rolling in the dirt. Several of the men throw rocks and shoes at the dog. Seaman locates YORK and wakes him up by pawing and licking the sleeping man's face.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

YORK
(half-asleep)
What's the matter, boy? You like the taste
of that bear grease? It's gonna make you
sick if you keep gobbling it down like
that. Go on now and get some sleep.

Seaman continues his anguish as York tries to go back to sleep. The persistent dog gets York's attention again by burying his snout in YORK'S ear. Frustrated, York sits up in his bedroll. Now fully awake, York regards Seaman thoughtfully. He sees the cloud of mosquitoes teeming on the hapless Newfoundland. York nods his head in recognition as an idea suddenly dawns on him. HE looks over at the barrel of voyager's grease.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-SAME-NIGHT

The CAMERA pans along the sleeping Crew and finishes the SHOT by showing York sleeping peacefully next to Seaman, who is also sleeping. The dog is visibly covered from head to tail with a healthy portion of voyager's grease.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. KEEL BOAT DECK-1804-MORNING

The CAMERA shows PVT. WILLARD lying down alone on the deck of the moored keel boat. He is tall and slim, in his early 20s, with a muscular build. Willard's back is to the CAMERA as Sgt. Ordway approaches. Sgt. Ordway stops, surveys the situation, and turns on his heels. Sgt. Ordway disembarks from the keel boat to inform Merriweather Lewis of Willard's offense.

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-SAME

SGT. ORDWAY
Captain Lewis, sir...I boarded the ship a
few minutes ago to find Private Willard
asleep on the deck. He had the last watch
and was due to be relieved in an hour or
so.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Are you positive of this, Sergeant?

SGT. ORDWAY
Yes sir. I saw him lying down behind some
stores. His rifle was on the deck next to
him.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Very well. Where is he now?

SGT. ORDWAY
Still asleep on the deck, sir.

EXT. KEEL BOAT DECK-SAME

Merriweather Lewis and Sgt. Ordway board the boat and approach Willard, asleep on the deck.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(shouting)
Pvt. Willard, you will come to attention!

Willard hastily comes to his feet.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)
You sir, were assigned to watch this boat,
not sleep on its decks.

PVT. WILLARD
(scared and stammering)
Yessir. I unerstan' that, sir. But I was
not sleeping, sir.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Sergeant Ordway witnessed you lying on the
deck with his own two eyes.

PVT. WILLARD
Yes, sir, but I was awake.

Clark now comes aboard from shore.

CLARK
Captain Lewis, is there something wrong?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Yes, something is very wrong. This Private
does not take his duty seriously. The
Sergeant caught Willard here sleeping while
on sentry duty.

CLARK
Is this true, Private?

PVT. WILLARD
Not exactly, sir. It's true that I was
lyin' on the deck, but I was only resting.
I wasn't sleepin'...I swear.

CLARK
You realize, of course, that Captain Lewis
and I will have to convene a court martial
to decide your fate?

Willard shakes his head in acknowledgement.

CLARK
(looking towards shore)
Very well...Sergeant Ordway, assemble all
hands on deck.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(disgusted; to Willard)
You may answer the charges in front of the
men.

CUT TO:

EXT. KEEL BOAT DECK-SAME

Foreboding black STORM CLOUDS form in the sky overhead as the
Crew assembles on the deck of the keel boat to witness the court
martial of Willard. Willard stands at attention before the
Captains.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Private Alexander Willard, you are hereby
charged with lying down and sleeping on
your post. How do you plead?

PVT. WILLARD
Guilty of lyin' down, but not guilty of
goin' to sleep.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
The fact that you did not happen to notice
Sergeant Ordway, or myself for that matter,
approaching your position leads this court
to believe that you were not only lying
down while on guard duty, but also asleep.

Merriweather Lewis leans back towards Clark and whispers
something. Clark nods his head.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)
This court is of the opinion that you are
guilty of both charges and orders you to
receive a total of forty lashes, on your
bare back, for four days, beginning at
sunset of each day.

A startling THUNDERCLAP booms loudly in the dark sky and is
punctuated by a blinding flash of LIGHTNING. A soaking RAIN
begins to fall. Merriweather Lewis addresses the rest of the
crew.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)
You might think this punishment harsh,
but consider the possibility of being
attacked by savage Indians in the middle of
the night without any warning. There might
not be a man left among us to tell that sad
tale...

CLARK
Sergeant Floyd, dismiss the men and make
preparations to break camp and set sail.
And confine Private Willard to my cabin
until sundown.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

SGT. FLOYD
 (To the CREW)
 All right, you heard the Captain. Company dismissed. Get busy. I want to be under way inside an hour!

The men disperse and begin to strike their tents and round up gear and equipment on shore. As Sgt. Floyd takes Willard below deck, the CAMERA shows York, visibly distraught over the prospect of seeing a man whipped.

CUT TO:

EXT. KEEL BOAT DECK-SAME-DUSK

Hard rain pelts the wooden deck of the keel boat. Clark, with the Crew lined up in formation behind him, stands in front of the shirtless Willard. It appears as though the Crew and Clark are waiting for Merriweather Lewis .

CLARK
 (to SGT. FLOYD)
 Where is Captain Lewis?

SGT. FLOYD
 He is below deck sir. He stated that he was feeling ill and was not to be disturbed.

CLARK
 (irritated)
 Very well. We'll carry out the sentence without him.
 (he pauses and surveys the
 CREW and then turns back to
 PVT. WILLARD)
 Private Alexander Willard, step forward.
 (waits for WILLARD to come
 forward)
 You have been found guilty of lying down and sleeping on your post. Your punishment, in accordance with military law, will be forty lashes, administered over four days.
 (to the CREW)
 Company, off hats to witness punishment.
 (the men remove their hats
 respectfully)
 Sergeant Ordway, carry out the sentence.

Sgt. Ordway positions the stone-faced Willard with his back up and stretched across the cannon. Sgt. Ordway then removes the lash from its wooden box in an almost reverential manner and gingerly uncoils the cruel-looking CAT-O'-NINE-TAILS. Sgt. Ordway looks to Clark for tacit approval to commence the flogging. Clark nods and Sgt. Ordway winds his arm back over his shoulder and strikes the first blow. The leather tails CRACK loudly as they meet the bare skin of Willard's back and land in perfect synchronicity with a terrifyingly ominous THUNDERCLAP.

The storm intensifies into a wrathful downpour as the merciless blows continue to rain down on the back of the accused.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

Clark looks to the heavens as if he fears Divine retribution for man's cruelty towards man.

SGT. FLOYD
(counting out the lashes)
Seven, eight, nine, ten...

The CAMERA shows each man's reaction to the sounds and consequences of the brutal punishment. Hardened by years of rough living and harsh lives, many of the crew members look unaffected. Some of the Crew exhibit more interest in the hard rain and violent thunder than in Willard's agony. However, York is visibly upset.

The CAMERA shows dark crimson blood, looking almost black in the absence of sunlight, being washed down Willard's wounded back and onto the deck by the cold, pelting rain.

CUT TO:

FLASHBACK

EXT. JOHNSON FAMILY FARM-1782-RAINY NIGHT

The CAMERA shows thick drops of BLOOD, black in the moonlight, mixing with puddles of rain on the muddy ground. The CAMERA pans up to reveal an UNKNOWN MALE SLAVE, shirtless and lashed to a post; he is being whipped by an enraged Mr. Johnson (Sarah's master) for a petty offense. We see Young Clark and Young York hiding in a stand of trees on the outskirts of the barnyard. The two boys watch the punishment with a mix of fascination and horror.

MR. JOHNSON
(enraged)
I'll teach you to steal eggs from my
henhouse, you thieving black sneak! I feed
you and your family enough as it is! Steal
again and the punishment will be ten-times
worse!

The brutal beating of the Unknown Male Slave continues as the rain intensifies. A SLAVE MOTHER and group of 6 SLAVE CHILDREN watch this savage spectacle from an open barn door. The woman and children WAIL and CRY in anguish, which is in stark contrast to the Unknown Male Slave, who remains entirely SILENT and STOIC during his punishment.

CUT TO:

EXT. STAND OF TREES-SAME

Young Clark notices that Young York has begun to cry; he is barely able to stifle his sobs. Young Clark puts a comforting arm around Young York's shoulder and turns him away from the scene of the carnage. Young Clark takes one last look over his shoulder at the slave whipping.

CUT TO:

PRESENT DAY

EXT. KEEL BOAT DECK-1804-DUSK

York watches as Willard's punishment continues. Tears form in York's eyes.

CUT TO:

INT. KEEL BOAT-CAPT. LEWIS' CABIN-SAME

The sound of the driving rain hitting the wooden deck is drowned out by the sounds of the leather whip hitting bare flesh. Merriweather Lewis is lying prone on his bed with his forearm covering his eyes and forehead. He flinches like a frightened puppy every time a new blow hits home.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. KEEL BOAT DECK-1804-MID-MORNING

The men go about their duties on the keel boat in a slow and morose manner. Some are visibly weakened by illness. Clark comes on deck from below and assesses the situation.

CLARK

Sergeant Ordway, may I speak with you for a moment?

SGT. ORDWAY

Yes sir?

CLARK

Sergeant, the men seem to be slower than usual. What seems to be the problem?

SGT. ORDWAY

Well sir, the men are all worn out and some of them have taken sick. Sergeant Floyd is the worst of us. He has a belly ache that jus' won't go away.

(beat)

He's in an awful pain, but he ain't gonna admit it.

CLARK

That won't do. We'll have to make camp for a few days so the men can rest up. I'll tell Captain Lewis and you start looking for a decent place to lay over for a spell.

Clark looks over at SGT. FLOYD who is on the opposite side of the keel boat and holding his stomach, in obvious pain.

CLARK (cont'd)

Tell Sergeant Floyd that he is to report to my cabin and rest in my bunk until we make camp. And that's an order.

SGT. ORDWAY

Aye aye, Captain. I'll see to it.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

Clark goes below decks to Merriweather Lewis ' cabin;
Merriweather Lewis is busy writing in his journal.

CLARK
Merriweather, the men are down and out and
need some rest. And Sergeant Floyd has
taken ill...looks like some kind of stomach
ailment. He looks terrible.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(concerned)
We should make camp for a few days. Where's
Floyd now?

CLARK
Ordway is helping him into my bunk. I've
given the order to start looking for a good
place to make camp.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Fine. Yes. We'll make camp and give the men
some rest. They deserve it. Thank you for
seeing to everything, William.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-SAME-NIGHT

The men are camped at the river's edge. Spirits rise with the
prospect of a hot meal around the campfire, but Sgt. Floyd's
condition grows worse.

YORK
William, how is the Sergeant?

CAPT. CLARK
Not good, my friend. Why don't you go to
his tent and set with him awhile? I think
he'd like that.

YORK
(looking over at FLOYD'S
tent)
I think I will.

CUT TO:

INT. SGT. FLOYD'S TENT-SAME-NIGHT

York enters Sgt. Floyd's tent and stops at the entrance. He is
shocked to see Sgt. Floyd sweating profusely and writhing in
pain. Unbeknownst to anyone, Sgt. Floyd is in the advanced stages
of appendicitis.

SGT. FLOYD
(labored and weak)
Don't stand there gawkin' like a school
girl. Make yourself useful...Come over here
and put a blanket under my head.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

York bends down to tuck a blanket under Sgt. Floyd's head.

SGT. FLOYD (cont'd)
You know, I met me a lot of black men in my life...a lot of them with broken spirits. But you...you're different. You and the Captain...you don't treat each other like a master and slave. It's like, he don't mind having you as a friend, and you're good to him. Ain't never seen nothin' like it.

YORK
Well, me and the Captain, we go back a ways...

SGT. FLOYD
(interrupting)
No...
(coughs)
I know you've been together since you were young'uns. I mean that the two of you are like brothers. I can't explain it.
(beat)
You're jus' like two brothers.

YORK
(embarrassed)
A lot of folks see it that way. Guess it's 'cause when two men spend as much time together as me and William, they just grow on each other...you do things the same way and even start thinking alike.

SGT. FLOYD
He don't treat you that way because of time...
(grabs stomach in slight pain)
He treats you that way 'cause of what's in here...
(points to York's head)
And in here...
(gently touches York's heart)

York barely has time to reflect on Sgt. Floyd's remarks before Sgt. Floyd begins to cough violently, prompting York to call for the Captains.

YORK
Captains!

York mops the sweat from SGT. FLOYD'S forehead with his bandana as Clark and Merriweather Lewis enter the tent. The Crew gathers nervously outside.

YORK
Sergeant...the Captains are here now. Everything's gonna be all right, you'll see.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

SGT. FLOYD
 (barely able to talk; to
 CAPT. CLARK)
 Captain...I ain't gonna make it. I just
 ain't.
 (beat)
 You have to do one last thing for me.
 Please write a letter to my mother...tell
 her I'm going away.

Sgt. Floyd struggles and takes a last BREATH and dies in York's arms.

CUT TO:

EXT. BLUFF-MISSOURI RIVER-1804-DAY

6 members of the Crew, including York, carry Sgt. Floyd's body, sewn securely into a blanket and resting on a stretcher made of thick branches, to the top of a scenic bluff where the rest of the Crew stand at attention in preparation for the MILITARY BURIAL. The men are subdued and respectful. A red cedar cross marks the freshly dug grave. Merriweather Lewis delivers the eulogy.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
 So much can be said about this man's life,
 but even more can be said about his
 character. He was a man who knew the
 importance of friendship. He knew that
 small gestures, like a kind word and a well-
 placed jest did more for a soldier's spirit
 than anything else. Sergeant Floyd will
 always be remembered for his devotion to
 duty and his willingness to serve his
 country.
 (begins to read out of a
 prayer book)
 Oh God, it is through your mercy that the
 souls of all men take their rest; we ask
 thee to bless this hallowed ground and
 absolve from sin he whose soul we now
 commend to your keeping. May he rest in
 peace. Amen.

THE CREW
 Amen.

CLARK
 Captain Lewis, I'd like to say a few words.
 (pauses)
 Sergeant Floyd at all times gave us proofs
 of his firmness and determined resolution
 to do service to his country and honor to
 himself. He will be sorely missed.

The Crew watch in solemn silence as Sgt. Floyd's body is lowered into the ground. York is one of the men who performs this sad duty, and tears roll freely down his cheeks.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

As several of the men begin shoveling earth into the grave, the CAMERA shows dirt hitting the blanket-covered corpse.

OLD YORK (VO)

On the morning of August 20th, 1804, we buried Sergeant Charles Floyd with all the decency that we could possibly provide.

FADE OUT:

FADE IN:

SUPERIMPOSE: THE GREAT PLAINS

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-1804-DAY

The Crew is busy crating all manner of SCIENTIFIC SPECIMENS and taking measurements of species they have never seen before. Strange new BIRDS, PLANTS, and ANIMALS are being cataloged for President Jefferson to observe back at Monticello. Sgt. Pryor spots a PRAIRIE DOG in the distance, and the men stop working to observe this never-before-seen rodent.

SGT. PRYOR

Captains! Look over there! What in the Sam Hill is that?

CLARK

Looks like a small gopher. But it's *barking*.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

It is a strange looking creature... this is a curiosity President Jefferson would enjoy examining first-hand. I want that animal taken...

Drouillard cocks his rifle and sights in on the Prairie Dog, but Merriweather Lewis. Merriweather Lewis put his hand on the barrel and pushes it downward.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)

...**alive**.

DROULLIARD

(incredulous)
Sir?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

You heard me. I want it captured alive.

All of the Crew look with apprehension at the little prairie dog in the distance, as if sizing up an unknown enemy.

CUT TO:

EXT. PRAIRIE LAND-SAME

The entire Crew are chasing and attempting to catch the elusive little creature. Seaman joins in the pursuit as well.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

Frustrated and hot, they are desperate for a solution. Drouillard happens to chase the prairie dog down a hole. York approaches Clark.

YORK

William...remember how we used to catch those rabbits down in the holes out back.

CAPT. CLARK

As I recall, we used to shoot them. That is, I used to shoot them. You killed a lot of rocks...

YORK

No! I'm talkin' 'bout when we didn't have any powder or balls for that broken down old musket...member how we used to *flush* those fat ol' rabbits right out of their holes.

CLARK

Yep....

A sly smile slowly creeps across Clark's face as he continues to observe the fruitless efforts of the demoralized Crew.

CUT TO:

EXT. PRAIRIE LAND-SAME-DAY

The Crew forms a bucket-brigade, extending from the river to the hole where the prairie dog is hiding. The Crew dump bucket after bucket into the hole. The soggy prairie dog finally emerges from his place of concealment. York grabs the highly agitated and increasingly vocal rodent by the scruff of its neck.

YORK

I knew you'd come out. You ain't no fish, you're just a big squirrel. Don't worry none...they ain't gonna kill you.

(beat)

Can't eat something we ain't even got a name for, can we? No sir they're gonna put you in a nice cage and send you back to the President.

(the prairie dog is livid at his capture and continues to bark feverishly)

CUT TO:

INT. MERRIWEATHER LEWIS' TENT-MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-SAME-NIGHT

The entire Crew sleeps peacefully. Seaman sleeps at the entrance to Merriweather Lewis' tent. The dog wakes up with a start, sniffing the outside air and raising his ears inquisitively. Alarmed by a barely audible RUMBLING NOISE, Seaman begins to WHIMPER and BARK frantically. He paws at Merriweather Lewis until the Merriweather Lewis wakes up, reeling in confusion.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

The dog then darts out of the tent into the night. The ominous rumbling noise becomes louder.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-SAME-NIGHT

Seaman runs through the camp, barking furiously in an attempt to awaken the Crew. Men begin to emerge from their tents, half-asleep and in various states of undress. York, Clark and Merriweather Lewis gather outside of Merriweather Lewis tent. The deep rumbling continues. York stoops down and puts first his hand, and then his ear to the vibrating ground.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(excited; to Clark)
Wild horses?

CLARK
(unsure)
Sounds like too many to be horses.

YORK
I can't say for sure, but it almost sounds like cattle...

Just then, Sgt. Pryor, who has been on sentry duty, comes running into camp from the direction of a small hill, several hundred yards away. What looks like a black storm cloud blocks the moonlight behind him, but it is actually a cloud of dust raised by 1000's of STAMPEDING BUFFALO. The Sergeant is out of breath and visibly frightened.

SGT. PRYOR
Stampede! It's buffalo! They're headed this way, make for the river!

CLARK
(to the CREW)
Break camp and make for the river! Now!

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Save as many of the specimens as you can!
Sergeant Ordway, help me with my trunk...we must not lose the journals.

YORK
(worried)
Where's Seaman?

The men begin to run pell-mell for the river. Clark and Sgt. Pryor supervise the men. Unable to find Seaman, York wades out to the keel boat holding the caged prairie dog high above his head. The prairie dog shrieks his disapproval. Some of the men help Merriweather Lewis and Sgt. Ordway to come aboard. They carry a large trunk between them which is also hoisted onto the deck. The sound of the stampeding buffalo is now a deafening ROAR, as the first woolly beasts appear on the hill. From the deck of the keel boat, everyone watches in astonishment as 1000's of buffalo stampede across the prairie and through what minutes before was their camp.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

York nervously scans the shore for Seaman. A faint barking is heard above the stampede. Seaman appears on the shoreline. He is herding the buffalo away from the river's edge and then swims for the boat. The men cheer. Seaman barks cheerfully. Relieved, York helps Seaman onto the boat.

YORK (cont'd)
(petting SEAMAN
affectionately)
Hey, boy...you're the first hero of the
expedition. You ain't afraid of nothing!

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
I knew I brought this fine beast along for
a reason. But nonetheless, from now on, I
want to double the evening watch. I want
sentries posted on opposite sides of the
camp.

SGT. PRYOR
(apologetic)
Captain, I'm sorry I didn't warn the camp
sooner. At first I thought it was thunder.
(beat)
Then they just came out of nowhere.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(reassuring)
You did your best. Let's just be grateful
that Seaman hears better than us.

York continues to pet Seaman. The Newfoundland rolls on his back in appreciation.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. KEEL BOAT DECK-1804-MORNING

The keel boat makes its way up the Missouri River. The entire Crew looks tense and uneasy. This is LAKOTA SIOUX country. The first group of teepees is soon spotted, along with some LAKOTA WOMEN and CHILDREN doing chores by the river. The Lakota Sioux barely give the Crew a second glance. This is not a good sign.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(to the CREW)
All hands, have a care and listen
carefully...We are about to make contact
with the Lakota Sioux, the most powerful
Indian Tribe west of the Mississippi. At
all costs, we want this to be a friendly
encounter even though they are a highly
warlike nation. Their warriors are
bloodthirsty and fierce and are avid scalp-
takers.

At this, some of the Crew pat the hair on the top of their heads fearfully.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)

Remember, we are on a mission of peace. Do not initiate any unwarranted acts of aggression and do not succumb to any taunting or overtures of violence. Avoid horseplay of all kinds, no matter how innocent it may seem. These people are very competitive and have a well-developed, if primitive, sense of honor. That is all.

(to Drouillard)

I expect we shall be putting your sign-talking skills to the ultimate test soon...

DROUILLARD

(quietly)

Ready as I'll ever be.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Very well, then...

(shouting)

Private Cruzatte, bring us to starboard and head for shore. All hands look alive and be alert. Keep those muskets loaded and ready, but out of sight.

(beat)

Sergeant Ordway, prepare an armed landing party...six privates.

SGT. ORDWAY

Aye, sir.

Large numbers of Lakota Sioux Indians gather on both sides of the river as the keel boat makes its way to the shoreline.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-SAME

With the keel boat anchored safely about 75 yards off shore, a smaller boat manned by Clark, Merriweather Lewis, Sgt. Ordway, Drouillard, York, and 6 PRIVATES heads for the river bank where a delegation of LAKOTA CHIEFS and 30 SIOUX WARRIORS stands impassively, waiting. BLACK BUFFALO, BIG MEDICINE, and PARTISAN are the 3 principal Chiefs of the Lakota Nation. They watch as the LANDING PARTY beach their skiff and set up a canopy to receive the Indians. Several of the 6 Privates prop up a FLAGPOLE on the beach and raise the colors. The SIOUX DELEGATION moves slowly towards the CREW LANDING PARTY. The 3 principal chiefs carry welcoming gifts in leather pouches.

CHIEF PARTISAN

(in Lakota)

They look angry. What do you think they're so mad about?

CHIEF BUFFALO MEDICINE

(in Lakota)

You're eyes deceive you. I don't think they look angry, I think they look scared.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

CHIEF BLACK BUFFALO
 (pointing to York)
 Look! There is their medicine man, covered
 with charcoal.
 (pointing to Capt. Lewis in
 his Army uniform)
 Na-po-leon!

The Chief's laugh slightly and approach the canopy, leaving their followers waiting on the high ground behind them.

YORK
 They look mad.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
 Nonsense. They see our firepower. They are
 in awe of the military might of the United
 States of America. I'm sure they are
 determined to make a good impression on us.

DROUILLARD
 Begging the Captain's pardon, sir, but it
 takes a lot to impress these people. If
 they're determined about anything, I'd say
 they're determined to trade for a few of
 our Kentucky rifles. If anything, they look
 to me like they know whose land this is and
 who's outnumbered twenty to one.

Merriweather Lewis looks annoyed, but he doesn't have time to answer, the landing Party.

CLARK
 (To DROUILLARD; not taking
 his eyes off the CHIEFS)
 Well, this is it. Let's just hope they're
 willing to be all friendly-like. Be
 careful, men. Hold your ground and don't
 make any false moves. George, tell them in
 your hand signs that we come in peace and
 we have gifts for them.

Drouillard and the Lakota Sioux know each other; Drouillard signs to the Chiefs; at the same time, he speaks to them haltingly in broken Lakota.

DROUILLARD
 (in Lakota)
 Great War-Chiefs of the Lakota Nation,
 these white men come in peace, and bring
 gifts as a sign of their respect. They
 bring greetings from the father of all the
 whites, who lives far to the east, where
 the sun begins its journey every morning.
 The Great White Father greatly desires the
 friendship of the Lakota, and he sends
 these men as his messengers of good will.

CHIEF BLACK BUFFALO
 (in Lakota to Drouillard)
 I have heard you, Talking Hands.
 (MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

CHIEF BLACK BUFFALO (cont'd)

We did not expect you to be with these white-eyes on the floating lodge, but your coming here to make the sign talk is a good thing. We too have gifts.

Chief Black Buffalo motions towards Chief Partisan and Chief Buffalo Medicine, and the two subordinate Chiefs hand over a large amount of dried buffalo meat packed in highly-ornate beaded leather pouches to Clark, who gives them to York. The SIOUX CHIEFS grunt their approval at what they perceive to be Clark deferring to York. Merriweather Lewis signals 2 PRIVATES to bring forward gifts for the Sioux. LEWIS gives each of the Chiefs a bronze peace medal and a tin of salted pork. Recognizing Chief Black Buffalo as the obvious leader, Merriweather Lewis gives the old Chief a bright red military frock coat with a double row of brass buttons and a plumed Napoleonic Military Hat. Chief Black Buffalo immediately dons these presents, but all of the Chiefs look expectantly at the Landing Party, clearly expecting more booty.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

My new friends, we the Corps of Discovery, on behalf of our great President Thomas Jefferson, bestow on you these peace medals as a means of welcoming you as citizens of the United States of America. You are now under the protection of the United States Army.

(beat)

All right, Drouillard.

DROUILLARD

(Tense and sensing the dissatisfaction of the Sioux; in Lakota)

Great Chiefs of the Lakota Nation, Captain Lewis, on behalf of all the whites, begs for your friendship and protection. He requests that he and his men be allowed to travel freely in your country and says the whites will honor you in the future with many more gifts.

The 3 Chiefs are unimpressed as they look at the peace medals.

CHIEF BLACK BUFFALO

(in Lakota)

What are these?

CHIEF PARTISAN

(in Lakota)

They are like the small round charms that a child plays with.

DROUILLARD

(to Black Buffalo; in Lakota)

No, they are strong medicine...they will allow you to travel freely in the land of the whites.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (3)

CHIEF BLACK BUFFALO
(stone-faced; in Lakota to
Drouillard)
Tell them it will take more than worthless
medals and a colorful coat to earn the
friendship of the Lakota.

As Chief Black Buffalo is speaking to Drouillard, the Napoleonic
hat falls from his head to the sand. Chief Buffalo Medicine
retrieves it for him.

CHIEF BUFFALO MEDICINE
(in Lakota)
And that goes for funny hats too...

CAPT. LEWIS
What is he saying?

CAPT. CLARK
Do you really need to know? They don't look
pleased, Lewis.

DROUILLARD
(to Capt. Lewis)
They're tough customers, sir. I don't think
peace medals are going to be enough to
pacify this lot.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(conciliatory)
Maybe a tour of the *floating lodge* might
suit their fancy?

CLARK
It's worth a try. Go ahead and make the
offer, George.

DROUILLARD
(in Lakota)
Black Buffalo, perhaps you and your Chiefs
would like to go aboard the floating lodge
and discuss the possibility of more gifts?

CHIEF BLACK BUFFALO
(in Lakota)
It is good. But three of the white-eyes
must stay here with my people until we
return.

CHIEF PARTISAN
(in Lakota)
Talking Hands, tell them that I too want a
fine soldier coat.

CHIEF BUFFALO MEDICINE
(in Lakota)
As do I. (Looks at the Napoleonic hat) But
I do not want one of these strange hats.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (4)

Chief Black Buffalo glares at Chief Buffalo Medicine and Chief Partisan menacingly and snatches his hat back from Chief Buffalo Medicine.

DROUILLARD

(to the CAPTAINS)

They've agreed to take the tour...and they want three men left behind until daybreak.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Very well, then...

(beat; to York)

York, bring up our launch. Sergeant Ordway, pick two men to remain behind with you. If things get hot, fire a volley and we will support you from the keel boat with the cannon.

SGT. ORDWAY

(worried)

It isn't going to be much of a volley with only three men...

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Point taken, Sergeant. Keep an eye out...you may have to swim for it.

YORK

(to Capt. Lewis)

I'd be willing to stay behind, Sir.

CLARK

(annoyed)

Absolutely not! That is out of the question. You're place is with me. Now all of you, get going and prepare to bring the Chiefs aboard. Move!

The Chiefs watch this exchange with interest; Drouillard invites them to come aboard the keel boat in sign. The Chiefs grunt in agreement. Sgt. Ordway and 2 PRIVATES remain on the beach while the rest of the men paddle out to the keel boat in the canoe.

CUT TO:

EXT. CANOE-MISSOURI RIVER-SAME

Chief Black Buffalo looks at YORK with unabashed curiosity, amazed at YORK'S skin color and enormous size. He tries to rub off the "black" with his fingers, recoiling in fear when the "paint" does not come off. Chief Black Buffalo and the other Chiefs whisper excitedly amongst themselves. York is confused.

YORK

George, what was that all about?

DROUILLARD

He wanted to see if your color would come off. They ain't never seen a black man before, at least not one as big as you.

(beat)

(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

DROUILLARD (cont'd)
Don't worry, they probably think you're a
god of some kind.

This comment is not lost upon the Merriweather Lewis looks
amused; Clark looks perplexed.

CHIEF BLACK BUFFALO
(in Lakota; to the other
CHIEFS)
His color is not charcoal or paint.

CHIEF BUFFALO MEDICINE
(in Lakota)
A god does not have to paint his body in
order to come down from the sky.

CHIEF BLACK BUFFALO
(in Lakota)
If he is a god, why is he with these fools?

CHIEF PARTISAN
(in Lakota)
Maybe he is held against his will by some
magic these white men possess. Maybe he has
special powers the white men need, so they
keep him prisoner.

CHIEF BUFFALO MEDICINE
(in Lakota)
He is probably waiting for the right time
to kill them. We can help this god
slaughter his enemies and be free. Then he
will look with favor on us...maybe he will
even stay with us.

York stares quizzically at the 3 Chiefs; Chief Buffalo Medicine
and Chief Partisan smile fearfully and condescendingly at York,
but Chief Black Buffalo remains grim.

CHIEF BLACK BUFFALO
(in Lakota)
We will not harm these white-eyes and risk
offending their god.

YORK
Now what are they saying, George?

CLARK
Yeah, George, do tell us what the topic of
conversation is...

DROUILLARD
(disinterested)
Oh, I don't know...they're just going on
and on about what a handsome devil ol' York
is...

York smiles at the Chiefs. The Chiefs smile back and nod their
heads nervously.

CUT TO:

EXT. KEEL BOAT DECK-MISSOURI RIVER-SAME

The Chiefs and Captains along with York and Drouillard come aboard the keel boat. The Chiefs look around and take in their surroundings; they are particularly interested in the Crew's rifles. Merriweather Lewis pours each of the Chiefs a 1/4 glass of whiskey, which the Chiefs begin sipping immediately. The 3 Chiefs, emboldened by the whiskey, become boisterous. They begin to touch anything they can get their hands on and start to mix in with the Crew. Some of the Privates let the Chiefs handle their rifles. Clark scans the shoreline with a spyglass where SGT. Ordway and his men have been surrounded by curious Lakota Sioux. Merriweather Lewis becomes nervous trying to keep tabs on the wandering Chiefs; Clark has had enough.

CAPT. CLARK

Sergeant Pryor, form a detail of seven men to take these three dandies back to shore. Make two canoes ready to shove off right away. York, Drouillard and I are coming with you.

SGT. PRYOR

Aye-aye, sir.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-SAME

The 2 canoes reach the shore and are immediately mobbed by a throng of Lakota. The 3 Chiefs are drunk and in no hurry to disembark. Sgt. Ordway and his detail hastily jump into one of the canoes. Sgt. Pryor and several Privates have to muscle the 3 Chiefs out of their canoe. 3 WARRIORS enter the shallow water to receive their Chiefs, and are not happy about the way the Chiefs are being man-handled. More WARRIORS enter the water and grab the canoes to prevent them from leaving. In the background, Merriweather Lewis is bringing the keel boat as close to shore as he can without grounding it. The situation is precarious.

CLARK

(firmly)

Drouillard, tell them to let go of our canoes.

A shaken Drouillard attempts to sign to the Lakota Sioux, but he is interrupted by Chief Partisan, who has grown belligerent.

CHIEF PARTISAN

(in Lakota; to the crowd)

These white men have offered us unsuitable presents. They should not be allowed to leave until they give us a canoe filled with rifles, whiskey, and fine soldier coats as proper payment for passage through our land.

DROUILLARD

(nervously, to CAPT. CLARK)

He says he wants a canoe full of booty.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

Clark draws his saber and the men with him cock their rifles. Drouillard looks caught in the middle.

CLARK

Tell these savages that they have received their gifts and that what they demand is impossible for us to deliver.

Drouillard signs Clark's words. Chief Partisan looks to Chief Black Buffalo for approval, but Chief Black Buffalo says nothing. So as to not lose face, Chief Partisan shakes his head "no" to Clark's demands. The Lakota Warriors continue to hold the canoes.

CLARK (cont'd)

Men, prepare for action. Wait for my order to fire...make every shot count.

The members of the Landing Party cock their rifles and take aim. On board the keel boat, Merriweather Lewis and the rest of the Crew line the deck with their weapons at the ready; the cannon is loaded and trained on the shore. The Lakota Warriors notch their bows with arrows. A tense silence ensues. York begins to pray in a low, but deep voice. The Lakota Warriors regard York with superstitious apprehension and shrink back while murmuring fearfully.

YORK

Our Father, who art in heaven, hallowed be Thy Name...

CHIEF BUFFALO MEDICINE

(to Partisan, pointing at YORK)

Now you've done it! He's putting a curse on us!

A shocked York stops praying.

CHIEF BLACK BUFFALO

(in Lakota; hurriedly, to Drouillard, while back-pedaling)

Your generous gifts have been sufficient. We wish you the best of luck on your journey.

DROUILLARD

(relieved)

He says he's happy with your gifts and York is welcome here, anytime.

CLARK

Well, that's more like it.

(To York)

York, wave goodbye to your new friends.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

York waves enthusiastically toward the Lakota Sioux Indians. The Lakota Sioux Indians all duck down in unison to avoid York's "bad medicine".

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-1804-DAY-FALL

SUPERIMPOSE: FALL, 1804

Flocks of HONKING GEESE fly over the keel boat as they begin their winter migration. The weather is turning colder and the men wear heavier clothing.

CUT TO:

INT. YORK'S TENT-CAMP ON THE MISSOURI RIVER-SAME-NIGHT

York is wakened out of a sound sleep by the sound of Clark moaning in pain. York pulls his boots on and exits his tent.

CUT TO:

INT. CAPT. CLARK'S TENT-SAME

York enters Clark's tent. Clark is suffering from a case of rheumatism and is in visible agony.

YORK

William, are you all right?

CLARK

(labored)

My joints and muscles are so swollen and sore that it is sheer agony to move even an inch.

YORK

Sounds like you've got the rheumatism again...just like when you were a boy.

CLARK

(sadly)

I'm afraid you might be right. Back then you stayed up with me all night and read to me until the sun came up.

YORK

And I'll do it again if I need to. Only this time, ain't got no books to read...I'll have to tell you stories out of my head.

CLARK

Hey now,

(groans softly before spasm

passes)

you'd just love to talk my ears sore all night, wouldn't ya?

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

YORK
I could if you want me to.

CLARK
(kindly)
No, just help me get over these spasms.
I've heard all of your tall tales before.

YORK
Oh, I've got a lot more to tell now,
especially since we've come on this here
expedition.

Just then, Clark is racked with a prolonged bout of painful spasms and is overcome by pain; he struggles to catch his breath.

CLARK
You had better go and fetch Captain Lewis
right quick.

YORK
I'll go get him. Try not to move until I
get back.

Clark suppresses a groan.

CLARK
(weak)
I'll try, but I can't promise you anything.

York exits quickly with a worried look on his face.

CUT TO:

INT. MERRIWEATHER LEWIS' TENT-SAME

YORK
(entering)
Captain Lewis, sir? Captain Lewis?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(coming awake)
Yes, York, what's the matter?

YORK
It's Captain Clark, sir. He's groaning
something terrible and having an awful hard
time moving.

Merriweather Lewis pulls on his boots and puts on his coat.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Half a minute...All right, let's go.

York and Merriweather Lewis exit and go to Clark's tent.

CUT TO:

INT. CLARK'S TENT-SAME

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
What seems to be the trouble, William?

CLARK
Well, for starters, I feel like I've had a run-in with a bull buffalo...I never knew it was possible for every muscle in my body to be on fire at once. Even breathing is painful.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(feeling CLARK'S forehead)
Hmmm...an acute case of rheumatism, possibly accompanied by fever and congestion of the lungs...

YORK
Can you help him, Captain?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Yes, York, I believe I can do just that.
(beat)
Bring me three or four hot rocks from the watch fire wrapped in a blanket. We'll use the heat to draw the sickness right out of him. Hurry now.

CLARK
Merriweather, I don't think I've ever felt worse...if something should happen to me...and I don't pull through...

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(sharply)
I won't have any of that talk. You're delirious...

CLARK
No, listen to me. Just in case...just in case I don't return from this little journey of ours, promise me you'll take care of York. You know he's like a brother to me and I just don't know what...

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
He'd do without you. I know.

CLARK
(looking straight ahead)
I guess that's probably why I ain't never set him free. I worry about him getting along without me. Heck, I don't know what I'd do without *him*.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(concerned)
But you will set him free some day, wont you?

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

CLARK
(suddenly alarmed)
Why do you ask?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Curiosity, perhaps, and maybe nothing more.
(beat)
You know I abhor the institution of slavery...most enlightened men do. Even Jefferson is embarrassed by the fact that he still owns slaves, although why he doesn't free them is a mystery to me.

CLARK
Because he'd be *freeing* his mistress and half a score of his illegitimate children?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(amused)
Ah, blasphemy! I see you've heard that nasty little rumor too...

CLARK
It's no rumor and you know it.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
We were talking about York.

CLARK
So we were...what about him?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Do the words *Santo Domingo* mean anything to you?

CLARK
Of course. Every Southerner knows about the slave revolt in Santo Domingo. The French had it coming...they mistreated their Negroes something wicked. That's why it will never happen here...we, I mean most of us, treat our slaves like family. Hell, at least some of us do. Besides, what does that have to do with York?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Nothing, really. I just wonder how a man like York will adjust to being a slave again after having a taste of freedom.

CLARK
What are you saying?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
What am I saying? I guess I'm saying that if you wanted to keep him, William, you should have never brought him out here.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

Clark looks thoughtful.

CUT TO:

EXT. TENT-SAME

Unbeknownst to the Captains, Drouillard has been outside the tent eavesdropping and has heard their entire conversation. The CAMERA shows Drouillard crouched down with his ear to the canvass. As YORK approaches carrying a bundle of hot rocks for Clark, Drouillard straightens up and faces York.

YORK
(startled)
I didn't see you there, George. What are you doing out here?

DROUILLARD
(nervous)
I was just looking for you. How's Captain Clark doing?

YORK
Oh, he's doing fine. Don't worry about the Captain. Captain Lewis is by his side.

DROUILLARD
Then you'd better get those rocks in there while they're still hot.

CUT TO:

INT. CLARK'S TENT-SAME

York enters the tent in a hurry with four hot rocks wrapped in a blanket and hands them to Merriweather Lewis .

YORK
Here you go, sir.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Good...perfect. Let's wrap him in a blanket and put the rocks on each side of his chest and under each arm, like so.

York obediently wraps Clark in a blanket, securing it under his friend's arms. Merriweather Lewis uses another blanket to handle the hot rocks and puts them in place. He then wraps Clark and the rocks in the second blanket for a "sandwich" effect. Clark squirms a bit and starts to break out in a massive sweat.

YORK
Look at that! The sickness is coming right out of you, William!

CAPT. LEWIS
(looking at York)
What, you doubted my medical expertise?

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

YORK
(laughing, shaking his head)
No sir...not for one minute. Just never saw
a cure work so fast, is all.

CAPT. LEWIS
Well, you keep an eye on our dear friend
here and I'll be back at daybreak.

YORK
I will.

York kneels down by Clark and Clark smiles weakly as he grabs for York's hand. York takes Clark's hand in both of his big hands and smiles down at him. Clark, sweating profusely, soon falls asleep.

FADE TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-1804-DAY

SUPERIMPOSE: OCTOBER 24TH, 1804, NEAR PRESENT DAY BISMARCK, NORTH DAKOTA

The keel boat sails down the river, which is lined by high bluffs. As the boat traverses its way through a bend in the river, large numbers of MANDAN INDIANS become visible on the bluffs on both sides of the river. The Mandan Indians are magnificently dressed and present an impressive appearance.

CUT TO:

EXT. KEEL BOAT DECK-SAME

The men of the Crew look up at the high bluffs and admire the regal Mandan Indians.

CLARK
(in amazement)
Look at their clothing! These reds must be
the gentry of the Plains Indians!

DROUILLARD
Those are the Mandans, Captain...
friendliest of all the natives. As I see
it, there's only one problem with our
meeting them...

CLARK
What's that?

DROUILLARD
They're the last point on the map. After
them...
(looks out onto the horizon)
only God knows what's out there.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-SAME

Clark, Merriweather Lewis and Drouillard go ashore where a Mandan Indian delegation consisting of CHIEF BIG WHITE and FIVE WARRIORS wait to greet them.

CHIEF BIG WHITE

(in Mandan)

I am Big White and I welcome you! You are my guests and you may stay as long as you wish. Please come and sit by my fire.

DROUILLARD

(confused)

His name is Big White. He says we're welcome to stay as long as we like and he wants to sit on a fire?

Chief Big White signals to follow with his hand.

DROUILLARD

Captain Clark, I've never known an Indian to sit on a fire before.

CLARK

I think this will be one for the journals.

CUT TO:

INT. MANDAN ADOBE LODGE-SAME-NIGHT

The Captains look suspiciously at Drouillard as Chief Big White and another Chief, BLACK ROCK sit down by the fire. A MANDAN WARRIOR stands guard at the door. The Captains and Drouillard follow the Mandan's lead by sitting down also. Drouillard looks embarrassed.

CHIEF BIG WHITE

(in Mandan)

I am glad to see such peaceful white men. And you are now friends of the Mandan. Our wish is to be at peace with all. If we eat...then you will eat. But...if we starve...so shall you starve also.

Chief Big White turns towards the fire to think.

DROUILLARD

He says that if they eat, so do we, and if they starve...so do we. Also he considers us to be his friends.

BIG WHITE

(in Mandan)

Tell me about the holy man you travel with. Does he protect you from your enemies in the wilderness?

Chief Black Rock nods his head in agreement. Both Chief Big White and Black Rock look expectantly at Drouillard and the Captains.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

DROUILLARD

I'm not certain what he means. I think he wants to know why we have a medicine man with us.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Who is he talking about?

CLARK

Drouillard, your Mandan must be rusty. Are you sure that is what Chief Big White said?

DROUILLARD

Yes, Captain...I am sure.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

(dryly)

As sure as you were about Indians sitting on the fire?

CHIEF BLACK ROCK

(sensing their confusion;
speaks to the Warrior at the
door in Mandan)

Bring the medicine man here.

The Mandan Warrior nods and departs.

CLARK

Now what'd he say?

DROUILLARD

He wants to see the medicine man?

CLARK

Who? Who is our medicine man?

DROUILLARD

(in Mandan)

Chief Big White, who is this holy man you speak of?

CHIEF BLACK ROCK

(to Big White)

They must not be right in the head. They do not know their own medicine man.

At this point, the Mandan Warrior reenters the lodge leading York by the arm.

YORK

(to Clark)

You wanted to see me, Captain?

CAPT. CLARK

(amused)

No, York, but apparently Chief Big White here does. Sit down.

Confused, York sits down by the fire.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

CAPT. LEWIS
 (looking at York and speaking
 almost to himself)
 Remarkable. I should have known it. His
 color...they have never seen a black man
 before. They must think that he is the
 stuff of legends...

CHIEF BLACK ROCK
 (to Big White)
 Why does this medicine man cover himself
 with paint?

Chief Big White is silent and dumbfounded. Chief Black Rock gets
 up with a handful of dirt and tries to rub the "blackness" off of
 York. York endures this "test" with good humor. When no paint
 comes off, the 2 Mandan Chiefs are shocked.

CHIEF BLACK ROCK
 (in Mandan)
 He isn't a medicine man; he is a god!

CHIEF BIG WHITE
 He must be one of the bear men that walked
 the earth long ago. I had heard that they
 all left these lands many seasons ago.

DROUILLARD
 They think he is a god now!

CLARK
 See York, you're a god to these savages
 because you're black. How about that?

YORK
 Wish my color had the same effect on people
 back home as it does here. I'd be King by
 now.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
 (slightly jealous)
 Or at least a Duke...can we dispense with
 the fairy tales and get on with the
 council?

The 2 Mandan Chiefs continue to talk amongst themselves.

CLARK
 Lewis, this superstition of theirs might be
 useful to us.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
 (thinking)
 I agree, Clark, I agree. We'll let York
 play the part of a god, or medicine man, or
 whatever they want him to be. If it makes
 them look on us with favor, I'm all for it.

The 2 Mandan Chiefs finish their private conversation and face
 the Captains.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (3)

CHIEF BIG WHITE

The cold is near and you cannot go on. We would be honored if you and your...

(motioning towards York)

bear man would build a soldier fort across the river and stay with us until the sun becomes hot again.

DROUILLARD

He says we can build a fort across the river and spend the winter here.

CLARK

A fort? Merriweather?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Drouillard, tell the Chief we accept his gracious offer.

Drouillard translates this response to CHIEF BIG WHITE. The Captains and the 2 Mandan Chiefs smile and nod at each other.

FADE TO:

INT. LARGE MANDAN LODGE-SAME

There is a feast in progress inside the large, domed structure. The feasting lodge is made of adobe. Cruzatte is contributing to the native music with his fiddle; the Crew are dancing with INDIAN WOMEN and generally enjoying themselves. There are at least 50 MANDAN INDIANS mingling around a huge fire in the center of the lodge. The Captains wear their dress uniforms and the INDIANS are decked out in their most ornate finery. YORK is pretending to be a bear. He wears blue army trousers with white canvas gaiters around his boots. He is bare-chested. He growls and chases terrified MANDAN INDIAN CHILDREN. Even some of the MANDAN INDIAN ADULTS are frightened by York's antics. The Mandan Indian Children scatter and hide behind lodge poles. An OLD HIDATSA CHIEF, 80s, approaches York fearfully, while muttering under his breath. The room becomes silent and all eyes are on York and the Old Hidatsa Chief. YORK stands proudly while the Old Hidatsa Chief rubs York's skin suspiciously, attempting to "wipe the dirt off". When the Old Hidatsa Chief realizes that York's skin is actually black, he recoils in amazement and rushes back to his astonished Mandan Indians. York laughs deeply. The feast resumes.

Drouillard approaches YORK. He is accompanied by the HEAD CROW WARRIOR. The Head Crow Warrior becomes agitated and afraid at the sight of YORK; he turns to run. Drouillard grabs him by his arm and reassures him. The Head Crow Warrior does not make eye contact with York.

YORK

(facing them as they approach)

What's this, George?

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

DROUILLARD

Well York, this here is a Crow Warrior. He and some of his kin maintain a trading camp nearby so as to be close to their Mandan friends. They heard that we had a big, black *medicine man* with us, and it seems that this here brave has a favor to ask you.

YORK

(suspicious)

A favor? What kind of favor?

DROUILLARD

Well...

(beat)

These people believe that *big medicine* is passed on in strange and mysterious ways.

(scratching his head and
embarrassed)

What he wants is for you to get to *know* his wife.

YORK

(not understanding)

What do you mean...get to *know* his wife? He wants me to meet her?

DROUILLARD

Oh, you'll get to meet her, that's for certain, but I think he's got something a little more in mind. He wants you to *know* her in the, uh, the, uh, biblical sense. He figures that you laying with his wife will give her your medicine, and he'll get it the next time they lay together.

YORK

(shocked)

What if I say no?

DROUILLARD

That would be mighty bad manners. Besides, it's the easiest favor you'll ever do for anyone. He is considered to be quite a warrior among the Crows, and this is a great honor he offers you.

York looks at the HEAD CROW WARRIOR who is continuing to look away and not meet his gaze.

YORK

What's wrong with him?

DROUILLARD

(laughing)

He's afraid of you! They think you're some kind of a god. They're saying that you are a bear who has come to life and learned how to talk.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

 YORK
Should I do it?

Drouillard smiles.

CUT TO:

EXT. TEEPEE-CROW CAMP-SAME

The HEAD CROW WARRIOR stands proudly with his arms folded, guarding the entrance to his teepee.

CUT TO:

INT. TEEPEE-SAME

Inside the teepee, a small but fire blazes in the center. There are several bear hides and buffalo robes scattered on the ground. York kneels at the entrance of the teepee. He is too tall to stand. He has a look of utter fear and shock on his face as he beholds 4 CROW INDIAN WOMEN, ranging from their late teens to their late 30s, eyeing him with amused lust. York notices one PRETTY CROW INDIAN GIRL in particular. Their eyes meet and they make an instant connection. The Crow Indian Women swarm York, and laughing, begin to take his clothes off.

CUT TO:

EXT. CROW CAMP-SAME

Clark and Drouillard, who is carrying a torch, walk purposely and rapidly towards the teepee. Clark looks determined; Drouillard looks sheepish. Soon they are facing the Head Crow Warrior who is impassive and staring straight ahead. The Head Crow Warrior is wearing his weapons, and the CAMERA shows this.

 CLARK
 (annoyed)
George, I told you to bring me to York.
What are we doing here?

Noises of gratification emanate from inside the teepee.

 DROUILLARD
 (apologetic)
Well Captain, he's in there.

 CLARK
Doing what?

 DROUILLARD
Well sir, basically, I'd say he's keeping
up good relations with the Indians.

 CLARK
Well, I need to speak with him. Tell this
man to step aside.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

DROUILLARD
I'll tell him sir, but I doubt he'll
listen.

Drouillard speaks to the Head Crow Warrior in the Crow language. The LEAD CROW WARRIOR, as if noticing Drouillard and Clark for the first time, becomes angry and begins to speak rapidly in his native language. When he is done berating Drouillard and Clark, he puts his hand on the hilt of a large hunting knife.

DROUILLARD (cont'd)
(in Crow)
My chief would like to enter your lodge and
speak with his warrior.

LEAD CROW WARRIOR
(translated)

DROUILLARD
He says that Talking Bear is not to be
disturbed. He says Talking Bear will return
to his white-eyed friends when he is
finished here.

CLARK
Talking Bear?

DROUILLARD
Yes sir. It seems that's what a lot of the
reds are calling York these days.

Clark looks perplexed.

DROUILLARD (cont'd)
Sir, if I could say something here? I think
it would be real good form for you and I to
let York finish his business here and make
our way back to camp. To be honest, I think
that if either one of us puts a head inside
this teepee...we're going to have a fight
on our hands.

CLARK
(pauses, and, thinking
rationally to himself,
shakes his head in
exasperation)
Very well, then...let's go. (sarcastically)
Not to interrupt York's *missionary*
activities, but tell this fine, upstanding
member of the Crow Nation to advise *Talking*
Bear that the *Great Red-haired Chief* was
inquiring after him.

CUT TO:

EXT. CROW CAMP-MIDNIGHT

A CROW SECRET WARRIOR SOCIETY is holding a ceremonial dance by a large campfire. YORK is the only member of the expedition present.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

He is surrounded by admiring CROW INDIANS who encourage him to join the dance. The dancing is highly animated and mimics the violence of warfare and hand-to-hand combat. After some coaxing, YORK loses his inhibitions and begins to dance. He has never felt more **free** and is enjoying himself immensely. The CROWS are pleased with YORK'S actions. Enveloping him, they make YORK the focal point of the ceremony. The HEAD CROW WARRIOR paints half of YORK'S face red.

An OLD CROW MEDICINE MAN drapes a huge bearskin over York's head and shoulders. The bear's head covers York's head, giving him a fierce appearance. As York leaps about and chants in time with the Crow drums, we see the sparks and flames of the fire reflected in a CLOSE SHOT of York's eyes. The drums and otherworldly chanting grow louder and louder.

FADE TO BLACK.

FADE IN:

EXT. CORPS CAMPSITE-ACROSS THE RIVER FROM THE MANDANS-MORNING-1804

York, half-dressed and exhausted, wanders into camp as the men eat breakfast. Some of the Crew begin to laugh and cheer. York still has the remnants of red paint high on his forehead; he doesn't know this.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(coming to the door of his
tent)
That's enough of that...control yourselves!
You're soldiers, not tavern scum.

York crosses by Clark's tent and Clark, from inside the tent, sees him.

CLARK
(chilly calmness)
York...come in here, please.

York hangs his head and enters slowly.

CUT TO:

INT. CLARK'S TENT-SAME

Clark is at a folding camp table, is making journal entries and is constantly looking back and forth in reference to his map, which is spread out before him.

CLARK
York, you're not the only member of this expedition who took liberties with the native women last night. I'm not here to judge anybody on that score. Just be careful you don't get yourself all poxed up before we reach the Western Ocean.

At this last comment, York raises his eyebrows and, genuinely scared, looks down at the area below his belt.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

CLARK (cont'd)
(now facing York)
What I can't have, is you running off without permission every time some heathen savage wants you to roger his wife. The next time it happens, I will consider you absent without leave...and you will be punished. Do you understand?

YORK
(apologetic)
Yes sir.

CLARK
Good. I've always been a kind master to you and you've never wanted for anything. All I ask is for a simple *by your leave* when you have a mind to go off some place.

YORK
Yes, you've been very good to me, William.

CLARK
(now stares at York long and hard)
What's that on your forehead?

York reaches up and touches his forehead; looking at his hand, he sees red paint. A wave of guilt washes over him.

YORK
(embarrassed)
Oh. Those Crows were really carrying on last night and one of them painted my face for fun.

CLARK
Don't get too familiar with them. Some of them are not to be trusted. Besides, we're not painted savages...we're white men.

Clark catches himself and stammers quickly in an attempt to correct his mistake.

CLARK (cont'd)
What I mean to say is, we are not a bunch of godless pagans.

YORK
Of course.

CLARK
Now, go get yourself cleaned up and get some breakfast.

York turns to go, but Clark, still looking down at his work, remembers something else and stops him at the door.

CLARK (cont'd)
Oh, and York...?

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

YORK
Yes, Captain?

CLARK
After breakfast, you need to clean the
fleas out of my bedding...they've become a
horrible nuisance.

York's eyes grow hard for a moment as he stares at the opening in
the tent. He pauses for several seconds before answering.

YORK
Yes sir.

CUT TO:

EXT. CAMP-MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-SAME-DUSK

The CAMERA shows the Crew gathered around the campfire, drinking
coffee and telling stories after dinner. Clark stands at the
entrance to his tent and looks out over the camp. He sees York
sitting by himself near the riverbank. Just as Clark decides to
go and speak to his friend, Drouillard approaches York and sits
down beside him. Clark retreats back into his tent.

DROUILLARD
You still worn out from last night?

YORK
(ignoring Drouillard
question)
Back home, dusk was my favorite time of the
day. All the work was done and I could slip
off and visit my wife.

DROUILLARD
I didn't know you were married.

YORK
Yeah, I'm married. As married as a *slave*
can be. It's nothing like with white folks.

DROUILLARD
Something bothering you?

YORK
I used to think I was the luckiest man in
the world. I got to be with my best friend
night and day. What man wouldn't want that?
(beat)
We wore the same clothes, ate the same food
and traveled in the same circles. I dunno,
as I got older, I realized that I was
foolin' myself. I didn't have any choice
about any of those things...I was a slave.
But you know what, George? The friendship
was still enough.

DROUILLARD
Still enough for what?

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

YORK

Still enough to make me believe that I was the luckiest man alive. All of the trappings didn't mean squat. But the friendship...that meant something. It was real.

DROUILLARD

Why think about it now? Nothing's changed. The Captain really likes you.

YORK

I care about him too. Love him like a brother. That's not the problem.

DROUILLARD

Well, what then?

YORK

What do I do when the friendship isn't enough anymore?

Drouillard is a little perplexed on how to answer.

DROUILLARD

My friend, never think that freedom is something that someone can give you. Freedom is inside of you. That's a dangerous bit of news for any slave. But I'll tell you this, I think some day you may have to decide between friendship and freedom.

YORK

(introspective)
I'm just afraid that when the time comes, there won't be any choice left to make.

FADE OUT:

FADE IN:

INT. MEXICO CITY-VICEROY'S PALACE OFFICE-1804-DAY

SUPERIMPOSE: MEXICO CITY, MEXICO PALACE OF THE SPANISH VICEROY, JOSE' DE ITURRIGARAY

The VICEROY is a striking man in his 40s; well-built with olive skin and jet black hair; he exudes Latin machismo. He wears a crisp white shirt and tight blue military trousers tucked into black knee-high cavalry boots. The Viceroy is enjoying a meal with 3 SPANISH GENERALS, all in their 40s.

A MILITARY MESSENGER is escorted into the room by the VICEROY'S SERGEANT AT ARMS. As the Military Messenger enters the dining room he shows the Viceroy a note. The meal quickly comes to a halt as if they have been anticipating this message and its contents. The Military Messenger bows and exits.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

The Viceroy reads the note and is expressionless as he tosses it absently towards his Generals; he walks towards the window sill in deep concentration.

GENERAL #1

(reading the note; in Spanish)

This is a communication from the American General,

(now in English)

Wilkinson. He is one of our most trusted double-agents. Apparently the American President has gone through with his plans to explore the West.

VICEROY

That does not surprise me. Nothing the Americans do surprise me.

(getting more irritated)

Americans are greedy. Always wanting more and more.

(starts to map out his words on the window)

First the colonies, then the land near the Mississippi River, and now what is on their plate? Hmm?

(beat)

The West? Texas? Mexico? How about my wife and my children?

GENERAL #1

Excellency, the Americans must be stopped, but in doing so we might start a war?

VICEROY

So.

(beat)

We're going to fight them eventually...their boldness all but guarantees it.

(beat)

Do you think that I am afraid of a country of thieving vultures?

(waving his hand back and forth)

No.

(pointing and tapping the window sill)

I will not permit a single American to trespass on our lands.

GENERAL #1

What do want us to do?

VICEROY

(thinking)

Send three companies of cavalry north; tell them to find these

(laughs indignantly)

brave explorers.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

GENERAL #2

(unsure)

And when they find them...then what?

The Viceroy stares vacantly out his open window. He reflexively removes a piece of dirt from the window pane and examines it absently while rubbing his thumb and index finger together.

VICEROY

(without emotion)

Kill them.

The GENERALS sit in stunned silence. No one dares to disagree.

VICEROY (cont'd)

Have them take some Comanches with them.
Tell them to let the Indians do most of the
killing; that way we can blame it on the
savages.

The Viceroy continues to stare out the window.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-1804-MORNING

The Crew finish the building of FORT MANDAN. A crowd of MANDAN INDIANS look on as the Crew labors in the final phases of construction. The CAMERA shows a double-row of huts surrounded by 18 foot outer walls with pointed logs, a gate house and platform-mounted cannon.

CUT TO:

INT. MAIN ROOM-SAME-FORT MANDAN-DAY

The Crew assembles in the newly-finished common room of the fort. Merriweather Lewis addresses them.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

This fort will be our home for the next five months. We will use this time to collect information from the natives, fortify our food stores, and make all necessary preparations for our departure in the Spring. Captain Clark and I expect you to conduct yourselves like soldiers. We also encourage you to make friends with the Mandans. But, always remember that we are their honored guests and behave accordingly. We simply cannot afford any bad feelings or hostilities at this stage of our journey. Any questions?

(looks around)

No? Excellent.

FADE TO:

EXT. FORT MANDAN-1804-LATE FALL-DAY

The CAMERA shows the Crew and the MANDAN INDIANS taking part in everyday chores and activities together. Several Privates collect wood and water while SGT. PRYOR looks on. A MANDAN INDIAN FAMILY shows a group of Privates how to prepare hides for clothing. Sgt. Gass oversees some of the Crew as they clean their weapons. The CROW INDIAN GIRL walks hand in hand with YORK, pointing out different plants and roots. The Captains confer together over their journals and maps.

OLD YORK (VO)

As we settled in for a long, hard winter, we made use of our idle time by being neighborly with the Mandan. Often, we would repair their cookin' tools and in exchange for beans and venison. We really didn't do it so much for the food as we did to be friendly, I guess. The boys didn't mind the natives...we were happy to have them so close by. They were mighty sociable and you could say the crew took full advantage of their...well...shall we say, *hospitality*.

The CAMERA shows 2 INDIAN GIRLS excitedly leading 2 PRIVATES into an adobe lodge.

CUT TO:

INT. CAPT. LEWIS' ROOM-FORT MANDAN-1804-NIGHT

Merriweather Lewis is partly obscured by the bare behind of a PRIVATE with venereal disease. Merriweather Lewis has a medicine bottle in one hand as he examines the "lower extremities" of the V.D. Private.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

(disapproving, as if
lecturing a small child)

Now then, this salve of Mercury will kill the infection, but continuing to have relations with the native women will only have you back in here again. Do you understand? Now...how many more are out there?

The door to Merriweather Lewis room opens to reveal 15 Privates and Crew in line, all holding their genitalia and in obvious pain. Merriweather Lewis looks expressionlessly at the line.

CUT TO:

INT. CAPT. LEWIS' ROOM- FORT MANDAN-SAME-NIGHT

After the last Private with V.D. leaves Merriweather Lewis' room, the door opens and Clark enters the room, looking embarrassed and looks down at his privates. Merriweather Lewis gives Clark a knowing smirk.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)
Well, I can make the observation from a medical standpoint that this condition does not discriminate between *officers and enlisted men*.

The door shuts.

CUT TO:

INT. CAPT. LEWIS' ROOM-FORT MANDAN-SAME-NIGHT

The CAMERA shows Merriweather Lewis seated at a makeshift desk with a quill writing a letter.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (VO)
Fort Mandan, one thousand six hundred and nine miles above the entrance of the Missouri River. Dear mother. The near approach of winter, the low state of the water and the known scarcity of timber which exists on the Missouri for many hundreds of miles, determined my friend and companion, Captain Clark and myself to fortify ourselves and remain for the winter in the neighborhood of the Mandans, who are the most friendly and well-disposed savages that we have yet met with. Give yourself no uneasiness with respect to my fate, for I assure you that I feel myself perfectly safe. And the only difference between three or four thousand miles and a hundred and thirty, is that I cannot have the pleasure of seeing you as often as I did, while in Washington. Your loving son, Merriweather Lewis.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. FORT MANDAN-WINTER-1804-DAY

The river is almost completely frozen and the ground is covered with three inches of snow. The CAMERA shows cottonwood trees EXPLODE from the ice freezing inside of them. Overhead, FOWL of all sorts fly past the village.

OLD YORK (VO)
Winter came early that year on the Northern Plains. By November, ice had formed on the river. Water froze in some of the cottonwood trees, shattering them from within with a sound like cannon fire. The wind never seemed to stop blowing and the temperature dropped lower and lower. It was the coldest winter I had ever known...or ever care to again, for that matter.

(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

OLD YORK (cont'd)
But even on the coldest of days, we looked forward to celebrating the birth of our Savior, and our hearts were warmed by fond memories of home.

CUT TO:

INT. FORT MANDAN-WINTER-1804-DAY

SUPERIMPOSE: CHRISTMAS DAY, 1804

The CAMERA shows a PANORAMIC SHOT of the Crew celebrating Christmas in typical, early 19th Century fashion. We see and hear some of the Crew singing Old English Christmas carols while Cruzatte and SEVERAL IMPROMPTU MUSICIANS, both white and Indian, play a musical accompaniment. Tables are laden with festive foods of all kinds. The Mandans and Crows mix freely with the CORPS. Some of the Crew dance with each other and 25 INDIAN WOMEN. York sits on a barrel in the corner of the room, surrounded by INDIAN CHILDREN; he hands out handmade toys that he has carved out of wood.

Clark moves about the room, jovially distributing presents of yellow silk handkerchiefs. Merriweather Lewis carves a huge goose as a hungry crowd looks on.

OLD YORK (VO)
We celebrated our first Christmas West of the Mississippi with the same good cheer you'd expect from a huge family gathering.

CUT TO:

INT. LARGE MANDAN LODGE-NIGHT-SAME

The MANDAN TRIBE performs a "Buffalo Dance" while the Captains and Crew look on.

CLARK
Lewis, do you believe in this sort of paganism? I mean, do you think this dance will actually bring buffalo to the Mandan hunting grounds?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
I'm not sure,
(enthralled by the dance)
but I think what matters most to these people is that *they* believe. Like the times when you have prayed just before a battle. Does it matter to you if God really hears you or that you feel in your heart that he is listening to you?
(smugly)
The mind, my dear friend, loves to be convinced of certain matters.

CUT TO:

EXT. FORT MANDAN-WINTER-1805-DAY

The plains across the river from the fort are covered with buffalo as far as the eye can see. The Mandan Indians gather excitedly on the riverbank. Merriweather Lewis watches the immense herd with his spyglass just outside the gates. Clark stands at his side.

CLARK
Well, that's convincing.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(bewildered, shaking his
head)
Fascinating.

FADE OUT:

FADE IN:

INT. FORT MANDAN-WINTER-1805-DAY

The CAMERA shows the entire Crew in various states of boredom in the main room of Ft. Mandan. There are no Indians present. A PRIVATE watches ice melting from a corner of the inner roof. The water dripping off the ice is audible in the silent room. Sgt. Pryor and Sgt. Ordway stand silently staring out the window. PVT. THOMPSON, the cook, serves Sgt. Gass, who is sitting at the table, a plate of elk. Sgt. Gass takes a bite of the elk and pushes his plate away disgustedly.

Merriweather Lewis is asleep at the same table, seated with his head buried in his arms. Clark is pointing out things to York on his panoramic map. The rest of the Crew sit, stand and lay in various positions of repose; for the most part, they either sleep or stare at each other, stupefied by the monotony.

Suddenly an OLD INDIAN WOMAN rushes into the room from the outside. She is distressed; all eyes are on her. Merriweather Lewis jerks violently awake, sensing trouble. The Old Indian Woman looks imploringly at Merriweather Lewis .

CUT TO:

INT. MANDAN LODGE-SAME

Merriweather Lewis , Clark, York, Drouillard and the Old Indian Woman enter the lodge to find an INDIAN GIRL, 17, pregnant and attempting to deliver her baby without success. This is SACAGAWEA. She is in excruciating pain and sweating. She looks wildly at them, desperation and fear all over her face. Beside her is a SECOND OLD INDIAN WOMAN, comforting her through the ordeal. Her husband, TOUSSAINT CHARBONNEAU, stands nearby. Charbonneau is a French Canadian fur trader, 45, but looks much older due to hard living and exposure to the elements. He is stocky, bewhiskered, and dirty.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(kneeling down and feeling
SACAGAWEA'S forehead)
(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)
She's burning up. She's not going to
survive if we don't do something for her
soon.

At this statement, Charbonneau lets out a sob, startling the
Captains. They notice him for the first time.

CLARK
(abruptly)
You're not one of ours, are you?

CHARBONNEAU
(in English with a thick
French accent; trying to
stifle his sobs, he reveals
a mouthful of rotting teeth)
I am Toussaint Charbonneau. I have been
trapping and trading in this territory
since 1796. My intention was to present
myself at your fort in the morning.
(beat)
This is my wife, Sacagawea. Can you help
her?

CLARK
(softening)
My apologies for being so abrupt with
you...didn't expect to meet any white men
this far west. I'm Captain William Clark,
United States Army. If anyone can help your
wife, Captain Lewis here can.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
How long has your wife been in labor,
Charbonneau?

CHARBONNEAU
According to these women, about two days.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
My God.
(beat)
I hope we can at least save her. York!

YORK
(from the entrance to the
lodge)
Yes Captain?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Go get me the bottle of crushed rattlesnake
rings from my medical box in my quarters.
The bottle is clearly labeled. Be quick!

Merriweather Lewis looks around the lodge and sees a pot boiling
on the fire in the center of the lodge.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)
(to Charbonneau)
Is that water boiling?

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

CHARBONNEAU

Yes, mon Capitain, it is.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Good. When York gets back, we'll make a broth out of the rattlesnake rings. It isn't much, but it's the only thing I know of that might induce her to give birth.

CHARBONNEAU

(hopeful)

You have seen this remedy work before, mon Capitain?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

(apologetic)

No, I have not. I have been trying to learn the medical remedies of the natives...I obtained the rattlesnake rings from one of the tribal elders a few months ago. He suggested several uses for the stuff, and this was one of them. (becoming authoritative again) How old is this girl, Charbonneau?

CHARBONNEAU

She's seventeen. This is our first child. Together, I mean. I have several others with my other wife.

CLARK

(amused)

Two wives? Most men can't handle one. What's your secret?

CHARBONNEAU

Distance. I keep the other one fifty miles away with the Hidatsas. Sacagawea lives here.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

(wiping sweat from
Sacagawea's forehead with
his handkerchief)

Sa-ca-ga-we-a. Is that a Mandan name?

CHARBONNEAU

No. She's Shoshone. She was taken prisoner by a Hidatsa raiding party when she was twelve. They sold her to me.

The Captains exchange a bemused look at this revelation. Before either of them has a chance to comment, York rushes in carrying a medicine bottle. For the first time, he approaches the sickbed.

YORK

(handing LEWIS the bottle and
looking tenderly at
Sacagawea)

I hope I didn't take too long.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (3)

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Not at all, York. Well done.

SACAGAWEA
(in Shoshone; crying out to
no one in particular as she
sees York for the first
time)
Look! They have brought me the medicine
man! I must be dying!

As Sacagawea sinks back into her bed of hides, York and the Captains instinctively look to Charbonneau for an explanation of her words.

CHARBONNEAU
She seems to think your Negro is some sort
of angel of death. (to York) No offense,
monsieur.

CLARK
And here I thought I was the only one who
had that effect on women.

York looks embarrassed and steps back into the shadows. Merriweather Lewis has located a tin cup and is stirring the medicinal broth with his hunting knife.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(as he feeds the bitter
liquid to Sacagawea)
Gentleman, if you have any sort of
relationship with the Almighty, now would
be a good time to pray. I have no idea
whether this will do one bit of good or
not.

Sacagawea sinks into an eerie calmness. The occupants of the lodge watch her with anxiety.

CUT TO:

EXT. MANDAN WIGWAM-SAME

A crowd of MANDAN INDIANS and Crew gathers outside the lodge. They whisper among themselves. As York exits the lodge, the group grows quiet and all eyes look to York for answers. York shakes his head sadly.

YORK
It's in God's hands now. Captain Lewis has
done all he can for her.

Suddenly, from inside the lodge, Sacagawea lets out a bloodcurdling FEMALE SCREAM. The crowd outside stares at the lodge in stunned silence. After several seconds, the distinct crying of an infant is heard. The CROWD smiles.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

FADE OUT:

FADE IN:

INT. FORT MANDAN-WINTER-1805-DAY

SUPERIMPOSE: TWO WEEKS LATER

The Sergeants have assembled the Crew in the main room of the fort. The CORPS stands in formation. Merriweather Lewis and Clark face the men. Charbonneau and Sacagawea, baby in arms, stand next to the Captains.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Gentlemen, meet Toussaint Charbonneau and his family. This is his wife, Sacagawea, of the Shoshone Nation. (turning to Charbonneau) What does her name mean, Charbonneau?

CHARBONNEAU

(flustered; pauses and thinks)

Her name means, *Little Bird Woman*, I think.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Little Bird Woman...that's very beautiful.
(looks fondly at the baby)
And have you decided what to name this fine boy?

CHARBONNEAU

(proudly)

I will call him, *Jean Baptiste*, after the cousin of Our Savior.

Merriweather Lewis produces an American Flag and turning towards Sacagawea, holds out his arms to take the baby. She reluctantly surrenders the child; Merriweather Lewis wraps the infant in the flag.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

(presenting the flag-wrapped infant to the Crew)

Men, please welcome the newest *citizen of the United States of America*, Jean Baptiste Charbonneau!

The Crew clap and cheer. Not knowing exactly what is going on, Charbonneau and Sacagawea manage to look both happy and worried at the same time. The cheers die down.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)

(to the Corps)

Charbonneau and his wife have been hired on as interpreters. We expect to meet the Shoshones this summer. Oh, and another thing...the baby is coming with us too. You will all be held responsible for the well-being of both mother and child.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

The Crew don't quite know what to make of this challenge.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)
That is all. Oh, wait...there is one more thing. In honor of our new companions and the birth of Jean Baptiste, there will be an extra ration of whiskey for all hands following the evening meal. Dismissed.

The Crew is silent for a moment and then lets out a thundering cheer.

FADE TO:

EXT. NORTH PLATTE RIVER-1805-WINTER-DAY

SUPERIMPOSE: THE NORTH PLATTE RIVER NEAR PRESENT DAY NEBRASKA

150 SPANISH CAVALRYMEN wearing tall shakos and long gray overcoats with white belts crisscrossing across their chests sit their horses at the edge of the North Platte River. They are accompanied by 10 fierce-looking COMANCHE WARRIORS.

The SPANISH MAJOR, 40, thickly-mustached and a burly bear of a man, confers with his LIEUTENANT, 30, tall, thin, and arrogant. The SPANISH MAJOR has no taste for his mission; the Lieutenant is cold-blooded and calculating. The Spanish Major does not like his subordinate and the bad feelings are mutual. The two stand over the charred remains of what was once a huge campfire. A pile of antelope and buffalo bones is scattered on the ground near the blackened wood.

SPANISH LIEUTENANT
We have missed them!

SPANISH MAJOR
(caustic)
You think so?

SPANISH LIEUTENANT
What do you intend to do?

SPANISH MAJOR
I intend to go home. We can resume this fool's errand in the Spring...

The Spanish Major disgustedly kicks at a half-burned log, turning the snow black with soot. The Spanish Lieutenant purposefully turns his back on his superior, and mounting his horse, rides over to the waiting Spanish Cavalrymen. The Spanish Major, lost in thought, doesn't even notice that the Lieutenant horse has kicked snow up on him. He shivers with cold.

CUT TO:

EXT. SPANISH VICEROY'S PALACE-STUDY-1805-DAY

The Viceroy is sitting alone by his fireplace, seemingly mesmerized by the dancing flames.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

He holds a large, smoldering cigar, forgotten for the moment. One of his AIDES comes to the doorway and shakes his head, signifying "No".

SPANISH AIDE

I am sorry, your Excellency. They missed the expedition.

VICEROY

(dismissive)

You are forgetting something, Febo.

(beat)

Eventually ...the Americans have to turn around and go back home.

The Viceroy looks at his cigar as if seeing it for the first time; he takes a deep, reflective puff of the cheroot and tilting his head back, exhales a huge cloud of smoke skyward.

FADE OUT:

FADE IN:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-1805-MORNING

The Crew prepares the keel boat, four dugout canoes and two small keel boats, or "pirogues" for the next stage of the journey. The entire MANDAN INDIAN TRIBE as well as a CROW CONTINGENT assemble on both sides of the river to see them off. The Captains and Chief Big White exchange good-byes on the shore. Merriweather Lewis now has a passable knowledge of the Mandan language.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

(in Mandan)

We owe you much thanks.

CHIEF BIG WHITE

(in English)

Whenwillyou...return, my friend?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Before you see the next cold.

CHIEF BIG WHITE

Good. May the winds be with you.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

And you.

CLARK

(signing and speaking
haltingly in Mandan to Big
White)

Good-bye, my kind friend. I will look forward to the happy time when we will meet again.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

(surprised)

Why, William, how poetic. I didn't know you had it in you. And in Mandan, no less.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

CLARK

Well, I guess you could say my time with the local girls was time well spent.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Oh, I see...language lessons...that's what you were up to all those nights...who would have guessed?

CUT TO:

EXT. KEEL BOAT DECK-1805-SAME

York is tending to the prairie dog in the cage. Charbonneau and Sacagawea approach York. Sacagawea is holding a magnificent tanned buffalo robe.

YORK

Easy, little one. You're going to be all right. I might not be going back with you, but they'll feed you and such. I'll make sure of it. And you tell President Jefferson that ol' York and the Corps will be back by next year.

York notices Sacagawea and Charbonneau.

YORK (cont'd)

Hello Toussaint. Hello Little Bird Lady. What's this?

CHARBONNEAU

Monsieur York, my wife wants to give you this fine buffalo robe as a gift.

YORK

(touched, as he strokes the long soft fur)
It's beautiful. That's mighty kind of her. I don't know what to say...

CHARBONNEAU

(proud)
She worked all winter on the hide and wants you to send the robe back east to your woman.

YORK

(to Sacagawea)
Tell her I thank her kindly. Sarah will truly enjoy the gift.

SACAGAWEA

(slowly)
Sar-ah.

York smiles.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

YORK
That's right Little Bird Lady...Sarah.

Sacagawea, handing the robe to York, puts her right hand over her heart.

SACAGAWEA
(smiling)
Sar-ah...wife...good.

CUT TO:

Sacagawea and Charbonneau leave the keel boat and York, after carefully folding the buffalo robe, resumes saying goodbye to the prairie dog. Cpl. Warfington and five crew members prepare to shove off and set sail down river.

CPL. WARFINGTON
York...it's time. Leave that little friend
of yours alone. I'll take good care of him.
(beat)
I just hope we don't get too hungry. He
might make a good critter stew.

York looks at PVT. MCNEAL and Pvt. McNeal shakes his head "no" to assure York that Cpl. Warfington is just joking.

YORK
Warf, would you do me a favor?

CPL. WARFINGTON
Sure York...what is it?

YORK
Would you see to it that this buffalo robe
finds its way to the Clark family farm in
Clarksville? Tell Miss Rosa that it's a
gift for York's wife, Sarah. She'll know
what to do.

CPL. WARFINGTON
Clarksville...Miss Rosa...gift for Sarah. I
reckon I can handle that, York.

YORK
Much obliged.

Clark, stands up in his pirogue (a small keel boat).

CLARK
Corporal Warfington,
prepare to set sail.

CPL. WARFINGTON
Aye aye, Captain.
(yells to the keel boat crew)
Prepare to set sail. Launch!

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

As the fog rises off the river the keel boat sets sail homeward. The 6 smaller craft move in to the center of the river in preparation for their departure in the opposite direction.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-1805-DAY

OLD YORK (VO)

The Captains sent the keel boat back to Saint Louis so that President Jefferson could chart the progress of our expedition. We, in turn, were continuing up the river where there was no telling what we might encounter. We were the first Americans to travel this far west and no one knew what to expect. We had no maps and no landmarks to guide us...only the clouded memories of an old Mandan guide who wanted to travel with us. There was supposed to be a big waterfall a day and a half ahead of us, and after that, a mountain range. The Captains figured we'd be through the falls and the mountains in about two weeks time, maybe even less. After that, they envisioned a straight and easy path to the great western ocean. Funny how things don't always turn out the way you want them to. As I watched the keel boat disappear behind us, I was sad. A part of me wished I was going back with Warf and the rest...back to the only home I'd ever known and a wife I could barely remember. Even though I didn't have a choice in the matter, I told myself that my place was with William.

CUT TO:

York looks back at the Mandan Indians and Crow Indians standing on the river bank.

OLD YORK (VO)

Besides, I couldn't wait to return to Fort Mandan and see all of my new Indian friends again...especially one of the pretty young girls that I had become very close to.
(Chuckles)

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-1805-DAY

The CAMERA shows a line of INDIAN WOMEN of all ages, some are weeping; all are sad. The CAMERA focuses on the Crow Indian Girl. She cries the hardest and loudest. York makes lasting eye contact with this girl.

OLD YORK (VO)

Thing is, I knew I couldn't think about the good times I'd had with all my new friends...at least not now, anyway.

(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

OLD YORK (cont'd)

There was work to be done. I had to think about my duty to William. (pauses) I *had* taken a real shine to little baby Jean Baptiste, who Captain Clark had taken to calling Pomp, or Pompy and his devoted mother, Sacagawea. I appointed myself their guardian and protector.

CUT TO:

EXT. CANOE-MISSOURI RIVER-SAME

The CAMERA shows Sacagawea cradling POMP while Charbonneau, York, Drouillard, Sgt. Pryor and 2 PRIVATES man the oars on the scaled-down keel boat. Cruzatte tends to the rudder at the rear of the craft, and manages the small sail. This pirogue is the main supply boat, loaded with food and gear, and is commanded by Clark, who is positioned at the bow.

OLD YORK (VO)

Mostly, I had to protect them from Toussaint Charbonneau, one of the biggest rascals I'd ever met. Even though Charbonneau tried to be a doting father to Pomp and a good husband to Sacagawea, he somehow managed to be a prized jackass most of the time. More often than not, he seemed to have more grog running through his veins than he did blood. Where he got the hootch remains a mystery to me to this day.

Pomp begins to cry. Clark becomes annoyed, but does not voice his displeasure because of his soft-spot for the infant. Sacagawea dips a rag into the water to cool her baby's forehead. At the same time, Charbonneau, who is somewhat intoxicated, stands shakily. Facing the front with an oar in hand, he turns abruptly towards Sacagawea.

CHARBONNEAU

(slurring as he turns)

Give me my son. He needs his papa.

Charbonneau clumsily whacks Sacagawea on the rump with the oar, sending her and Pomp into the river. York immediately jumps into the water to save the baby. The unbalanced craft begins to spin out of control. Clark yells and screams, trying to maintain order.

CLARK

(barking orders at the remaining men)

Steady those oars, get us straight!
Cruzatte, fix that rudder! Damn you,
Charbonneau, I'll have your hide for this!

Charbonneau clumsily attempts to retrieve the oar he has dropped and lurches drunkenly in the process. He stumbles and falls overboard, capsizing the boat. The water is not very deep, but the current is steady. York, who is holding the baby, and Sacagawea look on incredulously from the water. Seaman barks wildly from the bow of Fog rises off the river. ' pirogue.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

Some of the Crew laugh uproariously, but Fog rises off the river. is not amused.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(yelling)
The journals! Save the journals!

Charbonneau flounders in the shallow water.

CHARBONNEAU
(to Capt. Clark)
Mon Dieu! Save me!

Sacagawea recovers the journals and medical supplies, while Clark saves Charbonneau. The other Crew busy themselves righting the boat and saving the other equipment. York has made it to the shoreline and is comforting Pomp.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-SAME

Clark's repacked supply boat glides silently through the water. Clark, York, Sacagawea, Pomp, and the others maintain a meaningful silence. All are drenched and staring straight ahead. The CAMERA pans the boat from front to back revealing a rope tied to the rear of the craft and trailing into the water. As the CAMERA reaches the end of the rope, we see that it is tied to a floating log which is being towed in the skiff's wake. Charbonneau has been lashed to the log, half in, and half out of the water. His pride has been wounded.

CHARBONNEAU
(attempting to sound sober
and official)
Mon Capitain, I must object to this
cruelty.

Clark ignores him

CHARBONNEAU (cont'd)
Mon Capitain, in the name of His
Excellency, Napoleon, the Emperor of
France, I demand to be released from this
unjust bondage and let back into the boat.

Clark ignores him.

CHARBONNEAU (cont'd)
(pleading)
Mon Capitain, please, I beg you. My family
needs me. I am cold and tired.

CLARK
And dangerous. Not another word out of you,
or I'll have you gagged.

Charbonneau rests his head on the log, resigned to his fate.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER EDGE-1805-DAY

SUPERIMPOSE: MONTANA TERRITORY NEAR THE MOUTH OF THE YELLOWSTONE RIVER

The Crew is busy making camp. Approximately 100 yards from the camp, York, Clark and Drouillard, rifles in hand, watch an antelope grazing where the field meets the forest. Drouillard raises his rifle and drops the antelope with one shot. They make their way towards the fallen animal. As they come within 15 yards of the antelope, a massive GRIZZLY BEAR springs from the woods with a terrifying roar. The Grizzly Bear raises up on its hind legs to reveal its full height, bellowing at the 3 stunned hunters. Sensing the men's fear, the Grizzly Bear drops down to all fours and quickly drags the antelope back into the woods.

CLARK
He's got our dinner

DROUILLARD
(in fear)
So? I shot it, and he's welcome to it.

YORK
That's fine with me too!

CLARK
Well, I'm going in there to shoot that bear. I'm not going to order anyone to come with me, but I could use the added firepower. I intend to eat an antelope rib and maybe a bear steak for dinn...(He is cut off midsentence.)

The Grizzly Bear comes charging out of the thicket at the hunters. Drouillard, back-pedaling, falls to his back. Clark fires a quick shot into the bears torso, dropping it.

DROUILLARD
I've never seen anything like it. What a monster! It could've torn my head clean off.

Drouillard prods the Grizzly Bear with the muzzle of his rifle. The BEAR is not dead. Only stunned, it springs to life, madder than ever.

CLARK
Run!

The 3 Privates run back across the field with the wounded Grizzly Bear in pursuit. This commotion now catches the attention of the rest of the Crew. As the 3 Men are running together, York gets an idea.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

YORK
(winded)
William...I'm the fastest runner, you and George break-off and get some more of the boys while I try and keep the bear busy.

The Grizzly is closing rapidly on the runners.

CLARK
After all these years, you still think you're faster than me?

The Grizzly lets out a thunderous roar.

YORK
(breathing heavily)
This is no time for boyhood rivalries.

DROUILLARD
(terrified)
I agree!

Drouillard breaks left, towards the river and camp. York and Clark run together with the BEAR right behind them.

YORK
(out of breath)
Please, William. I'm begging you. Go get the men. You're too important to this expedition to wind up some bear's dinner.

Clark secretly knows that YORK is the faster runner.

CLARK
All right...make some noise and get its attention. I'll have the men waiting by the edge of the camp.

Clark darts right and York stops in his tracks, turns and begins to yell and wave his arms wildly over his head. The Grizzly focuses on York and charges towards him. York turns and proceeds to lead the Grizzly on a zigzag trail around the field. At the edge of the camp, Clark and Fog rises off the river. Organize the men into a makeshift skirmish line. Seaman barks continuously. As York leads the Grizzly Bear closer to the camp, the Crew fire several shots from their state of the art Kentucky Long Rifles, into the side of the enraged beast. The Grizzly then changes direction and charges at the Crew of shooters and the camp.

CLARK (cont'd)
My God, he must have been hit eight times!

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(distracted and amazed)
What a magnificent creature!

The Crew is nervous as the giant Grizzly closes in on them. They struggle to reload quickly. Clark gives the order to fire and the CREW put a volley into the Grizzly at point blank range. The Grizzly's carcass finally drops to the ground.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)
(cheerful and oblivious to
the recent danger as he
prods the dead bear with his
foot)

Good work, men. I bet they've never seen a
hide like this back home. Looks like it
will be bear steak for dinner.

The entire Crew, including Clark, stares at fog rises off the
river. In disbelief as York makes his way back to camp, sweating
and exhausted.

CLARK
That was a really brave thing you did. But
remember, you won't be any good to me dead.

YORK
You'd like that I was dead.

CLARK
Why?

YORK
Well, then you'd finally be the fastest
runner.

Clark and York look like they are about to wrestle, but quickly
realize that people are watching from a distance and revert back
to a military-like decorum. They smile at each other and walk
back to camp.

EXT. THE MISSOURI RIVER-FIRESIDE-NIGHT-SAME

York is enjoying the stars and his freedom for the moment and is
approached by Sacagawea and Charbonneau. Sacagawea speaks to
Charboneau in her native tongue.

CHARBONNEAU
My wife saw what you did with that bear
today. She wants Talking Bear to have this
gift as a sign of his bravery.

Charbonneau looks at Sacagawea and nods, and Sacagawea presents
York with a simple leather thong with 4 grizzly bear claws
attached to it.

SACAGAWEA
Talking Bear, you are now brothers with the
Master of the Forest. Wear his claws close
to your heart and his bravery will always
be inside of you.

YORK
(puzzled)
What did she say?

CHARBONNEAU
She says that this necklace is big medicine
for you.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

York dons the bear claws and Sacagawea smiles.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-1805-DAY

The canoes move upstream against a strong current and high winds. The Crew begins to get pelted with small amounts of blowing sand. Within moments, a full scale SANDSTORM is in progress. Barely able to see or breathe, the Crew members use articles of cloth to cover their faces. YORK leaps out of the canoe. The water comes up to his midsection.

YORK
(to CLARK)
Captain...it's not that deep. I think we
can pull the canoes over there to the rocks
on the far bank.

Seeing that the water is not that deep, 7 Crew members jump into the river and pull the canoes to safety.

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-SAME

The Crew makes it to a bed of rocks and a 6 foot riverbank. Under the direction of the Captains, they unpack the canoes and build a makeshift lean-to using the overturned canoes and the riverbank. Surrounded by the gear and canoes, the Crews remains sheltered for the night as the storm continues to blow fiercely outside.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-1805-DAY

The Crew is back on the river which is bathed in brilliant sunlight. The water is calm and the canoes cut an easy path.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(yelling to Capt. Clark)
We're making excellent progress. If the
weather holds, this old Mandan says we
should reach the big falls in under a week.

EXT. CANOE-MISSOURI RIVER-SAME

Charbonneau is wincing inside Clark's boat.

CHARBONNEAU
Mon Capitain. There is a nice low bank
coming up and I need to answer a call of
nature.

CLARK
Why don't you just jump your filthy carcass
into the water...we'll wait. You could use
a bath anyway...you stink.

CHARBONNEAU
Please, mon Capitain, I cannot empty my
bowels in front of a woman.

(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

CHARBONNEAU (cont'd)
(motions towards Sacagawea)
I appeal to you as one gentlemen to
another.

CLARK
(embarrassed)
All right already. But make it quick or
we'll leave without you.

CHARBONNEAU
(dignified)
Thank you, mon Capitain.

As soon as the pirogue is within swimming distance, Charbonneau rolls off the side like a walrus and swims frantically towards shore. When he gets ashore, the CAMERA shows him moving quickly but awkwardly into the woods.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(furious)
William. Why are we stopping? Where is that
creature going?

CLARK
Charbonneau has to empty his bowels
(sarcastically)
and he's too much of a gentlemen to do it
in front of his wife.

Disgusted, Merriweather Lewis folds his arms and speaks to Sgt. Ordway at his side.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
That Indian woman is as brave as any man on
this expedition. Unfortunately, it has
become apparent to me that her imbecile of
a husband is utterly without merit.

Satisfied groans emanate from the woods.

CUT TO:

EXT. WOODS-SAME

Charbonneau is squatting in a clump of bushes with his underwear bunched around his knees. The CAMERA pans to these articles of clothing. They are crusted and filthy. Small, mite-like bugs are teeming on his underwear and legs, but Charbonneau does not seem to mind. He continues to grunt contentedly. He hears a rustling noise coming from behind a huge evergreen tree nearby.

CHARBONNEAU
(agitated)
Who's there? Seaman, is that you? Can't
you leave a man in peace? You damn dirty
dog...find your own bushes!

The rustling of the evergreen continues. Now angry, Charbonneau picks up a rock and hurls it towards the noise.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

CHARBONNEAU (cont'd)
That will teach you to sneak up on a man
doing his business.
(looks at the tree)
Seaman, come here boy, nice doggie...

Charbonneau throws another handful of rocks.

CUT TO:

EXT. CANOE-MISSOURI RIVER-SAME

The CAMERA shows that Seaman is not in the forest; the dog sniffs the sand and suddenly stops and lifts his head to the wind. Seaman senses danger before anyone else does. Merriweather Lewis and his Crew stare at the woods with boredom and impatience.

Suddenly the ROAR of another GRIZZLY BEAR is heard up and down the shoreline. The Crew grab their muskets and stand at the ready. Charbonneau breaks through the edge of the woods, desperately trying to run and pull his pants up at the same time. He is oblivious to the men watching him. Seeing a cottonwood off to his right, Charbonneau quickly scampers up the tree. A huge BEAR crashes out into the open, but instead of running after Charbonneau, charges directly into the water, swiping at Merriweather Lewis' boat. Merriweather Lewis and his Crew fire, hitting the Grizzly several times, but not before the angry BEAR manages to capsize the canoe containing Merriweather Lewis.

EXT. UNDERWATER-THAT MOMENT-CAPT. LEWIS' POV

Merriweather Lewis falls into the water and can see the Grizzly standing up just feet away from his underwater position. Still fully submerged, Merriweather Lewis hears another muffled volley of musketry as the Grizzly falls into the water turning it deep red. Merriweather Lewis comes up for air. Clark rushes to help him as York comes to the aid of a Private who has been trapped underwater by heavy equipment and the overturned canoe.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-SAME

The Crew silently paddles up the river. Merriweather Lewis' boat pulls along side Clark's craft.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(still exasperated)
William,,, you'll be happy to know,,, that
my curiosity in regards to the great bear
of the western territories...has been fully
satisfied.

The CAMERA pans to the back of the keel boats where we see Charbonneau once again floating behind on his "punishment log". The boats glide silently on the tranquil water into a beautiful sunset.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

OLD YORK (VO)
We continued up the river into uncharted territory. The scenery made it easy for me to forget that I was a slave in a life so far away, but I was treated as an equal and it made me feel like a man among men. And I liked that...

CUT TO:

INT. CAPT. LEWIS' TENT-1805-NIGHT

Clark sits at a field desk, ink quill in hand, painstakingly creating a map of their day-to-day discoveries on a large piece of parchment. CAPT. LEWIS stands at Clark's side and nods approvingly at Clark's efforts. Sgt. Ordway stands guard outside the tent's door.

CLARK
Sgt. Ordway.

SGT. ORDWAY
Yessir?

CLARK
Will you go and fetch York, please?

SGT. ORDWAY
Right away, sir.

CUT TO:

INT. CAPT. LEWIS' TENT-SAME

York pokes his head through the tent door.

YORK
You wanted to see me, Captain?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Come in, York. We want to show you something.

York enters the tent and looks down at Clark's map.

CLARK
(to York)
Remember that dry river bed we passed last week? The one where you collected those pretty rocks?

YORK
I sure do. Why?

CLARK
Well look here.

The CAMERA shows a CLOSE-UP of the map and the tributary river that bears the name "York's Dry River".

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

CLARK (cont'd)
 Captain Lewis and I agreed that since we're
 naming landmarks after everyone on the
 expedition, you deserve one too.

Clark stands and holds up the map to YORK'S POV.

CLARK (cont'd)
 (slightly formal)
 Gentlemen, by the power invested in me by
 the President of the United States, I give
 you York's Dry River.

York smiles proudly as Clark hands him the map to view.
 Merriweather Lewis and Clark clap politely. York bows with
 exaggerated pride.

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-FIRESIDE-SAME

York is in his bedroll staring at the multitude of stars in the
 night sky.

OLD YORK (VO)
 That night my heart swelled with pride and
 I dreamt I was tall enough to touch the
 stars.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-1805-DAY

The Crew camps on an island of the Missouri, located directly in
 the middle of a major fork in the river. The Captains are hunched
 over the map, which is laid out on the ground and weighted with
 rocks. The OLD MANDAN INDIAN GUIDE is gesturing wildly and
 speaking in rapid Mandan to Charbonneau, who is struggling to
 understand him. York and Sacagawea are standing nearby.
 Merriweather Lewis is agitated, pacing back and forth and rubbing
 his forehead.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
 (to Charbonneau)
 Damn it, man! What do you mean he doesn't
 remember? Why is he even here? Send him
 back today!
 (to no one in particular)
 Is anything going to go right on this
 glorified sight-seeing tour?

CLARK
 (reassuring)
 Calm down, Merriweather we're not beat yet.

Sacagawea, sensing Merriweather Lewis' despair, begins to
 urgently converse with Charbonneau. Merriweather Lewis is beside
 himself with curiosity over their private conversation and cannot
 contain his impatience.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

(still agitated)

Well? Out with it! What do she say, man?
Tell me before I flog your stinking hide
from here to the Pacific Ocean...wherever
in God's creation that might be!

Charbonneau looks towards Clark for protection.

CLARK

(amused and smiling)

You heard him. Better tell him quickly and
try not to mince your words.

CHARBONNEAU

(stammering and scared)

My wife is starting to remember, but she
cannot be certain. She believes that the
great waterfalls lie on the south branch of
the river.

Merriweather Lewis has become moody and reflective and receives
this information in silence. He squats over the map and looks
down with his head in his hands.

YORK

Captain Lewis, sir?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

(perfectly calm now)

Yes, York. What is it?

YORK

It seems to me that most mountain rivers
run fast, clear and cold. If we're gonna
find this so called Northwest Passage
through the mountains, then the south
branch is probably going to be the way to
go.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

(sulkily)

Tell that to the rest of them. Sergeant
Gass tells me that the men all seem to
think we should take the north branch.

CLARK

(sensitive to Lewis' fragile
condition)

They're good boys, Merriweather. They'll
go wherever we lead them.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

(to all present)

To ascend the wrong stream will not only
lose us the whole of this season, but will
probably so dishearten the party, that it
might defeat the expedition entirely. Oh,
I'm not suggesting they'll mutiny.

(to Capt. Clark)

They are good boys.

(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)
I'm just saying that once they lose hope
and their spirits are broken...we've lost
them forever.

CLARK
Then what do you propose we do?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
William, I feel personally responsible for
this decision. I would bet my life that the
southern route is the way to go, but to
maintain the confidence of the men, I will
do all I can to prove this.

Merriweather Lewis stands and looks towards the north branch of
the river.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)
Tomorrow morning, myself and three men are
going to go north on a scouting trip. I
intend to prove without a doubt that our
success lies with the south branch.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-1805-MORNING

SUPERIMPOSE: THREE DAYS LATER

Merriweather Lewis, Sgt. Pryor, Cruzatte and Pvt. Ruben Fields
are in a canoe making their way back down the north branch of the
river towards the camp. They are spotted by Sgt. Gass. The camp
is stirring and some of the COOKS are making preparations for the
morning meal. From the opposite end of the camp, York and
Drouillard are returning from an early morning hunting trip. They
carry their rifles and an antelope they have shot.

SGT. GASS
(yelling to the camp)
The scouts are coming in! Get the word to
Captain Clark that Captain Lewis and the
scouts have returned!

York and Drouillard leave their antelope with the Cooks and run
to Sgt. Gass' side to view the incoming canoe. They are shortly
joined by Clark who is still dressing. The canoe makes its way
towards the riverbank and the men are helped ashore. While the
others unpack the gear, Merriweather Lewis and Clark walk to the
breakfast fire with York and Sgt. Gass following.

CUT TO:

EXT. CAMP FIRE-SAME

Merriweather Lewis and Clark stand over the fire.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Good, I'm glad you haven't eaten breakfast
yet.

(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)
We've been living on buffalo jerky and I have a taste for some fresh game and a biscuit. Some of Charbonneau's white pudding would be capital right now.

CLARK
(sleepy and irritable)
Merriweather, I don't want to think about chopped buffalo meat and kidneys stuffed into intestines this early in the morning. I take it from your cheerful mood that you have good news?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(reflectively)
Well, yes and no. The good news is, we went forty miles up the north branch and didn't find any waterfall. The bad news is we *didn't find a waterfall*. There is still no way to know for sure which way we should go. I'm cheerful because we made it back alive and I've finally made up my mind. We're going south without any further delay.

CLARK
Good. I've always said there's power in decisions.
(turning back)
Sergeant Gass. Spread the word to break camp after breakfast. We're going south today.

Merriweather Lewis retires to his tent and York and Clark are alone at the fire.

YORK
(trancelike)
William...Last night I had a dream that we went south and found that waterfall. We were standing there and we looked up and there was no end to it. It seemed like God was pouring water out of the sky and in my dream the sky was different colors. It was red and green and yellow and blue.

York appears to be almost in a daze.

CLARK
(scolding, as if to a child)
I don't want you and Drouillard eating those wild mushrooms on your hunting trips anymore...you hear me?

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER'S SOUTH BRANCH-1805-DAY

The party is back under way on the south branch of the Missouri.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

OLD YORK (VO)

We struggled upstream on the south branch for days, stopping only to hunt for fresh game and make camp for the night. The Captains were so sure of their southern choice that they named the north branch the Marias River and considered our path to be the true Missouri. The wind and the current were against us and the Captains were not pleased with our progress.

CUT TO:

EXT. CANOE-MISSOURI RIVER-SAME

Merriweather Lewis is visibly upset by the slow progress the CREW is making.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

William...This is no good. At this rate, we'll be lucky to reach the falls by winter.

CLARK

I agree. Let's go ashore and rest...we're wasting our time.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-SAME

The entire expedition goes ashore.

CLARK

Sergeant Pryor, tell the men we'll rest here for a few hours and eat something.

SGT. PRYOR

Yessir. Permission to send out a hunting party for some fresh game?

CLARK

Permission granted. See to it.

YORK

William...That island out in the middle of the river looks like its got some wild greens. How about I swim out there and get us some for lunch?

CLARK

Well, if you don't think the current is too strong.

YORK

Naw. Its not too strong. I've swum harder currents back home...besides, I'm hot and I'd like a bath and a swim.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

Merriweather Lewis and Sgt. Ordway approach Clark and York.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
William, after my last trip, I developed a real taste for scouting. I'd like to try my hand at it again. The wind and the current are beating us and a scouting party could make better progress on foot than by boat.

CLARK
How many men do you want?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
The same as last time. I'll take Pryor and the Fields brothers.

CLARK
Why not take York too? He's been rowing enough for two men and could stand to stretch his legs a bit. I'm sure he'd jump at the chance to go on a scout.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
I'd be glad to have him. We'll leave after we eat.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER'S SHORELINE-SAME

Merriweather Lewis , York, Sgt. Pryor and the Fields Brothers make their way along the Missouri River's shoreline. Merriweather Lewis keeps up a very fast pace, making it difficult for some of the men to keep up. The terrain is rough at times. The midday sun is hot and relentless. Merriweather Lewis , realizing the men need a rest, halts the party.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
I'm sorry, men, I got a little carried away there. We'll rest here for a few minutes.

RUBEN FIELDS
Do you think it's much further, Captain?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(almost to himself)
They've got to be close.

JOSEPH FIELDS
(under his breath but still audible)
If they're on this fork at all.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Have faith in me, Joseph. I wont let you down.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

JOSEPH FIELDS
(embarrassed)
I'm sorry, Captain. I'm just tired.

York has climbed to a higher elevation approximately 25 yards away and looking upstream. He is distracted by something and has his ear to the wind.

YORK
Captain Lewis...Captain Lewis, come quick!

Merriweather Lewis and the remaining men rush up the hill to where York is standing. They all look at York expectantly.

YORK
(pauses and gestures with his
hand upstream)
There! Can you hear it?

SGT. PRYOR
(out of breath and irritable)
I can't hear anything but my own heart
beating through my chest.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(interested)
What is it, York?

YORK
Listen...it sounds like the wind rustling
thousands of leaves at once. But when the
wind stops blowing the noise is still
there.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(straining)
My God...you're right. I hear it!

The other men also now hear the sounds of the far distant waterfalls and begin to laugh and embrace each other and dance a jig on top of the hill.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)
Well done, York. I knew I made the right
decision bringing you on this scout. Well
done, indeed!

The men continue their impromptu celebration as Merriweather Lewis and York continue to stare off in the direction of the sound.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-SAME

Clark and the rest of the Crew move up the Missouri River towards York, who is standing at a bend in the river. York is waving his arms to signify that the Great Falls lie up ahead. Clark paddles to shore to meet York. A deafening roar fills the air.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

YORK
(excited)
William...William! The falls are just ahead. Captain Lewis is going there on foot.

CLARK
Hurry, get in the boat! Maybe we can beat Lewis to the falls.

York quickly gets into the canoe and they make their way towards the crashing sounds of the waterfall.

CUT TO:

EXT. GREAT FALLS-SAME

Clark and the Crew round a bend where the thundering crash of falling water fills the air. They come into full view of the GREAT FALLS, actually 4 separate waterfalls. Merriweather Lewis is standing on a high bank of the plateau and watches the approaching men as they beach their boats and go ashore.

CUT TO:

EXT. GREAT FALLS EDGE-SAME

The entire Crew stands silently in awe of the falls. 4 levels in all and some 300 yards wide, they are breathtaking. A rainbow appears in the sky. York, standing apart from the group, is amazed at the sight.

YORK
(to himself)
It's beautiful...just like in my dream.

Clark walks up to York very businesslike and snaps York out of his reverie.

CLARK
(clipped tone of voice)
York. Can I speak to you for a moment?

YORK
(startled)
It's beautiful, isn't it, William?

CLARK
(distracted)
That it is. That it is. York...back on the riverbank, when you were waiting for us...you called me *William* in front of the men. Please refrain from doing so in the future. Call me Captain or sir. It's important that we keep up appearances.

YORK
(hurt)
Yes, William...of course. I mean, yes sir, Captain.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

Clark has assumed a purposeful manner, and unlike the others, is more concerned with the logistics of portaging the falls, rather than their beauty.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

My God, it's the grandest sight I have ever beheld. Do you realize, William, that since the commencement of time, civilized men have been denied the sight of these incredible falls?

CLARK

Yes, Lewis, it's quite a sight...it would make a mighty fine painting, but it's gonna make one hell of a portage.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Nonsense. We'll be around it in a day.

Clark is straining to see past the falls and cannot.

CLARK

That may be, but that will be the longest day anyone has ever experienced.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

One day, Clark, one day at the most.

CUT TO:

EXT. GREAT PLAINS-1805-DAY

SUPERIMPOSE: FOURTEEN DAYS LATER

The members of the Crew, hot, sweaty and exhausted, push and pull crude supply carts across the plains; they also haul their canoes overland.

OLD YORK (VO)

Captain Clark was right. Fourteen days had passed and we were only half way across the falls. What was thought to be one great waterfall was actually four separate obstacles. We built crude carts out of cottonwood trees to transport the supplies and boats. The terrain was almost unbearable. The ground was covered with prickly-pear which was akin to walking on pin cushions. There were so many of these sharp and unforgiving plants that stepping on them was unavoidable. Our feet bled and a good pair of moccasins only lasted two days at the most. To make matters worse, Sacagawea had taken ill and nothing Captain Lewis did for her seemed to help. For the first time ever on this journey, many men, including myself, began to despair. We asked ourselves what other hardships we would we have to endure.

(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

OLD YORK (cont'd)
If we only knew the answer to that
question, I wonder if any of us would have
gone on.

CUT TO:

EXT. GREAT PLAINS-SAME

The Crew continues to push the carts. The CAMERA shows the sweaty men struggling with their burdens; their hands and feet are bloody, calloused and wrapped in rags. Their clothes are dirty and ripped. Overall, they look gaunt and exhausted. Sgt. Pryor pushes from behind the last cart in line. He loses his footing and falls to the ground on his shoulder, dislocating it. He lies on the ground writhing in pain.

SGT. PRYOR
(crying out in pain)
My shoulder! My shoulder!

The Captains and York come over and tend to Sgt. Pryor. The men are so exhausted that Sgt. Pryor's injury barely stirs them. They take advantage of the halt to fall down where they stand in various stages of exhaustion.

PVT. TUTTLE sits down on a fallen log and is bitten by a rattlesnake on the ankle. Pvt. Whitehouse, overcome with heat exhaustion, passes out in his place. The CAMERA shows that he is convulsing and sweating profusely due to a high fever; he falls on his side atop a prickly-pear plant that is now stuck in the side of his arm.

25 yards down the trail, York pops Sgt. Pryor's shoulder into place while the Captains hold Pryor down. Pryor screams in pain. From the front of the column, Sgt. Ordway comes running back to Merriweather Lewis .

CLARK
What is it, Sergeant?

SGT. ORDWAY
(out of breath)
Captain Lewis, sir...There's something
wrong with Joseph Whitehouse. He's having
some kind of fit and we can't stop him from
shaking. He's burning up pretty bad sir.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Thank you, Sergeant...I'll be along in a
moment.

Sgt. Pryor still moans in pain.

SGT. ORDWAY
I'm sorry, sir, that's not all.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(impatient)
All right then, what else?

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

SGT. ORDWAY
Private Tuttle's snake-bit.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(agitated)
Very well, Sergeant, have someone bring out
my medical box.

Charbonneau comes over to Merriweather Lewis and hovers over him
like impending doom.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)
Well...what do you want?

CHARBONNEAU
Captain Lewis...It's my wife. She is too
sick to go any further today. If she
doesn't get rest soon, I am worried that
we'll lose her.

YORK
(urgent)
Captain Lewis, Captain Clark...look!

York points to the sky in the distance, where a huge black storm
cloud is moving in over the plains. Thunderclaps are heard.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(visibly upset; he is
speaking outwardly to Capt.
Clark, but is really
speaking to himself)
I won't let this blasted prairie beat us.
Do you hear me? I haven't come this far to
beaten by prickly-pears and snakes. Can
anything else go wrong?

YORK
We best make camp now if we're gonna stay
out of that storm.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(sarcastically)
Really? Thank you for that most astute
observation. Keep it up, and in no time
you'll be a general.

York hangs his head in shock and embarrassment. He attends to
Sgt. Pryor.

CLARK
(sensing that Lewis is on the
verge of losing it)
Merriweather, those sick men up there need
your help. If you'll see to them, I'll have
the men make camp.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(embarrassed and relieved
that he has something to do)
Yes, of course. They need my help.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

Merriweather Lewis departs towards the front of the column.

CLARK

Don't mind him when he gets like that, York...he means well. Men...we'll make camp here. Sgt. Gass, post sentinels and send a party to gather wood and fresh water. Make sure you have the men set up a hospital tent for the sick and wounded. Take care of that right away. Drouillard, take the Fields brothers and York and see if you can't get some fresh game before this storm hits us.

DROUILLARD

Yes sir.

CUT TO:

EXT. GREAT PLAINS-HOSPITAL TENT-SAME

Merriweather Lewis tends to the wounded in the makeshift hospital tent. Crudely, he bleeds Sacagawea in an attempt to rid her of her illness. He puts a tourniquet on Pvt. Tuttle's leg and extracts the snake venom with a primitive suction device. He fashions a sling for Pvt. Whitehouse and bandages the puncture wounds on his shoulder. Thunder is heard in the distance. Then closer. Rain, heavy as lead balls, begins to pelt the tent. Merriweather Lewis looks at the ceiling of the tent nervously.

CUT TO:

EXT. CAMP-GREAT PLAINS-SAME

Hail begins to fall. The hail balls are some 7 inches in diameter. It is a crisis situation.

CLARK

(screaming over the
hailstorm)

Take cover! By any means! Hurry!

Men scramble under carts, buffalo hides, and into the 4 tents that have been erected. The hail grows even more intense. The men who are under cover anxiously watch for the return of the woodcutters and hunters.

SGT. GASS

(from under a cart, yelling
across to CAPT. CLARK who
has yet to take cover)

Here come the woodcutters! Captain Clark,
over to the right!

CLARK

(yelling to the woodcutters)

Drop the wood! Drop the wood! Take cover!

The WOODCUTTERS are assaulted by the hail. They are slipping and falling from the onslaught of ice.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

They drop the wood they have gathered and break for the camp. Some of the men are bleeding from gashes in their heads caused by the hail balls and others have bruises on their hands and arms. They finally make it to cover underneath a cart. Clark runs up to the cart holding a buffalo hide over himself.

CLARK (cont'd)
Have you seen York and the hunters?

PVT. CARSON
Not for at least twenty minutes, sir. The last time we saw them, they were making their way towards a stand of evergreens near the river.

Clark notices PVT. CARSON'S bleeding forehead.

CAPT. CLARK
Come with me, Private. You're injured.

Clark points to Pvt. Carson's forehead. Carson touches his forehead and looks at his finger; he realizes it is blood, not water that he is looking at.

PVT. CARSON
It doesn't hurt...I can't feel a thing.

CLARK
You will tomorrow. Get under this robe and I'll take you to Captain Lewis.

Clark and Carson run towards the hospital tent.

CUT TO:

EXT. GREAT PLAINS-UNDER AN EVERGREEN TREE-SAME

York, the Fields Brothers, and Drouillard are nestled under the shelter of a huge evergreen tree. They are comparatively dry as they watch the storm in awe.

DROUILLARD
(looking back and forth at
the forest around them)
We've come a long way from St. Louis.

YORK
Yeah...we sure have.

DROUILLARD
A man could get lost out here.

YORK
Don't I know it.

DROUILLARD
(looks hard at York)
No...I mean really. A man could get lost in this wilderness and no one would ever find him. There are no slave catchers out here.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

The Fields Brothers look over, but decide to mind their own business.

YORK

What are you gettin' at, George?

DROUILLARD

Freedom. Real freedom. A man like you...good hunter, good woodsman, respected by the Indians...I'd partner up with you anytime. We could set off on our own and be gone a day before they even missed us. Just you and me, huntin' and trappin' and livin' off the land.

YORK

I'd be a liar if I said I never thought about that, George. And coming from you, I take that offer to be quite a compliment. I'd be your partner anytime, too. But you don't understand. It's not like that between me and William. We've been together ever since I can remember and we're loyal to each other...

DROUILLARD

(cutting him off)

You're a slave, damn it! No man has the right to own another man.

YORK

Not in my mind, I'm not. And besides, William made a promise to me a long time ago and I reckon he'll keep it when we get back.

DROUILLARD

(suspicious)

What promise?

YORK

He promised to free me and I 'xpect that he will, especially with all that's happened since we've left. I know he can't help but notice all of the good work I've been doing on this trip, and I think he'll reward me for it.

DROUILLARD

For your sake, I hope he does. But my offer still stands. Anytime you want to go, you come find George Drouillard.

YORK

I just might do that, George, but I've got to do it my way....not until I'm free...

(turns towards Drouillard)

and I know William will free me.

Just that moment, there is a huge thunderclap. Unfazed, Drouillard stares at YORK with knowing skepticism.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

YORK
(wanting to change the
subject)
If this storm lets up, we should make a
break for camp.

RUBEN FIELDS
Why not stay here? This seems like a better
place than most to wait out the storm.

JOSEPH FIELDS
(frightened and trying not to
show it)
I go where my brother goes and stay where
my brother stays.

DROUILLARD
I agree with York. They'll be worrying
about us in the camp.

YORK
They might send somebody out to look for
us. And I'd sure hate to have someone get
hurt on our account.

RUBEN FIELDS
You two go if you want. Joseph and I are
staying here til morning.

20 yards away, a tremendous lightning bolt crashes down,
splitting a tree in two and setting the branches on fire. The
men are visibly shaken and temporarily blinded by the flash.

RUBEN FIELDS (cont'd)
(scared, rubbing his eyes)
Me and Joseph are ready to leave when you
are!

YORK
The hail is letting up...now is as good a
time as any.

The hail turns into rain. The 4 men get to their feet. They begin
jogging towards camp. When the Hunters get within sight of the
camp, the hail begins to fall again, considerably harder than
before. Once again, the ice balls are the size of small apples
and begin to pelt the men.

They are all hit with the hail, but Joseph Fields suffers the
worst. He is knocked down twice by the ice but manages to regain
his feet and continues on. He sustains bloody gashes on his head
and arms. Joseph Fields is dazed and partially blinded by his own
blood. The CAMERA shows a massive piece of hail graphically
striking Joseph Fields in the head, this time knocking him
unconscious.

Drouillard and Ruben Fields are well ahead of the others and do
not realize what has happened to Joseph Fields, but York does and
rushes to his aid. Without hesitation, YORK picks the injured man
up, and effortlessly slinging the unconscious Joseph Fields over
his shoulder, carries him the remaining 50 or so yards into camp.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (3)

Clark and the Crew, still under cover, watch York come in and direct him over to the hospital tent.

CUT TO:

INT. GREAT PLAINS-HOSPITAL TENT-SAME

York enters the hospital tent and gently lowers the now conscious Joseph Fields to the ground at Merriweather Lewis' feet. Merriweather Lewis helps Joseph Fields take a sip of medicinal whiskey. YORK leaves and hurriedly joins Clark under the cart while trying to protect his body from the hail.

CUT TO:

EXT. GREAT PLAINS-UNDER A WOODEN CART-SAME

YORK (cont'd)
Well, I failed you William.

CLARK
(surprised)
How's that, York?

YORK
This is the first time I ever went out hunting and didn't come back with any game.

CLARK
Never mind about that. You brought yourself back and from the looks of it, Joseph Fields is going to be in your debt too. To be honest, I don't think I've ever been happier to see you.

YORK
Well, I sure am happy to be back. It was pure hell out there.

Clark and York continue to watch the hailstorm brutalize the plains.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. GREAT FALLS-1805-DAY

The members of the Crew are pulling the carts through a rainstorm. They are exhausted, wet and cold. Pomp, riding in a papoose on Sacagawea's back, cries louder with every step his mother takes. Sacagawea desperately wants to find shelter for her child and herself. She is still ill and, running a fever, begins to shake. Charbonneau is watching his wife and child with great unease.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(turns to CAPT. CLARK)
This is madness. We can't go any further tonight. This is as good a place as any to make camp. We might be able to find some dry firewood in those woods over there.

(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)

If York and Drouillard can't come up with any fresh game, it's going to be jerky again for supper. And we may have no choice if we can't get a fire going.

CLARK

George, York, go see if you can hunt us up some supper, but don't dare stay out past sunset.

YORK

We'll get something; I don't care if it's squirrel, rabbit or field mouse. Anything's better than that cold, dry jerky.

DROUILLARD

I had a field mouse stew once; tasted just like prairie chicken...

CLARK

Get going, you two, and remember... don't stay out after dark.

Drouillard and York depart for their hunting trip.

CLARK (cont'd)

(to SGT. ORDWAY)

Sgt. Ordway. Have some men see if they can find any dry firewood in that stand of trees over yonder. Tell them to be careful; York and Drouillard are out hunting. Captain Lewis has enough to bear without having to remove any misplaced musket balls.

SGT. ORDWAY

Yes sir, I'll see to it.

A worried looking Charbonneau approaches Clark.

CLARK

What is it, Charbonneau?

CHARBONNEAU

It's my wife, Capitain. She is burning with the fever again and I must get her out of the rain.

CLARK

No need to fret; We're stopping for the night. We'll have our tents pitched in no time.

CHARBONNEAU

You see, that is the problem. The canvass is soaking wet and does not keep out the wind or the rain. With the Capitain's permission, I saw a cave around a half mile back on our trail. It was in a dry creek bed and looked like it would be just the place to stay dry and warm for the night.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

CLARK
(thinking it over)
Well, I don't think it's a good idea. This is unchartered country and I want to keep everyone in camp.

CHARBONNEAU
Please, Capitain, just one night. I could light a fire at the entrance of this cave and we will be quite comfortable.

CLARK
Well, I suppose so. But Sergeant Gass and I are going to come with you and help you get settled. Let me tell Captain Lewis about our plans and you go get your wife prepared to go.

Clark goes to find Merriweather Lewis and Charbonneau rounds up Sacagawea and Pomp. The woman and child are futilely trying to take shelter from the storm by hiding under a buffalo hide. SACAGAWEA is weak with fever; her illness has left her desperate and dejected. Charbonneau tries to comfort his family.

CUT TO:

INT. CAVE-DRY TRIBUTARY OF THE GREAT FALLS-SAME

Clark, Sgt. Gass, Charbonneau, Sacagawea and Pomp are all gathered around the beginnings of a small fire. Charbonneau feeds the fire with small pieces of driftwood found about the cave. The cave is more of a rocky outcrop, due to the fact that is not very deep. It still provides good shelter from the storm. Clark has stayed because of his growing affection for Sacagawea and Pomp and his desire to protect his only link to the Shoshones. Outside, the storm increases in intensity. SGT. GASS goes to the mouth of the cave and surveys the weather.

SGT. GASS
Captain. This dry riverbed ain't so dry anymore. I'd say the water is about six inches high and rising. You'd better come take a look, sir.

Clark joins Sgt. Gass at the cave's entrance and looks outside.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-SAME

The CAMERA shows the Missouri River overflowing its banks. The unchained river cascades towards the dry tributary, crashing into it with incredible force. The land barrier separating the Missouri from the dry tributary collapses under the tremendous pressure. This is a FLASH FLOOD.

CUT TO:

INT. CAVE-GREAT FALLS-SAME

Clark and Sgt. Gass both hear the roar of the flash flood at the same time. Being experienced woodsmen, they both know what this noise means.

SGT. GASS
(scared)
It's a flash flood, Captain.

CLARK
Everybody out of the cave! Now!

Charbonneau quickly starts to pack up their personal gear.

CLARK (cont'd)
Do you want to drown, man? Just grab the rifles!

The party hastily exits the cave. The water is already up to their knees.

CUT TO:

EXT. GREAT FALLS-DRY TRIBUTARY-SAME

Once they exit the cave, they see the flash flood crashing down on them like a tidal wave. They barely have time to rush to some high ground in the middle of the riverbed where there is a stand of trees. This was an island at one time.

CUT TO:

EXT. GREAT FALLS-CAMP-SAME

York and Drouillard are carrying a brace of rabbits and a large raccoon into camp. The Cooks have managed to start a fire under a canvass tarp. The Cooks take the game and begin to butcher it while Merriweather Lewis approaches York under the tarp.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Well done. Another successful hunt...you and George Drouillard have become quite adept at feeding this company.

YORK
Thank you, sir. I do my best.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
York, Captain Clark took the Charbonneaus to find a cave in a dry riverbed about a half mile back along our trail. They thought that Sacagawea would be more comfortable there than in one of these leaking tents. No cause for alarm just yet, but they have been gone for a couple of hours. William has become quite fond of that little baby and probably lost track of time.

(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)
 Why don't you bring them one of those rabbits for their supper and make sure everything is in order? If you'd like, stay the night in the cave, but send Sergeant Gass back so I know everything is in order.

YORK
 I'll leave right away, Captain Lewis.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
 Excellent. Carry on.

CUT TO:

EXT. GREAT FALLS-SAME

York backtracks along the trail; the storm shows no signs of letting up. Soon his pace is slowed considerably by mercilessly high winds and a driving rain. York hears a roar in the distance and, running to the dry riverbed's edge, witnesses the flash flood rolling down the tributary, sweeping everything in its path.

YORK
 (shocked, whispering to himself)
 Great Lord Almighty.

Now worried and desperate, he begins to sprint along the banks of the tributary, yelling out as he goes.

YORK (cont'd)
 (calling out)
 William! William! Patrick!

EXT. TRIBUTARY ISLAND-SAME

The flood has crashed through. The river is now 9 feet high on either side of the island and rushing at a dangerous speed. Clark, Sgt. Gass, Sacagawea, Charbonneau and Pomp, stand on the highest point of the small island in a stand of cottonwood trees as the water continues to encroach on the diminishing land. They have placed Sacagawea and her baby in one of the lower branches of a cottonwood tree.

CLARK
 Sergeant, do you have a coil of rope in your kit bag?

Sgt. Gass looks into his buckskin bag and produces a coil of rope.

SGT. GASS
 Yes sir, I do. I never go anywhere without a bit of rope.

CLARK
 Amen to that. Luckily, I share your affinity for rope, Sergeant.

Clark pulls his own rope out of his kit bag.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

CLARK (cont'd)
It's not too far to that near bank.
There's a stand of cottonwoods over there
that would make a nice anchor for a rope
bridge. But one of us is going to have to
swim for it.

Sgt. Gass prepares to volunteer.

CLARK (cont'd)
Save your breath, Sergeant. I'm the
strongest swimmer here. We'll tie one end
of the rope around this cottonwood tree and
the other end around me as a safety line.
If the current gets the best of me, pull me
back in.

They prepare the safety line as they hear York calling their
names in the distance. Everyone on the island takes up the cry
back to York.

CLARK AND CREW
York! York! We're over here.

YORK
I hear you! I'm coming!

York appears on the newly created riverbank and looks perplexed.

CLARK
(yelling)
York, there's no time to waste! The water
is getting higher by the minute. We're
going to throw you two lengths of rope. Tie
them to that cottonwood tree and make a
rope bridge, just like we use to do back
home.

York needs no further direction. The rope is thrown to him, and
because the gap between the trees is not too severe, he is able
to easily help to construct the rope bridge.

CLARK (cont'd)
Sacagawea and the baby first.

Sacagawea has the baby in a sling carrier and begins to traverse
the raging river. YORK, seeing that she will be off balance with
the baby, yells across to Charbonneau.

YORK
Charbonneau, tell her to stay put and I'll
come for the baby. Have her meet me half
way!

Charbonneau translates the request to his wife. Sacagawea meets
York half way and hands off the baby. Soon York, Sacagawea and
Pomp are safe on the shore.
The other 3 men quickly come across the rope bridge. When all are
across, the entire party and looks back and notices that the
island is almost completely submerged.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

FADE OUT:

FADE IN:

EXT. CAMP-MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-1805-DAY

SUPERIMPOSE: JULY 4TH, 1805, TEN MILES UPRIVER OF THE GREAT FALLS

A clear and pleasant morning greets the CORPS. There is a 4th of July celebration in progress. Pvt. Cruzatte plays the fiddle to everyone's enjoyment. Pvt. Collins and Charbonneau cook a huge elk on a spit. All of the Crew, including Merriweather Lewis, Clark, and York take turns dancing with Sacagawea. Merriweather Lewis dispenses whiskey to the crew from large jugs.

OLD YORK (VO)

We had finally finished our portage around the Great Falls of the Missouri River. What the captains had originally thought would take half a day at most had taken twenty-nine. It being the Fourth of Independence and the end of our journey around the falls, we celebrated all day and long into the night.

EXT. CAMP-MISSOURI RIVER-SAME-NIGHT

Clark and Merriweather Lewis stand by the cart containing the whiskey barrels. They watch the men in their merrymaking. Clark tips a whiskey jug and mere drops fall into his cup as Merriweather Lewis continues to look ahead and suddenly notices the emptied jug.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Well, that's the end of the whiskey.

CLARK

How do you think the men will take the news?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

There will be some grumbling, but they knew this day was coming. Besides, does it matter? We're way too far along now for any of them to even think of deserting...not this deep into the wilderness.

CLARK

(chuckles)

True. Someday you'll be writing books on how to conduct a scouting expedition in the most efficient manner.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

No, Clark. You'll write the chapters dealing with tactics and I'll be consigned to the chapters dealing with whiskey.

They both laugh.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

CLARK

Those mountains to the North and Northwest
of us are entirely covered with snow.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

(listening to Clark and
thinking of other things as
well)

We're way behind schedule.

CLARK

(now becoming serious again)

Do you still intend to send messengers back
to Jefferson?

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

No. Our party is too small as it is and we
can't afford to lose anyone. I think that
if we sent anyone back to Saint Louis at
this juncture, it would discourage the men
who remained...and might possibly hazard
the fate of the expedition.

CLARK

Then I'm glad we never told them that we
were even thinking of sending someone back.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

No, we have never even hinted at it. To me,
they all appear to have made up their minds
to succeed or perish in our attempt.

The CAMERA shows York is sitting off by himself; he has heard the
entire exchange between the Captains. He knows he has heard
something important.

CUT TO:

EXT. CAMP-MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-1805-DAY

The morning after the Independence Day celebration, the CREW are
groggy, hung-over and sleepy. The Sergeants busy themselves by
prodding the Crew into formation. Merriweather Lewis and Clark
stand at the front of the formation and address the men.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Men, I think you all know that we are about
to enter the most perilous and difficult
part of our voyage. So far, no one has
shirked their duties and you all have
remained true to our purpose. Captain Clark
and I are proud of all of you. I ask you to
remain ready to meet the difficulties which
await us with resolution and courage.

CUT TO:

INT. MONTICELLO-INSIDE JEFFERSON'S LIBRARY-1805-DAY

Thomas Jefferson sits on the floor of his library, surrounded by boxes, crates and specimens sent back by Lewis and Clark. He is in awe of everything and examines the finds with great relish. He stops only to occasionally pour over a small copy of Clark's map, which he has spread out on the floor in front him. The only other man in the room is Jefferson's Aide, who is desperately trying to catch the Prairie Dog, which runs amuck all over the study. Thomas Jefferson is so immersed in his investigations that he is oblivious to his Aide's plight. Thomas Jefferson holds up an antelope skull with tremendous antlers.

THOMAS JEFFERSON
Absolutely magnificent. Like a unicorn with two horns.

The Prairie Dog continues to lead Jefferson's Aide on a wild goose chase around the study, screeching and barking angrily all the while. Jefferson's Aide is trying to stay focused on catching the elusive animal while being attentive to his Chief's observations at the same time. He isn't having much success.

JEFFERSON'S AIDE
(Out of breath)
Yes sir. It looks to have been a truly amazing creature. Do you think it was able to fly? I saw a picture in a book once of a horse that had wings.

He continues his hapless pursuit of the Prairie Dog. Thomas Jefferson sets down the skull abruptly and stares hard at his Aide.

THOMAS JEFFERSON
Flying horses? What in heaven's name are you talking about, man?

For the first time, Thomas Jefferson sees that his Aide is struggling to ensnare the little rodent. The Aide has picked up a large butterfly net and has cornered the prairie dog.

THOMAS JEFFERSON
For God's sake...put that net down, man. You're scaring the poor little fellow. You just need to use a little kindness.

Thomas Jefferson grabs a carrot stick off a plate that sits atop his desk and offers it to the Prairie Dog. Without hesitation, the animal immediately becomes docile and eats out of Jefferson's hand. The Prairie Dog allows Thomas Jefferson to pick him up and does not protest when Thomas Jefferson strokes his considerably round underbelly. Thomas Jefferson holds the Prairie Dog out to his Aide.

THOMAS JEFFERSON
Now...be a good fellow and make friends with him.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

JEFFERSON'S AIDE
(appalled)
How shall I go about doing *that*, sir?

THOMAS JEFFERSON
My God man, do you have the brains you were
born with? Pet him.

The Jefferson's Aide hesitates.

THOMAS JEFFERSON (cont'd)
Go on. Give him a little scratch behind his
ear...show him you're his friend.

The Aide shakily extends his arm towards the animal, looking away as he does so. The CAMERA shows his fingers approach the Prairie Dog's dogs furry ear. The rodent begins his angry screeching again and the Aide recoils his hand back in pain.

JEFFERSON'S AIDE
He bit me! The little bugger bit me!

THOMAS JEFFERSON
(unsympathetic)
He doesn't like you, and I fear he never
will. A pity. Go get your hand looked at;
I'd like to continue my studies in peace.

The Aide is holding his finger and turning red with anger.

JEFFERSON'S AIDE
Very well, sir. Will that be all?

THOMAS JEFFERSON
Yes, that is all. And when you're done
getting your finger dressed, bring some
more carrots...my little friend here seems
to enjoy them immensely.

The Aide storms out of JEFFERSON'S LIBRARY. Thomas Jefferson effortlessly places the Prairie Dog back into its wooden cage and continues to look at the map.

THOMAS JEFFERSON (cont'd)
(speculatively; to the
Prairie Dog)
They should be to the Western Ocean by now.
Imagine that. What do you think, sir?

The Prairie Dog screeches violently at Thomas Jefferson through the bars of the cage.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-1805-DAY

Back on the river, the Crew struggles with hard currents and buffeting winds. They look miserable.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

OLD YORK (VOW)

August had come and we were nowhere near the Western Ocean. Everything that could go wrong had done so.

As York enumerates the problems that have befallen the expedition, the CAMERA shows a MONTAGE of the events.

OLD YORK (VOW) (cont'd)

We ran out of fresh meat and were unable to find game. We were living on tough buffalo jerky and whatever greens we could scrounge up. The crew was becoming lame. The men had boils, bruises, sprains and sores. One man dislocated his arm. Captain Clark's ankle had become infected from prickly pear punctures and was so swollen that he could not walk. At night, he burned with fever. George Drouillard, my good friend and hunting companion, fell, injuring his fingers and leg. The lines we used to tow the canoes often snapped without warning and the canoes capsized in the strong currents. Joseph Whitewash was nearly crushed between some rocks and his boat, but we saved him from drowning. The men were exhausted and wanted to abandon the river and make the trip by land. The only good news we had in weeks was that Sacagawea was starting to recognize the terrain. She told us that we were not far from the summer camp of her people, which we should find beyond a large hill on a river that runs west. Her people called this hill the Beaver's Head. Finally, on a day that no one expected to find anything but more suffering, we spotted the rock formation known as the Beaver's Head in the distance. We now knew that we were on the right path and that lifted our spirits immensely.

CUT TO:

EXT. CAMP-THREE FORKS OF THE MISSOURI RIVER-1805-NIGHT

The men sit and lay around the fire in the early evening. YORK sits near Clark, who has a makeshift crutch and his right ankle heavily bandaged. Merriweather Lewis emerges from his tent to address the company.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Captain Clark and I have decided to proceed along the western fork of the Missouri, which we have named the Jefferson River. It only makes sense for us to push West by whatever means possible. Sacagawea has informed us that we are not far from the summer retreat of her nation.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

Merriweather Lewis looks down at the ground and kicks dirt with his boot.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)
 But we must find her people soon. The successful issue of our voyage depends on the Shoshones and their horses. The rest of you will be in good hands with Captain Clark. Drouillard, John Shields and Hugh McNeil...you're coming with me in the morning. Be ready before dawn.

Merriweather Lewis steps back and turns to walk away. Having an afterthought, he stops and turns back to the CORPS.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)
 Charbonneau I need to speak with you and your wife. York, can you come over here also?

Charbonneau, Sacagawea and York join Merriweather Lewis outside the ring of men. Clark's injury prevents him from getting up, and he doesn't want to.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)
 Charbonneau, as much as I'd like to bring your wife on this scout, I fear that the baby would hinder our progress. Time is of the essence and I need to find horses quickly. I'm confident that I can gain the Shoshone's confidence on my own, but I'll need some quick lessons in their language. Please ask Sacagawea what the words are for *white man who comes as a friend*.

Charbonneau turns and converses with Sacagawea. Their conversation is animated and Charbonneau appears to be trying hard to get her to understand something. Sacagawea is speaking rapidly, seeming to state many ideas at once, but Charbonneau abruptly cuts her off in mid-sentence and turns to Merriweather Lewis .

CHARBONNEAU
 (proudly)
 Capitain. The word you are looking for is *Tab-ba-bone*.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
 (slowly)
 Tab-ba-bone.

CHARBONNEAU
 That should get your point across just fine.

SACAGAWEA
 (furious)
 No, you idiot! That word means *enemy*!

Sacagawea continues to berate Charbonneau. Charbonneau ignores her.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

What is she saying?

CHARBONNEAU

Mon Capitain...she is going on and on about coming with you on the scout. I told her that her place is with the baby, but she does not listen.

Sacagawea continues her verbal assault on Charbonneau. He looks embarrassed as she punches him in the shoulder and storms away.

SACAGAWEA

(exasperated and turning on her heels)

Idiot!

CHARBONNEAU (cont'd)

My wife is very spirited.

CAPT. LEWIS

Yes, I've noticed that you have a remarkable knack for bringing out the worst in a people.

Charbonneau looks to York for support.

YORK

(embarrassed)

If I was you, I'd bed down far away from her tonight.

Charbonneau walks away shaking his head

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

(as he watches Charbonneau walk off)

My God, that man smells like a chamber pot. A full chamber pot, that is. He's lucky she stays with him at all.

(turns to YORK)

York, I know you want to come on the scout and I'd like to have you along, but I need you to stay with Captain Clark and take care of him. He'd never admit it to you, but he misses you terribly, even when you're away for a few hours hunting. Besides, he needs someone to talk to when I'm not around and no one is better suited for that job than you.

YORK

I'll stay.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-1805-DAY

SUPERIMPOSE: A WEEK LATER, THE SOURCE OF THE MISSOURI RIVER NEAR THE CONTINENTAL DIVIDE

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

The river has run out and turned into a small stream. The Crew have abandoned their canoes and now hike overland towards the Continental Divide. The mountains are closer than ever. They are tired and sweating profusely in the sun. In stark contrast to the midday heat, the mountain caps on the horizon are covered with a blanket of snow. York on the other. Their pace is agonizingly slow. Just when it seems they will not be able to continue any further, Merriweather Lewis appears on a rise in the distance waving an American flag on a pole and shouting happily. The Crew do not realize what Merriweather Lewis is so happy about and are somewhat confused.

CLARK

He's finally gone off the deep end.

YORK

Where are the rest of them?

Just then, Merriweather Lewis is joined on the rise by the rest of the scouts, 6 SHOSHONE INDIANS, and a caravan of horses. The with Clark begin to cheer and some break ranks to run and meet Merriweather Lewis .

CLARK

Get back here, you men! And stop that infernal racket. Let's make sure this isn't a trap before we run right into their hands.

SGT. PRYOR

(looking through a spyglass)

Captain Lewis and the scouts appear to still have their rifles sir.

CLARK

Point taken, Sergeant, but let's be cautious.

Merriweather Lewis brings his party down the hill as Clark brings his men to the bottom of the rise. Merriweather Lewis and Clark embrace and York and Drouillard embrace. The SHOSHONES sit on their horse and stare at the white men with expressionless faces. Unnoticed by the rest of the men, Sacagawea, who is now close enough to the Indians to see them plainly, begins to cry. She runs up to the Shoshone Indian, CAMEAHWAIT, 25 and well-built, and begins an animated conversation with him. After a minute or so, the foremost the Shoneshone Indian dismounts and embraces Sacagawea. Charbonneau, who has been watching this exchange, approaches his wife and Cameahwait and begins to speak to them urgently, a worried look on his face. Sacagawea turns to Charbonneau and speaks hotly to him, she punctuates her words by hitting him in the chest with her balled fist as she scolds him. Cameahwait laughs briefly at Charbonneau. The CrewS have gathered round and are watching this exchange.

CLARK (cont'd)

What's going on now, Charbonneau? Has her rightful husband come to claim her?

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

CHARBONNEAU

No sir. Although I did fear the worst for a moment. This is the most amazing coincidence and good fortune I have ever witnessed.

(He gestures to CAMEAHWAIT)

This man, Cameahwait of the Shoshones, is the long lost brother of my wife.

Clark shakes his head in disbelief. Sacagawea continues to smile and weep at the same time, wraps her blanket around her brother, and embraces him again. Cameahwait speaks to Charbonneau in Shoshone, and Charbonneau translates for the Captains.

CHARBONNEAU (cont'd)

He has agreed to sell us all the horses we will need.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Tell him that our father back east and the entire Corps are forever in his debt. Oh, and Charbonneau? Just for future reference, Tabbabone means *enemy* in the Shoshone language. I thought you might like to know that.

Charbonneau is unnerved by this revelation, and anxious to avoid the subject, translates Merriweather Lewis' thanks to Cameahwait.

CUT TO:

EXT. BITTERROOT MOUNTAIN RANGE-1805

The reunited Crew has begun its trek over the Bitterroot Mountain Range. They travel with 29 horses and 1 mule. The Crew take turns riding the horses. However, they are now moving on an upwards elevation and the weather is getting noticeably colder. They travel with a Shoshone Indian Guide, OLD TOBY, 60.

OLD YORK (VO)

Chief Cameahwait sold us all the horses we needed at a bargain price and as a token of their good faith, sent one of their old tribal elders to be our guide. We called him Old Toby. As we approached the top of the range and neared the crest of a mountain, we all expected to get a glimpse of the Western Ocean. Spirits were high, but no one was more excited than Captain Lewis. Scarcely able to contain himself.

EXT. BITTERROOT MOUNTAIN RANGE-SAME

The Crew and Old Toby are halted on a fairly level inclining slope, three quarters of the way up a mountain. This mountain is one in a range of many that extends north and south of the expedition's location.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Captain Clark, I'd like to halt here for awhile and rest the horses.

(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)

(pointing)

See that peak over there? It's not in our immediate line of march, but I believe that it will give us a view of the whole valley in front of us. Will you do me the honor of accompanying me for what may very well be our first look at the Western Ocean?

CLARK

I'd be honored to, Captain Lewis.

(turns to SGT. ORDWAY)

Sergeant Ordway, pass the word that we're stopping here to eat and rest the horses.

SGT. ORDWAY

Should I have them unpack the horses sir?

CLARK

No...I don't think we'll be here that long.

SGT. ORDWAY

Yes sir.

(turning back to the CORPS)

Dismount!

CLARK

York, why don't you come with Captain Lewis and I...this should be an interesting sight.

The Captains and York, dismounted, make a short hike to a nearby peak. They must pass through some snowy evergreen woods and choose their footing very carefully. Merriweather Lewis, visibly excited, is in the lead and addresses York and Clark while walking briskly towards their objective.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

(somewhat out of breath)

Gentlemen, if my calculations are correct, we are about to become the first Americans ever to see the fabled Western Ocean. As you look out on its sandy shores, count yourself lucky and give thanks to the Creator that you have beheld this magnificent sight. We have conquered the Northwest Passage of our wildest dreams.

At this point, Clark, due to his sore ankle, stumbles and York must stop to help him up.

Merriweather Lewis is too excited to even notice to what has happened. He disappears over the ridge line and gains the crest of the elevation.

CLARK

This blasted ankle of mine...I thought it was getting better.

YORK

(helping CAPT. CLARK to his feet)

(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

YORK (cont'd)
Have a care to not put too much pressure on
it William. We're not out of this yet.

Clark and York hear a cry of joy or anguish, it is impossible to tell which, from the direction Merriweather Lewis has taken. As they come to the crest, the first thing they see is Merriweather Lewis on his knees on a rocky outcrop facing west. He holds his head in his hands; he is weeping inconsolably. York and Clark look up and see what has upset Merriweather Lewis so much. There is no Western Ocean. Rather, there is 1000 miles of jagged and snow-capped mountains extending to the farthest reaches of the horizon. Their task now seems insurmountable.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(weeping)
No...no...it can't be. My God, give me
strength. Why...why have you forsaken us?

Merriweather Lewis is so distraught that he actually pulls at his own hair. York turns away with embarrassment but Clark becomes resolute. Clark walks over to his friend, squats down beside him and puts a consoling arm around Merriweather Lewis.

CLARK
We knew it wasn't going to be easy,
Merriweather. And God knows it hasn't been.
But we can beat these mountains.
(looks doubtful)
They can't go on forever.

Clark helps Merriweather Lewis to his feet.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
How will we get through, William? Winter
is almost here.

CLARK
Oh, we'll get through. Or we'll die trying.
We'll eat the horses if we have to. I don't
intend to die lost and alone in the middle
of some nameless mountains. *We will get
through.*

CUT TO:

EXT. BITTERROOT MOUNTAINS-1805-EARLY WINTER

The Crew breaks camp in a valley. They are preparing for the next crossing. Winter has come to the mountains ahead of them. The men are packing a few deer and antelope carcasses across the mule's back and busy themselves with the many tasks that their forced march will require.

DISSOLVE TO:

The CAMERA shows an AERIAL SHOT of the Crew zigzagging single-line column as it moves up the face of the mountain.

OLD YORK (VO)
It was cold in those mountains and the
going became very rough.
(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

OLD YORK (cont'd)
 Old Toby lost the trail several times,
 forcing us to blaze our own trail over
 treacherous and steep ground. On more than
 one occasion, our pack animals lost their
 footing and tumbled down a mountainside.

The CAMERA shows a horse, packed with gear, rolling head-over-
 heels down the side of a mountain. Men scramble out of the way in
 the nick of time. The CAMERA shows the horse lying dead at the
 base of the mountain.

OLD YORK (VO) (cont'd)
 Foolishly, we cut the packs loose from the
 injured or dead animals and left them where
 they lay, not knowing just how badly we
 would soon be missing that horseflesh.
 After a week...we ran out of food.

CUT TO:

EXT. CAMP-BITTERROOT MTS.-1805-WINTER

The men are bundled up against the cold and snow. They wear many
 layers of clothing and have wrapped themselves in blankets and
 rags. The horses are corralled nearby. Most of the men huddle
 around the fire, motionless, but Merriweather Lewis stands off by
 himself near the small horse herd. York and Drouillard emerge
 from the woods, holding their rifles. Merriweather Lewis looks at
 them expectantly, but they shake their heads sadly. Their hunting
 trip was unsuccessful. Merriweather Lewis unceremoniously walks
 up to one of the mares, drawing his flintlock pistol as he goes.
 He shoots the unsuspecting animal in the head, dropping it where
 it stands.

The shot rings out loudly and startles the camp into absolute
 silence. The men all stare at CAPT. LEWIS, some slack-jawed, with
 their hot breath visible in the cold air.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
 (testily)
 Well...what are you all staring at? Why do
 you all looked so shocked? Did you expect
 me to let us all starve? Private Collins,
 Charbonneau, get busy butchering this
 horse.

CUT TO:

The Crew eats in silence. They pour a mysterious "gravy" on their
 horse meat.

CUT TO:

EXT. CAMP-BITTERROOT MTS.-BLIZZARD-NEXT MORNING

A blanket of snow covers irregular shapes. A tent flap opens,
 revealing that this is the camp. The occupant, York, must dig
 himself out. York surveys his surroundings as the other men
 emerge in similar fashion from their tents. While they slept, a
 blizzard hit.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

OLD YORK (VO) (cont'd)
 We continued to battle against fatigue, starvation, illness, and the most unpredictable weather you can possibly imagine. Many men wanted to turn back, but there was no point in that; the Captains remained as cheerful as possible under the circumstances and inspired us by their determination.

The CAMERA shows the Crew moving down the side of a mountain. The snow ends at the bottom and there are no longer any mountains in front of them. They look as if they have been forgotten prisoners of war. Their clothing is in tatters and they are all sullen and gaunt.

The CAMERA shows Merriweather Lewis heating his knife by a fire. Pvt. Carson has a rag in his mouth and is about to undergo crude frontier surgery. Merriweather Lewis takes the red-hot knife and cuts around a festering sore which has grown over a piece of cloth on the man's shoulder. Pvt. Carson bites down on the cloth to suppress his screams as tears well in his eyes and sweat pours down his face.

OLD YORK (VO) (cont'd)
 As we made our way west, our spirits began to lift. We knew that we were now on what promised to be the final leg of our journey. Even though we were out of the mountains, we weren't completely out of the woods.

The CAMERA shows the CORPS halted in line at an opening in the woods. They all stand completely still and stare at something which we cannot see.

CLARK
 (slowly)
 Don't move a muscle, men.

Now the CAMERA show the Crews' POV. We see that they are surrounded by 50 fierce-looking INDIAN WARRIORS. The Indian Warriors sit tall and straight atop their horses, and hold weapons of all kinds. They are the NEZ PERCE'. Without speaking, the NEZ PERCE' INDIAN CHIEF urges his horse forward and stops in front of the Captains. Through sign language, he indicates that he wants the Crews to follow him to the Indian camp. The CAMERA shows the Crew riding while surrounded by the Nez Perce'. The Nez Perce' are astounded at the state of the crew, they look like the walking dead.

CUT TO:

EXT. NEZ PERCE' INDIAN CAMP-SAME

The Crew are seated in 3 lines on the ground while the Captains stand with arms folded in front of them. The Captains look anxious. The men have their rifles and gear and are not prisoners, but are being watched closely by the Nez Perce' Indians in the village.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

Groups of men, women and children approach York and look at him curiously. York does not object when they want to touch his black skin. The NEZ PERCE' INDIAN CHILDREN run away from York when they get up close. The NEZ PERCE' WARRIORS and CHIEFS converse while gesturing towards the Crew.

CLARK

Charbonneau, can you understand anything they are saying?

CHARBONNEAU

I am sorry, mon Capitain, I do not know this language. All I know is that these Indians must be the Nez Percé, or *people of the pierced nose* in your language.

CUT TO:

INT. NEZ PERCE' INDIAN CAMP-LARGE LODGE-SAME

4 NEZ PERCE' INDIAN CHIEFS sit in a circle around a council fire. A very sick and RETURNED FROM A FAR AWAY COUNTRY, 80, lies in the corner of the lodge, being attending to by 2 FEMALE NEZ PERCE' INDIANS, middle-aged.

1ST NEZ PERCE'

Twisted Hair...because the high chief is away with a war party, you are the leader of the council. You must decide what to do with these white-skinned strangers who have come among us.

TWISTED HAIR

They have come in peace and we must be careful to make the right decision about their fate.

2ND NEZ PERCE'

They have a man with black skin among them.

3RD NEZ PERCE'

I have heard about these black-skinned men. They are holy men descended from the father of all bears.

All NEZ PERCE' INDIANS nod and mumble in agreement.

2ND NEZ PERCE'

Their rifles would make us more powerful than all of our enemies combined. Let's kill them all except for the black-skinned creature. We'll invite him to stay with us and he can be our holy man...

1ST NEZ PERCE'

What if the bear man is a Black Devil, and becomes angry that we've killed his companions? Even though he is probably anxious to be rid of their smell and their company, he may want to harm us.

Murmurs of approval echo throughout the lodge.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

TWISTED HAIR

The thought of killing these strangers troubles me. Our people have never harmed those who come to us without violence in their hearts.

From the corner of the lodge, with some effort, Returned From A Far Away Country, raises herself up on an elbow. Her words are respected due to her old age and wisdom.

RETURNED FROM FAR AWAY

When I was a young girl, and a captive of our enemies, I was sold to another tribe far from our homeland and made a slave. I escaped to the great northern country and was befriended by some of these white skins. These are the children of the people who helped me. Do not harm them, they have good hearts.

TWISTED HAIR

I have heard Returned From A Far Away Country and respect her words. It will be so. The white skins are our friends and will be our honored guests.

CUT TO:

EXT. NEZ PERCE' INDIAN CAMP-SAME

The CAMERA shows a TIGHT-SHOT of York holding a NEZ PERCE' INFANT, around 8 months old, up to his face and rubbing noses with the infant. He coos softly to the baby. Only York and the Nez Perce' Infant are visible to the CAMERA.

YORK

Coochie-choochie-coo. Coochie-choochie-coo.

The CAMERA pans back and shows a crowd of NEZ PERCE' INDIANS standing around YORK, gaping at him in shocked silence. The Captains and Crew stand nervously watching the NEZ PERCE'. The Nez Perce' Infant grabs York's nose and begins to laugh. The ice has been broken. The NEZ PERCE' INDIANS begin to smile and voice their approval. The Nez Perce' Chiefs embrace the Captains and the men look relieved. The CHIEFS prepare a feast as both the Crew and the Nez Perce' Indians interact on a kind and joyful level.

OLD YORK (VO)

From that day forward, the Nez Percé became our fierce allies and welcomed us with open arms, feeding us, clothing us, and helping us in anyway that they could. Most importantly they showed us how to make canoes.

CUT TO:

EXT. FOREST-1805-DAY

The Captains supervise while YORK and others are cutting down huge Ponderosa pines to make into canoes. Twisted Hair and 3 NEZ PERCE' INDIANS instruct the men in their efforts. Twisted Hair watches as Sgt. Ordway hollows out a log by building a fire on top of the log to soften the wood.

OLD YORK (VO)

Although we were the first Americans to pass through this territory, we knew that French-Canadian trappers had been here before us. Some of the Nez Percé spoke a spattering of French, enabling us to communicate with them. We also knew that shipping captains had sent boats from the Pacific Ocean down its tributary rivers. Captain Lewis told us that this river would lead us into the Columbia river and the Columbia would take us all the way to the Western Ocean.

The CAMERA shows the CORPS loading the dugouts on the river preparing to follow it to the Pacific. The Nez Perce' Indians see the Crew off on their next leg.

OLD YORK (VO) (cont'd)

The day of our departure finally came. Much to our surprise and pleasure Twisted Hair himself volunteered to be our guide.

The dugouts make their way down the river.

CUT TO:

EXT. COLUMBIA RIVER FALLS-1805-DAY

The dugouts move side by side and Twisted Hair signs to Returned From a Far Away Country that they are approaching the falls are ahead. Merriweather Lewis nods in understanding to Twisted Hair and turns to Clark in the next canoe.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

As near as I can tell, Twisted Hair has just told me that we will soon reach the falls of the Columbia River and the he must return to his people. And from what I remember, the Nez Percé told us there would be friendly villages near the falls that we could trade with.

CLARK

Lets keep our eyes open for a village then so we can camp for the night.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

(to the men)

That peak on the horizon is Mount Hood, men! Thirteen years ago, British explorers came one hundred miles up this river from the Western Ocean.

(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)

They came far enough that they saw that mountain range and they named the biggest one Mount Hood. That mountain is proof that we are going the right way.

CLARK

Thank God for that beautiful sight.

PVT. WILLARD

(from one of the other
dugouts; alarmed)

Captain Clark, will we have to cross those mountains?

CLARK

No son, the next mountains we cross will be on our way home.

The Crew spots a throng of FLATHEAD INDIANS on the nearby shore. They are the Flathead Indians. As the dugouts approach the shore, we can that see that they are attired in the clothing of 18th century British sailors, despite being Native American Indians. The FLATHEAD CHIEF stands in front of his people wearing a long British Admiral's frock coat with two rows of brass buttons. He smiles good-naturedly and calls out to the party.

FLATHEAD CHIEF

Rascally, son-of-a-bitch! Me rascally son-of-a-bitch!

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

(dryly to Clark)

I see our British predecessors did wonders in advancing the English language among the native peoples.

Twisted Hair has some knowledge of the Flathead language.

FLATHEAD CHIEF

Twisted Hair, it has been many seasons since you've visited my people. The people of the cut noses are always welcome in our village. What news do you bring from the mountains?

TWISTED HAIR

These people are my friends. I would consider it a great service if you make them your friends as well and treat them with kindness.

FLATHEAD CHIEF

The white skins have always been good traders...we will welcome them.

TWISTED HAIR

They wish to trade for meat.

There are over 10,000 pounds of dried Salmon on the ground.

FLATHEAD CHIEF

(gesturing to the ground)

(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

FLATHEAD CHIEF (cont'd)
Meat...we have enough fish to feed an
entire nation of white-skins.

TWISTED HAIR
These white-skins are strange. They desire
only to eat the flesh of an animal that
walks on four legs.

FLATHEAD CHIEF
(thinking)
Perhaps they would like dog? We have had
many new litters recently...and the pups
are as plentiful as blades of grass.

The Captains have been watching this exchange expectantly from their respective dugouts. Twisted Hair turns to Merriweather Lewis and tries to convey through sign language that the Flatheads have to offer dog meat in trade. Merriweather Lewis does not understand. Exasperated, Twisted Hair makes the motions of eating and then points to Seaman. Seaman's ears perk up in canine understanding and he bares his teeth and snarls at Twisted Hair.

CUT TO:

EXT. FLATHEAD VILLAGE-SAME-NIGHT

A feast is in progress. The CAMERA shows huge piles of dried salmon everywhere. The Flathead Indians sing and dance and gorge themselves on fish. Sitting apart from the Flatheads, the Crew is eating animal meat, not fish, that has been spit-roasted over a fire. At the edge of their circle, the CAMERA PULLS BACK and reveals several, severed dog heads.

YORK
(picking a bone clean)
I never thought I'd live to see the day I
ate a dog.

CAPT. LEWIS
I find it quite succulent...delicious even.

CAPT. CLARK
(sourly)
I will never reconcile myself to eating
man's best friend.

From the opposite end of the circle, Seaman barks in agreement with Clark.

CUT TO:

EXT. COLUMBIA RIVER-1805

The dugouts move with the choppy current and there is a driving rain coming down. A heavy fog rises off the water. Because of the dense fog, the 4 dugouts are lashed together, making two separate vessels. We see that the Flathead Chief, still wearing his admiral's coat, has joined the expedition as their new guide. As the members of the Crew strain to see through the fog, the water takes on the characteristics of a large body of water.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

Soon the canoes are being tossed and turned on whitecap waves. The fog and darkness make it impossible to see.

SGT. ORDWAY
(looking down at the waves)
Is it still the river? Have we hit rapids?

PVT. WILLARD
(petrified)
Maybe there's a waterfall ahead...we'll all
be killed.

The Flathead Chief is screaming and gesturing in his language but no one knows what he is saying.

CLARK
(calm)
Merriweather, I think we've hit open water.

A wave crashes into Merriweather Lewis ' canoe.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
I think you're right. We must have. Men, I
believe we've reached the open sea.

The Crews' mood immediately changes from fear of the unknown and apprehension to joy and elation at the prospect of reaching their destination. The dugouts continue to be rocked severely on the waves. Some members of the party, including Sacagawea, become sea sick and vomit over the side.

CLARK
We're taking on water...it's foolishness to
stay out in this storm.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Let's try to find the shore and make camp
for the night.

CUT TO:

EXT. CAMP-EASTERN SHORE OF A LARGE BAY-1805-MORNING

The sun rises. York emerges from his tent, half-dressed and half-asleep he goes into the woods to urinate. When he finishes, he pauses for a moment and enjoys the solitude. Smiling to himself, he exits the woods and notices the bay for the first time. He realizes that what he is looking at is not the ocean, but a large bay with land visible on all sides. He shoots a worried look at Merriweather Lewis ' tent and sees that Merriweather Lewis is up and glaring at the bay.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
It's just a bay...damn it all!

CUT TO:

EXT. OPEN WATER-LARGE BAY-SAME

The 4 dugouts move briskly along the shoreline of the bay, heading west. The men seem resolute and focused.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

The CAMERA shows the dugouts moving through rough and choppy waters. Sacagawea and other men are vomiting over the side again. The dugouts are assailed by dozens of floating logs that appear out of nowhere and almost capsize the boats. Some of the mysterious logs are 200 feet long and 7 feet in diameter. As the dugouts clear the logs, some men are seen drinking water from the bay while Merriweather Lewis and Clark shake their heads in disapproval. These same men are then shown violently vomiting over the side of the canoes. The MONTAGE continues as the dugouts are in yet another violent thunderstorm. Sacagawea is vomiting into the bay along with others.

CUT TO:

EXT. CAMP-MOUTH OF GREY'S BAY-1805-DAY

Tattered tents are erected as a futile barrier against the high winds and rain.

INT. MERRIWEATHER LEWIS' TENT-SAME

Merriweather Lewis lies under a buffalo robe weakened with dysentery. Clark and York enter his tent.

CLARK

(softly to Lewis)

Merriweather...I don't mean to disturb you, but we need to talk. We're not making any progress and I can't stand still another day. We've come too far to let rain stand in our way. Our supplies are running out and some of the men barely have clothes to wear. We're going to have to make a permanent camp soon, and settle in for the winter. But first we have got to get to the ocean.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

I agree with you, William. Unfortunately, physically I am very weak, and not much use to the expedition. I am afraid that this dysentery will keep me on my back a little while longer, but I do feel that the worst of it is over.

CLARK

You rest up. I am going to take a few men on an overland scout to see if I can finally find the ocean. Maybe there will be a ship that we can resupply with. Hell, I might even be able to convince them to take one of our men on board to send word back east that we are still alive.

Clark chuckles to himself.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

It sounds like an excellent plan, William. I wish you Godspeed and good fortune. May you see the sight that I have been dreaming about for what seems like a lifetime.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

CLARK

I'll be gone in the morning. I'm taking York, Drouillard and the Fields brothers. The sergeants will oversee things while you're laid up. It shouldn't take me more than a week to send word of what we find...then the rest of you can come up and join us.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

So you're saying we should abandon the dugouts and go overland from now on?

CLARK

Yes.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Then we'll do it.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. FORREST-1805-DAY

SUPERIMPOSE: NOVEMBER 18TH, 1805

Clark, York, Drouillard and the Field Brothers emerge slowly from a dense forest. They stop as they reach the edge do to the sight of sandy bluffs and the sound of crashing surf. They climb the bluffs and arrive at the summit; the sight that greets them renders them speechless. York and Clark stand slightly in front of the other 3 men. They see the Pacific Ocean. Rolling waves crash on the rocky shore and blue water covers the horizon. Billowing white clouds are scattered in a clear and contrasting blue sky. Drouillard and the Field Brothers run down to the sandy beach and play in the surf like giddy children. York remains at Clark's side. Clark is lost in the moment, he cannot take his eyes off the water. For the first time on the expedition, he breaks down and cries. Out of respect for his friend, YORK maintains the silence that this momentous occasion demands.

OLD YORK (VO)

I have to say that it certainly was a proud moment for me, and I was honored to be at my friend's side for that grand vision. Although I felt bad that Captain Lewis couldn't be us, it felt right that William and I were here alone. I can't explain it, but it was like those other men weren't even there.

CUT TO:

EXT. PACIFIC OCEAN SHORELINE-1805-DAY

Merriweather Lewis runs on the beach and into the shallow water where he drops to his knees and raises his hands and eyes to the heavens. He screams wildly and cries tears of joy.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

OLD YORK (VO)

I suppose you're wondering how Captain Lewis reacted to seeing that beautiful ocean for the first time. I can tell you this, he didn't disappoint us in his enthusiasm and exuberance.

CUT TO:

EXT. PACIFIC OCEAN SHORELINE-TEMPORARY CAMP-WINTER-1805

The entire Crew is assembled on the shore. The Captains face them.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Men, I have called you all together because we have a decision to make. We need to decide where to establish a permanent camp to spend the winter. We can stay here near the ocean in the hopes of meeting a ship. A ship would provide us with provisions and we might be able to send some of you back to Washington to spread the news of our success. Also, if we stay here, we can make salt, which we're going to need for our trip back.

CLARK

We could make our base on the north side of the mouth of the Columbia, but there didn't appear to be much game there. The Indians say there's plenty of elk on the south side though.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Or, we can head back up river, back to our friends the Nez Percé. We know that they would treat us well and the weather would be dryer.

CLARK

We have decided to put this to a vote, even though we each have our own preference. We've done everything as a unit so far, and Captain Lewis and I see no reason to break protocol. Sergeant Gass...you will call the names of every member of the company, one by one, and Sergeant Ordway will record their individual votes.

SGT. GASS

(looking at SACAGAWEA and
YORK)

Every member of the expedition, sir?

CAPT. CLARK

Every member, Sergeant.

Merriweather Lewis nods his approval. Sgt. Gass then calls the roll and Sgt. Ordway tallies the votes.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

When York's name is called, he firmly states his preference which is to cross to the south side of the Columbia.

SGT. GASS

York.

YORK

(stepping forward)

I vote we move to the south side of the Columbia.

As he votes, his tear-filled eyes meet the approving gaze of Clark. Something solemn and unspoken passes between the two men. When Sgt. Gass finishes calling the names of all the men, including Charbonneau's, he asks for Sacagawea's vote. The Crew is neither surprised nor angered that York and Sacagawea have been asked to vote. Charbonneau converses with his wife and informs Sgt. Ordway of her vote, which is to move to the south side of the Columbia. The vote is nearly unanimous...the Crew will move to the south side of the Columbia River and remain there for the winter.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Well, it's almost unanimous. We'll spend the winter on the southern banks of the Columbia. Sgt. Gass, dismiss the men.

SGT. GASS

Company...dismissed.

The Crew disperses, but York remains seated with his back to a large rock and his hands folded over his knees. He stares continually at the ocean.

OLD YORK (VO)

I had been the first black man to ever vote in an official capacity in the United States. Without a doubt, I had to be the only slave who ever had that honor. It seemed incredible to me that a black man and an Indian woman, who didn't speak a lick of English mind you, had been allowed to vote on a military expedition. But I guess that shows you how far we had all come. Somewhere along the way, I had shed my skin and was now the same as everyone else. I had gained a voice. That day, at least, my opinion mattered.

CUT TO:

EXT. SOUTHSIDE-COLUMBIA RIVER-1805-WINTER

The Crew erects Fort Clatsop on the southern banks of the Columbia River. Logs are manipulated by CARPENTERS to fit perfectly atop one another while other CRAFTSMEN apply a mud-cement sealer to the spaces between the pieces of sectioned timber. On the shoreline, several Privates under the supervision of a Sgt. Ordway make salt by boiling ocean water in huge kettles. The Captains are seen bartering with the CLATSOP INDIANS.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

OLD YORK (VO)

We built Fort Clatsop on the south shore of the Columbia River and spent the wet winter in quarters. We named the fort after the local Indian tribe, who we traded with, but were never inclined to become very familiar or friendly with. To fight the unending boredom, we busied ourselves with routines like making salt for the return trip and hunting elk and more elk. But always, thoughts of home were foremost in our minds.

The Crew prepares to depart as Merriweather Lewis is handing the fort over to the CLATSOP CHIEF in a ceremonious fashion.

OLD YORK (VO) (cont'd)

On March 23rd, 1806, we gave the fort to the Clatsop Indians, slipped our canoes into the Columbia River, and began our trip back to civilization.

The canoes make their way up the Columbia.

CUT TO:

EXT. OPEN MEADOW-FOOT OF THE BITTERROOT MTS-1806-DAY

The CAMERA shows a crude game of baseball being played at the base of the Bitterroot Mountains. The players are the Crew and the Nez Perce' Indians. The Indians are dressed for war and have their faces painted. Both sides play the game with reckless enthusiasm. York is at the plate and swings a canoe paddle as his bat. He hits a makeshift ball over the head of the NEZ PERCE' LEFT FIELDER and begins to run the bases. The Nez Perce' Left Fielder attempts to get York out by throwing the ball at him, nearly missing his head several times; Seaman follows close on York's heels. However, their efforts are in vain, and both York and Seaman cross home plate to the cheers of the Crew.

OLD YORK (VO)

On our way home, we stopped to visit with our good friends the Nez Percé. We had to pick up our horses for the return trip and we had some time to spare, so we spent an afternoon playing a game of base with them.

CUT TO:

EXT. COLUMBIA RIVERBANK-1806-DAY

The CAMERA shows the Crew separating into 2 groups at the rivers edge. Merriweather Lewis and Drouillard take 1 group; Clark and York are with the other group.

OLD YORK (VO) (CONT'D)

The next day, we said our good-byes and resumed the long journey home.

(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

OLD YORK (cont'd)
 Captain Lewis and a handful of men broke off from the Corps to scout for the northernmost reaches of the Louisiana territory. Captain Clark led the rest of us directly east.

CUT TO:

EXT. POMPEY'S PILLAR-BANK OF THE YELLOWSTONE RIVER-1806-DAY

The CAMERA shows Clark's POV of POMPEY'S PILLAR, a huge sandstone rock formation jutting out of the Great Plains like a giant tooth. Clark stands with York, Sacagawea and Charbonneau as they stare at the pillar in awe.

CLARK
 What a remarkable rock!
 (looks down at Pomp)
 What shall we name it? Hmm? Let's call it *Pompy's Pillar*, in honor of our youngest explorer.

Pomp looks up at Clark and looks back at the huge rock.

SACAGAWEA
 (to Charbonneau, but still looking at the formation)
 This place is very sacred to my people. It makes my heart glad to see it again.

Charbonneau translates this to the others.

CHARBONNEAU
 (to the group)
 She says this is a very holy place and the she is happy to see it again.

YORK
 Do you think we can climb to the top of it, Captain? We'd be able to see for miles.

CLARK
 Not only are we going to climb it, but I intend to leave my mark for future generations to see. Go get a stone chisel.

CUT TO:

EXT. TOP OF POMPEY'S PILLAR-SAME

The CAMERA shows York, Sacagawea and Pomp standing on a ridge near the top of the pillar. They watch Clark finish carving his name and date into a sandstone wall near the top of the pillar. Clark steps away from the wall and admires his work. The CAMERA shows **WM. CLARK 1806** carved into the sandstone.

CLARK
 So they'll know we were here...

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

YORK
Betcha Captain Lewis is going to be
jealous...wonder where he is right now...

York looks north.

CUT TO:

EXT. GREAT PLAINS-1806

Merriweather Lewis looks through his spyglass at 8 BLACKFEET WARRIORS making their way over a hill towards his small scouting party. With Merriweather Lewis are Drouillard and the Field Brothers. The 2 groups meet and Merriweather Lewis give them gifts of an American flag, brightly colored bandanas and bronze peace medals. He signs to the Blackfeet Warriors to join him for food at the small scouting camp.

CUT TO:

EXT. CAMP-GREAT PLAINS-SAME-NIGHT

The Blackfeet Indians and the limited Crew sit together around the campfire and begin to eat.

OLD YORK (VO)
On a scout up the Marias River, Captain Lewis and his three men encountered eight Blackfeet Warriors, sworn enemies of our friends the Shoshones, the Flatheads and the Nez Percé'. He made friends with them with gifts and a meal. That night, Captain Lewis found out the hard way that those Blackfeet wanted more than he was prepared to give.

Merriweather Lewis and his men are now sleeping in their bed rolls and the Blackfeet Indians are quietly attempting to steal their rifles.

PVT. JOSEPH FIELDS
(awakening suddenly)
Damn you! Let go of my rifle!

The CAMERA shows Ruben Fields and a BLACKFEET INDIAN WARRIOR wrestle in hand-to-hand combat as RUBEN attempts to recover his stolen rifle. Ruben Fields stabs his adversary with a large hunting knife as they roll around on the ground.

Merriweather Lewis jumps up and drawing his pistol, fires it at a charging Blackfeet Indians Warrior, hitting him in the stomach and dropping him. Drouillard and the Fields Brothers have recovered their rifles and fire at the 6 remaining BLACKFEET, who flee to the north.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(enraged)
Gather up all of their effects and burn them!

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

Merriweather Lewis walks up to the corpse of the Blackfeet Warrior that he killed and examines it. The Fields Brothers drag the other dead Blackfeet Warrior over. The corpses lie side by side and Merriweather Lewis puts a bronze peace medal around the necks of both.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS (cont'd)
I want their friends to know we came in peace.

CUT TO:

EXT. CAMP-MISSOURI RIVER'S EDGE-1806-DAY

The CAMERA shows the joyful reunion of the Captains.

OLD YORK (VO)
Once again, we were all together, and ready to complete the final phase of our journey.

CUT TO:

EXT. FORT MANDAN-1806-DAY

SUPERIMPOSE: AUGUST 14TH, 1806, FORT MANDAN

The CAMERA shows a tearful reunion between the Crew and their Mandan Indian friends. As soon as York walks ashore, the Crow Indian Girl who was so distraught at his leaving runs up to him and throws her arms around him. Other men are similarly embraced by welcoming Crow Indians and Mandan Women. Big White Chief and other Chiefs approach the Captains and greet them warmly.

The Captains, York, Charbonneau, Sacagawea and the boy Pomp stand together along the shore of the Missouri River.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(to CHARBONNEAU)
Toussaint, I thank you for your services over these past two years. Your interpreting and navigational skills were invaluable to us. As a token of our appreciation, I want you to have the expedition's blacksmithing tools. They should be of some use out here.

CHARBONNEAU
I thank you, mon Capitain. I know at times I was more trouble than I was worth, but I was happy to be of service.

CLARK
(to SACAGAWEA)
There are no words strong enough to tell you how much Captain Lewis and I appreciate all you have done for this expedition. You and your family will always be welcome at my home in the east, should you ever need a place to stay.

(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

CLARK (cont'd)
Just follow the rivers east and ask for
William Clark...there will always be people
who know how to find me. (he tousles POMP's
hair) I feel like an Uncle to this boy...

Charbonneau translates as Clark is speaking and Sacagawea is
reduced to tears. Clark takes Pomp into his arms and hugs him
fiercely. As he puts the boy down, York picks up Pomp and hoists
him up on his shoulders. The boy laughs happily.

SACAGAWEA
(through CHARBONNEAU)
I have been proud to serve my two white
fathers. I will miss both of you...
(looks at YORK)
and I will miss my friendship with Talking
Bear. You will all always be with me inside
my heart.

Sacagawea, still in tears, touches her heart. They all embrace.
The Captains walk along the shoreline by themselves.

CUT TO:

EXT. GREAT PLAINS-SAME

The Spanish Cavalry is stopped on a rise overlooking an endless
plain of green hills. The Spanish Major and the Spanish
Lieutenant are arguing over their next move.

SPANISH MAJOR
(disgusted)
All this way for nothing! We've missed them
again. The Governor General will be
furious.

SPANISH LIEUTENANT
You give up too easily. Let me take fifty
men and I'll catch up with this Captain
Merry Weather within two weeks.

SPANISH MAJOR
(exasperated)
Sure, I have nothing to look forward to but
a court martial when we return. You go and
find the Americans. You're trying to make a
name for yourself, and I understand that.
But be careful...you might get more than
you bargained for.

SPANISH LIEUTENANT
Just remember who gave up and who decided
to press on.

SPANISH CAPTAIN
Go with God, you fool.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

The MAIN BODY of Spanish Cavalry turns south behind the Major and the Spanish Lieutenant takes his 50 Spanish Cavalry and heads north.

CUT TO:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-1806-NIGHT-FOG

The remainder of the Crew moves with the current down the Missouri River. The night is pitch black with dense fog; visibility is near zero. The Captains, York and Drouillard travel in the same canoe.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
(straining to see anything in
the fog)
I don't like this. I don't like this at
all.

CLARK
I hear you. It's hard to say how far we've
come, but I don't like the idea of
traveling blindly into the darkness. We're
going to have to stop and camp soon. The
men are tired and they can't go much
further.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS
Let's at least camp on the opposite side of
the river from where the Lakotas had their
village. We'll have to post sentries on an
all night vigil. It's going to be a long
night.

CLARK
(calling over to the other
canoes)
Boys, start looking for a place to beach
the canoes and camp for the night. We've
got to get out of this fog. Keep your
rifles loaded and ready.

The CAMERA shows them beaching the canoes on a low bank in the river. They begin to set up camp in the fog.

CUT TO:

INT. INDIAN TEPEE-SAME

Chief Black Buffalo holds a council of war in his lodge. A group of SIOUX WARRIORS sit in a circle around a fire in the center of the teepee. They pass a pipe among them and smoke in a ritualistic way. The CAMERA moves in on the council in progress; the Sioux Warriors are involved in heated discussion.

CHIEF BUFFALO MEDICINE
I say we wipe these intruders out as soon
as possible. They are trespassing on our
lands, and by doing nothing, we are showing
them that we are weak.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

There are grunts of agreement around the circle.

CHIEF PARTISAN

I too believe that we have ignored the problem of unwelcome strangers in our lands for too long. We must go to war. Our young men's spears need to be washed in blood.

CHIEF BLACK BUFFALO

(staring into the fire
reflectively)

Long ago, in the time when the Everywhere Spirit still walked the earth, there was a beautiful green valley which lay in a ring of majestic mountains. The exact location of the valley is now lost to us but I know its story. A great tribe of eagles lived in those mountains and hunted in the valley. These were the fathers of all eagles and they were able to speak in the tongue of humans. For many years, the eagles heard the buzzing of locusts in their valley but in their arrogance they paid them no mind. After all, these were nothing but lowly insects. There were plenty of small creatures in the valley for the eagles to eat and all was well. Over the years, the buzzing grew louder and louder. One day, the eagles flew down to the valley to hunt, but they found that while they were sleeping, the locusts, who had become a great swarm, had picked the valley bare. There was no longer any place for the small creatures to hide and feel safe, so like the grass, they disappeared too. The valley was barren; there was no food left for the eagles. Many died of starvation. I think these trespassers are like the locusts...they don't inhabit our lands...they infest them.

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-1806-MORNING

100 LAKOTA WARRIORS are on horseback, concealed by the green hills that surround a camp. Only the tops of white tents are visible to the LAKOTA and the CAMERA. Smoke from a morning campfire rises over the hills and the clanking of cooking pots is the only sound that is heard. This is an ambush. Chief Partisan, who has been observing the camp on his belly, crawls back down the hill to his waiting comrades and mounts his pony. He blows a whistle made of a wolf bone to signal the beginning of the attack.

CHIEF PARTISAN

Strong hearts to the front, faint hearts to the rear...it is a good day to die!

The Lakota Warriors swarm over the hill and attack the camp. This is not the camp of the Crew;

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

this is the camp of the arrogant Spanish Lieutenant and his Cavalry. The Sioux Warriors quickly circle the camp of the dismounted Spanish Cavalryman. Several of the Sioux Warriors dismount and waving blankets, stampede the Spanish horse herd, causing utter confusion. The Spanish Cavalrymen have stacked their muskets in tripods outside of their conical tents. Sioux Warriors on horseback use their lances to knock the muskets over. The Spanish Soldiers are taken completely by surprise; they barely have time to organize a futile defense. The SIOUX fire their bows and muskets from the backs of their horses with deadly accuracy. Some of the Sioux Warriors fight fiercely with tomahawks and lances. They riddle the bodies of the Spanish Soldiers with arrows. They take many scalps. Within minutes, all of the Spanish Cavalrymen are dead. The Spanish Lieutenant is one of the last men to die. He falls to the ground with several arrows in his legs and chest. While he is still alive, Chief Buffalo Medicine dismounts and pins the Spanish Lieutenant's head to the ground with his own sword through the mouth. Chief Buffalo Medicine then takes the Spanish Lieutenant's scalp and raising the scalp above his head, lets out a bloodcurdling WAR CRY.

FADE OUT:

FADE IN:

EXT. MISSOURI RIVER-SAME

The CAMERA shows the Crew moving at a leisurely pace down the river. It is a beautiful morning; the water is calm, the birds are singing and the sky is a deep cloudless blue.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

What a glorious day!

YORK

It sure is fine, Captain Merriweather. I wish all of our days had been this way.

CLARK

(taking in his surroundings)
I recognize this part of the river. We will be coming up to the place where we met the Lakota Sioux at anytime now. Be alert and keep those rifles ready. Knowing them, they've been watching us for hours and they'll be waiting for us.

The Crew continues on their way. As they near a bend in the river, they see Chief Black Buffalo standing on a rocky outcrop, shaking his fist at them. Chief Black Buffalo yells threats, warnings, and curses at the Crew in the Sioux language. His tone is menacing and angry. He has only a 4 INDIAN WARRIORS standing on the bank near him. The members of the CORPS keep their heads low and their rifles ready as they quickly paddle by. Soon they are out of earshot of Chief Black Buffalo.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

Well, that was that. I hope I never see the likes of him again.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

CLARK

We were lucky to get away without a fight, but I reckon we won't be completely safe until we reach Saint Louis. We'd best keep our eyes and ears wide open and mind our business.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

True enough. But still, I've always thought as far as the Lakota Sioux go that their bark is much worse than their bite.

CUT TO:

EXT. OUTSKIRTS OF ST. LOUIS ON THE MISSISSIPPI RIVER-1806-LATE AFTERNOON

The boats move down the river. There are farms with cattle grazing in the fields. The river is teeming with FUR TRAPPERS, FREIGHT HAULERS, and FISHERMEN; all wave at the Crew as they pass.

OLD YORK (VO)

We knew we were almost home when we began to see farms with grazing cattle, a sight we had not seen for two years. Some of the men had elected to stay out west and start new lives in the territories that we had recently explored. Others had left the expedition at various points on the rivers. For the twenty or so men who remained, this would be our last night as the Corps of Discovery.

CUT TO:

EXT. ST. LOUIS-LARGE INN-SAME-NIGHT

SUPERIMPOSE: SAINT LOUIS, 1806

The Crew gather in front of the inn, with their baggage all around them as CROWDS OF INTERESTED PEOPLE flock to the area to get a glimpse of the explorers.

CLARK

Lewis, if you don't object, why don't you take the men into the tavern and make arrangements for our dinner? York and I will hunt down the proprietor and set up our lodging for the night.

MERRIWEATHER LEWIS

That's fine. I could use a bit of grog anyway.

Merriweather Lewis details 2 men to guard the baggage and takes the rest of the CORPS into the common room of the tavern. Clark and York enter the inn's office via a side door.

CUT TO:

INT. INN-SAME

The INNKEEPER of the Inn sits behind a high wooden counter, thumbing through the ledger. Clark approaches the front desk as York stands at the window, looking towards the street and the onlookers who have gathered.

CLARK

I'm Captain William Clark of the United States Army, lately returned from an expedition to the Pacific Ocean. I need lodging for myself, my co-commander, Captain Lewis, and twenty of my men.

INNKEEPER

My God sir, we had word that you would be coming tonight! May I shake your hand and tell you what an honor it is to have you in my humble public house. Rooms have been prepared for you and your men. (Hopefully) Will you be staying long?

CLARK

(shaking his head)
I can't say just how long we'll be here, but we'll inform you of our plans just as soon as possible.

INNKEEPER

(amazed)
They said you were dead...

CLARK

I can assure you that I am very much alive and at the moment, very tired and very hungry. If you'll excuse me, I'd like to join my companions in your common room.

INNKEEPER

But of course, sir. We have a nice beef stew in the pot, and fresh bread baking; and I am told my ale is the best in St. Louis.

CLARK

Sounds absolutely capital.

INNKEEPER

(noticing York)
Captain...is that your boy by the window?

Clark looks at York.

CLARK

Yes, that's York, my personal servant. He'll have free reign to come and go as he pleases and arrange my affairs while we are staying here. Make sure you get a good look at him, so you'll know him.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

INNKEEPER

He's a big buck, that's for sure. He'll stand out from the usual crowd of shiftless darkies that like to loiter around here.

CLARK

Very well, then. I am going to get some supper. York...let's go.

Clark walks up to York by the door.

CLARK (cont'd)

I suppose you can't wait to join the men in the tavern?

YORK

Well, we seem to be the main attraction around here, and it sure looks like fun. I reckon there will be an audience for my story-telling and I sure am hungry.

CLARK

I won't stand in the way of your merrymaking, but make sure my baggage and gear gets up to my room. Also, see if you can arrange to have my uniforms cleaned through the proprietor. I'm sure he knows of a good laundry in these parts.

YORK

Yes, William.

CLARK

And watch yourself around here, York. There are some rough characters about. Be sure to remember, don't be caught carrying any weapons while we're in the city. I don't have a writ from a judge that allows you to be armed, and I don't want anyone getting the wrong idea.

YORK

Yes, William. I'll take care of our bags...I'll be along shortly.

Clark goes into the common room as York walks outside to retrieve the baggage.

CUT TO:

EXT. INN-SAME

2 drunken ROUGHNECKS stagger into York's path as he is carrying the bags. YORK accidentally knocks them down. York towers over these little men, but they scream at him anyway.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

FIRST ROUGHNECK
(getting to his feet and
annoyed)
Watch where you're going, boy!

SECOND ROUGHNECK
You best be careful boy...or you're liable
to get hurt!

The 2 Roughnecks are more interested in drinking tonight and stumble down the street. Too shocked to speak, York gathers the baggage and makes his way into the office of the inn.

CUT TO:

INT. INN-SAME

York approaches the wooden desk of the Innkeeper. The Innkeeper continues to write in his ledger and does not stop to acknowledge York's presence. After a full minute of being ignored, YORK speaks up. The Innkeeper gushed over Clark, but now, in stark contrast, he barely has the time to speak to York.

YORK
Excuse me, sir. Can you tell me which room
Captain Clark will be staying in? I have
his bags and I'd like to take them up.

Without even looking up from his book, the Innkeeper places a key on the counter in front of YORK.

INNKEEPER
(dry and without emotion)
Room 214. Up the stairs and to the left.

YORK
Thank you, sir.

The Innkeeper does not acknowledge York. He struggles with the many bags, but the Innkeeper ignores this too. YORK battles his way up the stairs. When York is half way up, the Innkeeper has an afterthought and calls up to him.

INNKEEPER
We don't have quarters for Negroes here. If
your Captain wants to put you up in his
room that's fine; if not, you can bed down
in the stables tonight.

York continues silently up the stairs.

CUT TO:

INT. INN-COMMON ROOM-SAME

The room is buzzing with excitement and energy. As the Crew drink, eat and exchange stories, they are surrounded by ADMIRING PATRONS. A line of EXCITED SPECTATORS forms at the door and extends around the block. These people are eagerly waiting their turn to converse with the explorers.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

York and Drouillard hold court in a corner of the room, entertaining a crowd of people with highly animated stories of the trip. When their audience moves on to another table, York and Drouillard are left alone. Drouillard puts his arm around York's shoulders.

DROUILLARD

My friend, my friend. We had many fine adventures didn't we?

YORK

Ain't that the truth, George?

DROUILLARD

I've been meaning to ask you something, and now is as good a time as any...

(lowers his voice to a whisper and looks around)

I have a mind to go west. Soon. Back to the Crow...maybe build a log house and get a couple of Crow wives. A man could make a decent living in the fur trade out there, not to mention hunting, fishing, and working as a guide for the white men who are sure to follow our trail. I could use a partner and there's no one I'd rather have than you. I know I asked you before, but that seems like a hundred years ago. Under that tree...maybe you've given it some more thought and changed your mind? We could be on the river *tonight* before they even noticed we were gone...

YORK

You're forgetting something, George, I'm a slave...I'm Captain Clark's *property*. I have to go where he goes, at least for the time being. I'm sticking to my decision to wait it out. But watch for me...you might see me on the river some day.

DROUILLARD

I didn't forget that and we don't have to run away like common thieves either. I've made some money in my time and I was thinking of trying to buy your freedom from Captain Clark.

(looking around again to see if anyone is listening)

But we sure could take advantage of all this excitement and get out of here tonight. It would be a lot cheaper that way! What do you say?

YORK

You're a good friend, George. I thank you for your kindness. I appreciate it more than you know. But William is my friend too, and friends don't break promises to one another. I aim to hold him to his oath, and I suspect that he'll be keeping it very soon. Besides, I have a wife waiting for me in Louisville.

(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

YORK (cont'd)
That's one sweet homecoming that I wouldn't miss for anyone or anything...

DROUILLARD
Well, good luck my friend. I won't forget you. I hope he sets you free. You deserve it. But sometimes men have a way of looking out for themselves and promises get broken.

Drouillard and York stand and embrace each other warmly. Across the room, York meets Clark's Eyes. Clark has no idea what York and Drouillard were saying, but he stares at YORK suspiciously just the same. After a moment Clark reflectively as Clark empties his mug with one gulp. Drouillard leaves the tavern.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. DIRT ROAD-LOUISVILLE, KY-1806-DAY

The CAMERA shows York driving a four horse, clapboard wagon. Clark is seated next to him. The wagon is loaded with baggage and mementos.

YORK
Sure is good to be back home. I almost forgot what it looked like.

CLARK
Take a good look around...we might not be here for long.

YORK
Why...where are we going?

CLARK
I have a mind to move us to Saint Louis. Before we parted company, Captain Lewis hinted that the President might appoint me to an important position. If that happens, I'll need to be near the Indian Territory to set up shop.

York is stunned by this news. After a few moments of silence, he answers.

YORK
What about Clarksville? Will you sell it?

CLARK
No, not entirely. My brother George has expressed an interest in coming to Louisville. I guess there will always be Clarks in Clarksville, one way or another.

YORK
What about Miss Rosa?

CLARK
Oh, she is far too old to make the trip to Saint Louis. I guess I'll let her stay on with George.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

YORK
And me?

CLARK
(surprised)
You'll accompany me, of course. Why
wouldn't you?

YORK
I thought...I jus' thought that...
(changes his mind)
Yes, of course, of course I will go to
Saint Louis with you.

Clark realizes that YORK is apprehensive about the move.

CLARK
Don't worry, York. I know what's on your
mind. I'll make sure you get back to
Louisville several times a year to see Miss
Rosa and Sarah. There will always be
messages to carry and errands to run.
Besides, there are plenty of young girls
for you in Saint Louis.

YORK
If you say so, William.

CLARK
Cheer up...we're not moving tomorrow.
You'll have plenty of time with Sarah
before we go. Maybe I'll try to buy her
too, before we leave.

York and Clark's wagon pulls to a halt in front of Mr. Johnson's
abandoned farm. The 2 men are silent for a moment.

YORK
(confused and shocked)
I don't understand...what could have
happened?

CLARK
Judging by the condition of the buildings
and the overgrown fields, I'd say they've
been gone for a long time. Johnson always
talked about moving to Mississippi, but he
was always a big talker. Damn, I guess he
finally made the move.
(turns toward his bewildered
friend)
I'm sorry York...I truly am.

York and Clark continue along the dirt road while York looks
desperately at the abandon farm.

CUT TO:

EXT. CLARK'S SAINT LOUIS ESTATE-1811-FALL

SUPERIMPOSE: SAINT LOUIS, 1811

The CAMERA shows the grounds of William Clark's new estate.

OLD YORK (VO)

Several years had passed, and I was still a slave. William appeared to have forgotten his boyhood promise to me. Whenever I mentioned the my freedom, he became angry and refused to speak to me. To make matters worse, William had taken up residence in Saint Louis. This meant moving away from Kentucky and all of the old friends and family I had in Louisville. It made me sad and angry. It seemed like a wall was being built between William and I..brick by brick.

CUT TO:

INT. MANOR HOUSE-NIGHT-1811

Clark is hosting a formal dinner party. There are several MILITARY OFFICERS and LOCAL DIGNITARIES in attendance. There are no women present. The men have been drinking and have become somewhat boisterous. York, well-dressed and acting in the capacity of butler, supervises the slaves of the household as they bring food and drink into the dinning room. York stands in a corner of the room, making sure the serving is being carried out efficiently. York looks at the happy men with envy and longs to be part of the merriment.

ARMY OFFICER #1

(loud and slurring, gestures towards York)

So, William...is this the *slave* that saved your expedition? When you returned, tall tales of his exploits were all over the taverns of Saint Louis.

CAPT. CLARK

(somewhat embarrassed)

York did his part, just like everyone else.

ARMY OFFICER #2

The way my darkies tell it, he was a one man army...wrestling bears, leaping over rivers, and bedding down Indian princesses from the headwaters of the Mississippi all the way to the Pacific Ocean.

The party breaks into laughter.

YORK

(annoyed)

Will that be all, Captain? Will you be needin' anything else?

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

CAPT. CLARK

Yes, that will be all, York. We're going to take our cigars and brandy in my study.

Just then, Army Officer #1 decides to have some fun. He purposely drops his fork onto the floor, next to his chair.

ARMY OFFICER #1

(to York)

Would you mind getting that for me, boy?

As York bends down to retrieve the fork, the ARMY OFFICER intentionally spills a glass of water on YORK, but feigns innocence.

ARMY OFFICER #1 (cont'd)

Oh...I surely am a clumsy oaf. I'm so sorry, boy.

York, still bending over, looks at him angrily.

ARMY OFFICER #1 (cont'd)

Come on...a little water shouldn't hurt such a stalwart explorer.

York grabs a leg of the Officer's chair and effortlessly tips the man onto the floor. Realizing what he has done, and remembering his station in life, he back-pedals rapidly and apologizes profusely, but to Clark, not the drunken Army officer #1.

YORK

I'm sorry, Captain...I don't know what came over me.

CLARK

Go on and get out of here! I'll see you later, and you can count on that.

Army Officer #1 struggles drunkenly to his feet.

ARMY OFFICER #1

(slurring)

I want that man flogged to within an inch of his life, William! As a matter of fact, I'll rip the back off him myself.

(staggers)

CLARK

(irritated)

I'll decide what punishments are handed out in my own house, sir!

ARMY OFFICER #2

(outraged)

You're drunk, McCarthy. You baited the man, and you got what you deserved. If he was a white man, you'd be facing pistols at dawn.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

DIGNITARY #1

(to Army Officer #1)

I suggest you compose yourself and start acting like the gentleman you purport yourself to be.

DIGNITARY #2

(to Clark)

If you don't mind, William, I am going to take my leave of you. I've had enough excitement for one night.

CLARK

That's probably a good idea. (To OFFICER #2) Lieutenant Jenkins, take McCarthy home and put him to bed.

(to McCarthy)

Unless you'd like to disrupt my household further?

ARMY OFFICER #1

(sulkily and not entirely sincere)

You have my most humble apologies, sir.

(sarcastically)

Tell your negro that I didn't mean to offend his delicate sensibilities.

CLARK

McCarthy, I suggest you be on your way...now! Before you offend my delicate sensibilities.

ARMY OFFICER #2

We're leaving, Captain.

(ushers ARMY OFFICER #1 out of the room)

Good-bye, William.

CUT TO:

INT. MANOR HOUSE-NIGHT-SAME

York is cleaning up the dining room. Clark enters the room, shirt unbuttoned, and dishevelled. His arm dangles at his side, loosely holding a bottle of brandy. He stands silently as he watches YORK put clean dishes into the sideboard. The tension is thick and about to explode. Clark takes a deep drag from the bottle and addresses York.

CLARK

York...you can't go tipping a white man out of his chair. Even if he is acting like a horse's ass.

(getting angry)

What's the matter with you? One of these days I might not be here to bail you out.

YORK

Why did you allow him to treat me so poorly? What did you 'xpect me to do?

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

CLARK
(yelling)
I expect you to know your place and to be a credit to me and this household!

YORK
My place? My place? What exactly is my place, William? Hmm? *Poor old nigga in charge of a bunch of kitchen maids?*

CLARK
(slightly intolerant and frustrated)
Your duties never bothered you before...why now? Lately, all I get from you is sulky insolence about everything.

YORK
Can't you see what has happened?

CLARK
What, that you've become too big for your britches and have been putting on airs? Besides that...tell me what has happened? Solve this damnable mystery for me, please!

YORK
Everything has changed.

CLARK
(indignant)
What has changed? Tell me!
(shouting)
We are still together, you're my servant, and we're still friends! What the devil has changed?

YORK
(shouting back at CLARK)
You've changed! Our friendship has changed! But most of all, ***I have changed!*** You won't free me, but in my heart I'm already gone. Can't you see that, or are you blind? The expedition broke my chains! My mind is free, but my body is still your slave.

CLARK
(frustrated)
Chains, eh? And what is it that I can do to remedy your predicament?

YORK
I want my freedom. It's time for you to keep your promise.

CLARK
What...?

YORK
(imploring)
Free me, William!

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

CLARK
I will do no such thing!

YORK
Why?

CLARK
Why? Don't be ridiculous, man! What will you do? Where would you go? What would you do for money?

YORK
I might not go anywhere, but at least I'd know I was free to come or go as I pleased!

CLARK
Hogwash. You are safe here, well-fed and looked after.

YORK
There's more to living than a full belly and a soft bed...our journey together taught me that.

CLARK
And freeing you will exorcise your demons?
(scoffs)
Hmmm, York?

YORK
(confrontational)
I don't think I'm the one who has the demons...

CLARK
(incredulous)
Why, you ungrateful wretch!

Clark drops his brandy bottle to the floor, removes his belt, and lunges at York, who stands firmly in his place. York turns his body slightly to accept the whipping, but it is done more in defiance than fear.

CLARK (cont'd)
(whipping York)
By God...I...will
teach...you...to...talk...back....to....me.
..you...insolent...black bastard...I will
whip you until you the sun rises...

York suddenly turns, and with tears in his eyes, grabs Clark's hand, stopping the swinging belt in midair. Clark looks shocked and the two begin to brawl in the dining room. York is the bigger man, but Clark makes up for this in ferocity. After a few minutes of savage fighting, they fall to the floor and it breaks the violence between them. Out of breath and both bleeding, they wind up on their stomachs just a few feet from one another, and face-to-face.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (3)

YORK
(out of breath and
exasperated)
Why...? Why won't you free me?

Clark just shakes his head, having no real answer.

CLARK
(perplexed)
You're mine. I won't let you go. I can't
afford to lose you.

YORK
(accusatory)
There isn't enough work here for the slaves
you have! What are you so afraid of,
William? What? Tell me!

CLARK
(breaking down)
I am afraid of the whole world knowing the
truth.

YORK
What truth is that, William?

CLARK
(enraged, but at himself)
I don't want them to know that my best
friend is a...is a...slave!

The word hangs in the air.

CLARK (cont'd)
There, damn you! I said it!

York gets to his feet. His mouth and back are bleeding. York
feels his bloody back and looks at his hand. He shows the fresh
blood to Clark.

YORK
(outraged and incredulous)
Your best friend?
(holding his bloody hand out)
Is this how you treat your best friend? Or
is this how you treat a slave? Can you own
your best friend? You once told me that
when we were older that you'd free
me...well, we're older and *I am still your*
slave! We can't be friends if I am a slave
and you're my master...not any longer. And
as much as you may desire it, William...you
can't erase what happened to me on the
expedition with time, and you definitely
can't erase it with the end of a whip...

York walks toward the door and stops as Clark speaks to him. He
turns and faces CAPT. CLARK.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (4)

CLARK
You want me to do things I'm not capable
of.
(exhausted)
You-ask-the-impossible.

York mockingly stands at attention, and with tears in his eyes
and blood on his mouth addresses Clark:

YORK
(contrived)
*Yessa Massah, suh. Ise be goin'
now...Thankee for da' whippin', boss...I
sho' enough did learn mah place.*

York starts to walk out.

CLARK (cont'd)
York...wait! Come back here!

York stops in the hall but does not turn around.

CLARK (cont'd)
(challenging)
You want your freedom? Then take it, and
all the burdens that go with it! You're
free to go...to hell, for all I care! (Then
under his breath and to himself) Maybe I'll
join you there someday.

Clark crawls across the floor and retrieves the half-spilled
bottle of brandy. Sobbing softly and looking slightly deranged,
he raises the bottle to his cut lips and unceremoniously drains
it.

CUT TO:

EXT. CLARK'S SAINT LOUIS ESTATE-FALL-DAY

SUPERIMPOSE: ONE WEEK LATER

York is hitching a team of 6 large draft horses to a clapboard
wagon while the OTHER SLAVES look on. The CAMERA shows Clark
watching York through a ground-floor window of the house, and
then coming out the back door carrying a worn leather sack full
of food. He makes his way purposely towards York. As he
approaches York, Clark says nothing and lets York finish tending
to the details of the horses. He waits until York notices him
standing there.

YORK
(looking at the wagon)
Well, I'm just about finished here. Horses
look good and the wagon is all greased.

Clark surveys the horses and tugs back and forth on one of the
wooden planks that stretch across the length of the wagon.

CLARK
Yes...it looks fine.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

The two life-long friends and comrades now find themselves in a situation made awkward by uncomfortable small talk and unspoken apologies.

YORK
William, I intend to pay you back for the team and wagon.

CLARK
(gesturing with his hand)
No...no. It's the least I can do. Friends help each other. I just wish I could do more.

YORK
You've done enough already.

CLARK
Yes...I know. I meant something other than my actions last week.

YORK
No, William. That's not what *I meant*. I mean that you've helped me enough as it is. And I appreciate it.

CLARK
I know you do.

CLARK (cont'd)
Where are you going to?

YORK
Well, I guess I'll head towards Nashville or Richmond and maybe start hauling freight with this team and wagon.
(pauses and looks at the ground)
I reckon I'm really not sure. But I'll be fine.

CLARK
I know you will.

YORK
(fighting back tears)
You gonna go back to the Army?

CLARK
I can't say for sure.

YORK
Well, if you ever decide to go on another expedition, call on me.

CLARK
I'm done exploring for now.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

YORK
Yeah...me too. Well, I'd best get going so
I can put some distance between me and
Saint Louie by nightfall.

Clark, teary-eyed now, extends his hand and York does the same.
Both men, with tears in their eyes, give their interlocking
finger handshake, joining their blood-brother scars.

CLARK
Goodbye, my friend.

YORK
Goodbye, William.

York gives a short whistle and a quick snap of the reigns and the
team muscles away. York gets about 100 feet away.

CLARK
(slightly yelling)
York! In the bag is a present I wrapped for
you! Open it on a day when you're homesick!

York looks a little confused, but waves to signal his
acknowledgement of the proposal and gift. York, driving the wagon
and team, rides off on the dusty trail towards the Kentucky
hills and finally disappears.

FADE OUT:

FADE IN:

EXT. NASHVILLE, TN-FALL-1811-DAY

SUPERIMPOSE: NASHVILLE, 1811

We see the hustle of a rapidly growing Southern city. A MONTAGE
shows YORK loading wood, cotton and barrels of oil onto the
wagon, and taking paper invoices to get stamped by shipping
clerks. The MONTAGE also shows YORK unloading his goods in
another Southern town. He looks dedicated and focused. We also
see YORK fixing a broken wheel on a rain-soaked road in a
downpour, covered with grease and mud. He is totally ignored by 5
WHITE TRAVELERS. York looks up for their help, but they pay him
no mind.

OLD YORK (VO)
I started a freight business that ran
between Nashville and Kentucky. It didn't
go as easily as I had expected. All by
myself, the trips were long and cold and I
just couldn't load and unload the freight
as easy as I used to. And white folks
weren't that keen about letting a black man
haul their goods all those miles.

CUT TO:

INT. SMALL BOARDING HOUSE ROOM-1812-NIGHT

York is sitting on his bed in a small, dimly lit room. He counts the few meager coins and some paper money that he has managed to save over the past few months. Frustrated at the final tally, he moves to a small wooden desk and begins writing a letter.

OLD YORK (VO)

After a year or so, I saw that I wasn't making much money, and that to some degree, William was right. The white man's world wasn't ready for a black man to enter it on an equal level. There just wasn't such a thing as a free black man. Not really, anyway. So I decided that maybe it was best to go back and be with William again. Captain Clark was now the Governor of the New Missouri Territory, and he had written to me in a letter that because of his new position, there was much business for me to attend to. So I wrote him to expect me in the Spring.

CUT TO:

EXT. DIRT ROAD-SUMMER-1812-NIGHT

York drives his wagon south. He only has 4 of his original 6 horses left. As he moves down the road, he sees the flicker of flames on the horizon through the trees. As he draws nearer to the source of the flames, he sees that the road is blocked by a line of 4 MEN on horseback. These men are all Caucasian and in their 20s and 30s. Their clothes are somewhat ragged, betraying the fact that they are ruffians. Some of them wear large white bandanas over their noses and mouths. These are not hoods. The men are all armed in some way; some of them have firearms and others have clubs. They are SLAVE CATCHERS. The LEAD SLAVE CATCHER, in his late 30s, rides out to confront York as York brings his wagon to a halt. YORK, on the alert, without taking eyes from the men, slowly conceals a large hunting knife and a short, thick club under his massive legs.

LEAD SLAVE CATCHER

(challenging)

Say there, boy...whaddya think you're doing on our road?

YORK

(cautiously)

They told me in Huntsville that this is the road to Natchez.

LEAD SLAVE CATCHER

That may be true, but what they didn't tell you is that free or slave ain't no blacks allowed on my road.

YORK

I'm sorry sir, I didn't know this was a private road...I don't want no trouble.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

LEAD SLAVE CATCHER
Oh, you in plenty of trouble, boy. You just
set awhile and answer some questions. Let's
start with where did you run away from?

YORK
I didn't...I'm a free man.

LEAD SLAVE CATCHER
(turning back towards his
followers)
Did ya hear that boys? He says he's a free
man!

The Slave Catchers all laugh.

YORK
Really, I am...I've got the papers to
prove it.

York removes a document from his pocket and holds it out to the
Lead Slave Catcher.

LEAD SLAVE CATCHER
(to SLAVE CATCHER #2)
Bob...take a look at this boy's papers.

SLAVE CATCHER #2 rides up to YORK and snatches the paper from
YORK'S hand. The Slave Catcher #2 pretends to read it by the
light of the torch. He purposely holds the paper too close to the
flame, incinerating it.

SLAVE CATCHER #2
(mocking)
Oh...I'm sorry. Look what I went and done.
Momma always said I was the clumsy one.

LEAD SLAVE CATCHER
Well now, this is a real pickle. What we
gonna do? Seems to me we got ourselves a
runaway with no papers.
(pauses; thinking)
I'll tell you what, boy...you got two
options. You can come with us, nice and
peaceful like, and we'll find you a nice
new master down in Mississippi; someone who
will pay top dollar for a boy your size, no
questions asked. Or, we can string you up
from the nearest tree. What's it gonna be?

CUT TO:

FLASHBACK

1804-CROW CAMP-NIGHT

The CAMERA shows York taking part in the Crow Warrior Dance; his
face is half-painted red and he wears the bearskin draped over
his head and body.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

He pantomimes killing enemies while the reflection of the fire burns brightly in his eyes. This vision only lasts a few seconds.

CUT TO:

PRESENT DAY

YORK
(stone-faced and resolute)
I'm not going with you.

The Slave Catchers begin to hoot and holler.

LEAD SLAVE CATCHER
Well, you got some spirit. I like
that...but it's gonna cost you your life.

The Lead Slave Catcher rides up and grabs the bridle of one of YORK'S front horses, preventing his escape. 2 of the Slave Catchers dismount and jump onto the wagon, one on either side of York. One holds a flintlock pistol and the other a club. With a savage war cry, York, swinging his concealed club, knocks the pistol out of one Slave Catcher's hand and smashes the other SLAVE CATCHER in the face on his back swing. At this time, the Lead Slave Catcher's Horse becomes excited and begins to buck and rear. The Lead Slave Catcher desperately tries to regain control of his mount. YORK then picks up the fallen pistol and fires it at the Lead Slave Catcher's head. The ball strikes the Lead Slave Catcher in the forehead, killing him. He falls, and his lifeless body is trampled by his horse. The remaining Slave Catcher #2 with the injured hand gets back up on the wagon and begins to menace York with his torch. YORK grabs the wrist of the hand that holds the torch and pulls the Slave Catcher #2 viciously towards him, impaling him on his hunting knife. York quickly checks the other side of the wagon and confirms that the other Slave Catcher #2 is dead or out cold. Momentarily forgetting the SLAVE CATCHER #3, York prepares to turn his horses and flee north. He then notices the SLAVE CATCHER #4, a boy, 18, who is still seated on his horse, viewing the carnage with revulsion and horror.

YORK
(menacing and spattered with
blood)
Well, don't just sit there looking stupid,
boy. You going to fight or run?

The Slave Catcher #4 lets out a whimper, turns his horse south, and rides off into the darkness. York turns his wagon around and whipping his horses into a gallop, heads north.

OLD YORK (VO)
I knew that I couldn't go to Mississippi. I
decided to go back to Nashville where I had
friends who would help me if need be. That
night I realized that I would never see
Sarah again.

CUT TO:

EXT. NASHVILLE-FALL-1812-DAY

SUPERIMPOSE: SOMEWHERE ON THE NATCHEZ TRAIL

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

York loads his wagon and hitches his horses in the Nashville mercantile district; he climbs aboard his wagon and rides out of town.

OLD YORK (VO)

I had made it about fifty miles out of Nashville when I was caught with a sickness they believed to be cholera. I remained in a boarding house for Negroes until I could rid myself of this terrible disease.

CUT TO:

INT. BOARDING ROOM-SAME-NIGHT

York is desperately sick and vomiting into a bucket by the side of his bed. As a faceless BLACK WOMAN helps him to lay his head back down on the pillow, York stares into the crackling fire beside his bed. In the corner of the room, he sees his three bags and the leather sack that William gave him a year ago. He motions to the woman to retrieve his sack and after she brings it to him, he rustles through it to find the badly worn, brown-paper-wrapped present. It is somewhat small and square, about the size of a regular school book. The CAMERA shows YORK'S face as he opens the present, but we do not see the actual gift, only the paper being unwrapped. A CLOSER CAMERA shot of York's face shows that YORK has tears welling-up in his eyes and his face now displays an endearing smile. After YORK stares at the present, he calmly places the object on his lap, and we still only see his face. YORK then closes his eyes and turns his head slowly away from the camera. The CAMERA slowly pulls back and we finally see the distressed and worn book of his and William's youth, The Arabian Nights, lying on his lap atop the crinkled brown paper.

CLARK (VO)

I could never ascertain for certain where, when or even how York died. For all I know...he is still alive.

(pauses)

I have thought about this great man for many years...about our boyhood friendship, and our lives together, as men and explorers. Knowing York, I'd like to think that he made good on the promise he made to those Indians. Maybe my friend went back to the only place where he truly felt free.

CUT TO:

EXT. WATERFALL RIVERSIDE-DATE UNKNOWN-DAYTIME

York and an INDIAN WIFE are standing by the riverside with their 2 CHILDREN and 1 INFANT watching the Great Falls. They are dressed in Native American attire. They smile and laugh and convey a general feeling of happiness and well-being. An EAGLE soars overhead, a metaphor for freedom. SCENE is viewed through a gold-filtered lens to indicate that this is speculation or fantasy.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

CLARK (VO)
 I can almost see him in my mind, standing
 by that waterfall he loved so much.
 (beat)
 There may never be a monument or statue
 dedicated to York, but he is a hero just
 the same...and most importantly, I am proud
 to say he was my best friend. I will miss
 him dearly until the day I die.
 (beat)
 Sadly, I lost another friend too.

CUT TO:

INT. HOTEL ROOM-1809

Merriweather Lewis , distraught, sits on the edge of his bed and
 simultaneously shoots himself in the heart, and then in the head.
 He drops dead.

CLARK (VO)
 In 1809, Captain Merriweather Lewis, broke
 in debt and severely depressed, took his
 own life.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. CAMP FIRE-CROW VILLAGE-UNKNOWN DATE

OLD YORK, dressed as a Crow Chief, sits beside a campfire with
 his Indian Wife. He is speaking to a young white FUR TRAPPER, who
 has wandered into the Indian camp. The Fur Trapper is silent and
 in total awe of Old York's epic tale.

OLD YORK
 Well, now you know my story. Sometimes I
 can't believe I lived it. But here I am.
 (chuckles)

The Fur Trapper continues to stare at YORK in stunned silence.

OLD YORK
 Hey..are you alright?

The Fur Trapper regains himself.

FUR TRAPPER
 It's funny...back east your black skin was
 a curse...out here it's a blessing.

OLD YORK
 (mixed emotions)
 Yeah...

A long reflective moment permeates the conversation.

FUR TRAPPER
 But why...why come back here?

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

OLD YORK
(reflective)
Because I belong here.

Fur Trapper shakes his head in amazement.

OLD YORK (cont'd)
I think a man looks his whole life to find
a place that he can call his home. A place
that is like no other in the world.
Understand? 'Sides, I had to come
back..this is the only place I was ever
free.

One of YORK'S CROW INDIAN WIVES (the Crow Indian Girl from the
journey, but older now) whispers something to Old York in the
Crow language. Old York nods his head.

OLD YORK (cont'd)
(apologetically and smiling)
She says it's time for me to go to bed.
(rising from a sitting
position)
She says that staying up all night, talking
around a fire, is for young men like you.
Truth is, she can't get her feet warm
unless I'm under the buffalo robe with her.

Old York laughs again and shrugs his shoulders. He and his wife
are about to leave the tent.

FUR TRAPPER
Sir, when I get back east, do you want me
to tell them where you are?

YORK
Nobody to tell. The only one who'd care was
my old friend George, but I hear he was
killed by the Blackfeet several years ago.
And Captain Clark,
(beat)
Well, I suppose we're both free now.

FUR TRAPPER
One last thing. I...I don't remember your
full name.

OLD YORK
My name? My name is...

Old York pauses and looks lovingly at his CROW WIFE.

OLD YORK (cont'd)
(proudly)
My name is *Talking Bear*. It is *Daxpitch'e*
Ili'ish in the language of my Crow family.
It is *Modao dorre'* in the words of the
Mandan Nation. To the Shoshone people, I
was *Taiqwapuinte Aawaq*.
(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

OLD YORK (cont'd)
No matter how you say it, it is always
Talking Bear, a name that I earned...a name
that is respected. It is who I am now.

Old York and his CROW FAMILY leave the fire. The Young Fur
Trapper looks reflectively into the fire.

FADE TO BLACK.

SUPERIMPOSE: It is recorded history that on November of 1832, a
young fur trapper named Zenas Leonard met a black man living
with the Crow Indians in what is now the State of Wyoming. This
black man informed Leonard that he had originally come to this
country with Lewis and Clark and had returned back to the Indian
village twelve years earlier. The large black man spoke the Crow
language fluently, had four wives, and enjoyed all of the
privileges that came with being a Chief.

FADE TO:

DOCUMENTARY FOOTAGE-WHITEHOUSE CEREMONY WHERE PRESIDENT
WILLIAM CLINTON PROMOTES YORK TO FULL SERGEANT **NOTE:**
CLINTON'S STATEMENT ON YORK'S VITAL IMPORTANCE TO THE
OVERALL SUCCESS OF THE MISSION.

DIRECTORS V/O
York never received any medals or
compensation from the United States
Government for his unending bravery and
unconditional sacrifices with the Corps of
Discovery. He was however the first African-
American man to ever vote in any official
capacity in the United States. He was the
first African-American explorer, he was the
first African-American to cross the great
plains, the continental divide and reach
the Pacific Ocean by land.

CUT TO:

DIRECTORS V/O
On January 21, 2000, in one of his last
acts in office, President William Jefferson
Clinton posthumously promoted the slave
named York to full Sergeant, in the United
States regular Army.

FADE TO:

SUPERIMPOSE: THE END

The CAMERA ends on a bronze STATUE of York...showing that he is
immortalized forever.

FADE TO BLACK.